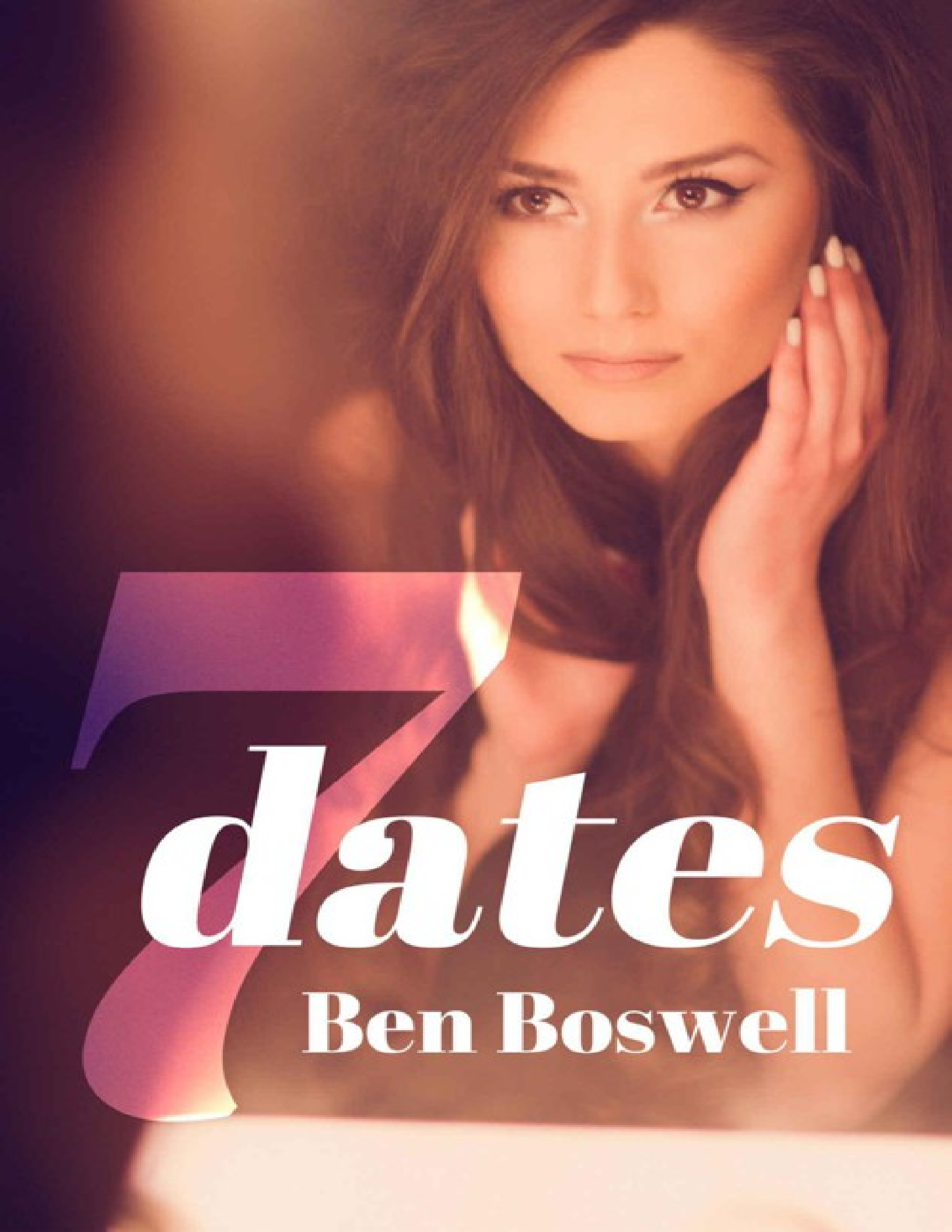




dates

Ben Boswell

Seven Dates

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dates

Ben Boswell

FOREWORD

Okay, I have to admit. I struggled with this one. I'm still not one hundred percent sure I got it right. I fell in love with the concept, and then got caught up in a couple of really hot scenes, but when I read over my first draft, it was clear I'd taken a wrong turn somewhere.

Part of my concern was that, especially, in the early drafts, none of the characters were likeable. The protagonists are still, even after a lot of work, deeply, deeply flawed people. I know that will rub some readers the wrong way.

Then, also, the plot is dark. It is full of deceit, manipulation, revenge, and deliberately hurtful behavior. It is about as far removed as possible in tone from my last book, *Dark Tide*.

I doubt this will be anyone's favorite book. It isn't mine, frankly. But that said, I don't regret it.

It would be easy to write the same book over and over. People loved *Dark Tide*. I could rewrite it to be on an African Safari next. Or a basketball camp. Or set on a college campus. Same characters, same plot, just new names and a new setting. I know that it would sell well. But it would be boring.

Seven Dates is, at least, a little original. I hope readers will give me credit for that. I hope that when readers read my stuff, they find what they expect, but they also find some surprises, some challenges. I don't want to write the same book over and over, and I hope you don't want to read the same book again and again.

I want to thank, as usual, Kenny Wright for his support, comments, and design help. Max Sebastian also provided some helpful comments on

the story. And thanks to reader RP for editing out some of the typos.

INTRODUCTION

Of course I was going to hit on Joanie. At the time I was hitting on basically any and every girl I came across. True, she wasn't really my type. I was more into trashy girls. Girls who wouldn't require much work. Bleached blondes with the roots showing and visible bra straps. Some Jaegerbombs, a little drunken grinding, and then back to my place for a fuck... if we got that far. Bar bathrooms, park benches, the back seats of taxis, I wasn't picky.

Joanie, I could tell, was going to require more effort. She was pretty, very, very pretty, though so conservatively dressed that I couldn't be completely sure her body was as hot as the brief hints allowed by her clothes suggested. With the face of cover girl, I had her pegged for Spanish, but actually she was French on her mother's side, Irish on her dad's, Catholic on both.

She was nineteen, a rising junior at Columbia, interning in my firm. They had her doing some miserable, pointless research. That's the problem with free labor, there is no incentive to use it productively. But the kids don't know that. Or maybe they don't care. It's a line on the resume regardless.

I perched up on her desk and tried to get a peek down her blouse. Damn, were those things really as big as they looked? I forced myself to meet her big, brown eyes, her pupils haloed in black.

"Good morning Joanie."

"Good morning, Mr. Graham. How can I help you?"

"You can call me Kellen to start."

She blushed a little, but didn't take the bait. She just looked at me. *Get on with it*, she seemed to be saying.

I cleared my throat. "Well, um, I guess we're supposed to get to know the interns. You know, mentor them. That sort of thing."

"Mentor, eh?"

"You seem skeptical."

"I'm been warned about you, Mr. Graham. You have quite the reputation."

"Oh? What do people say about me?"

"That you're a cad."

"Did we teleport back into the 1960s?"

"A playa?" she proposed with a sassy head waggle.

"1990s. But getting closer."

She smiled.

"I'm trying to reform," I added.

She wasn't buying. "Don't you think I'm a little young for you? I can't even drink legally."

"That's okay, I'm trying to cut back anyway."

She laughed. "So you're a cad *and* an alcoholic. It gets better and better. "

It occurred to me that I needed a whole different game. Somehow, I didn't think that she'd be impressed by the vial of coke in my pocket, the size of my paycheck, or my willingness to try just about anything, at least once, in bed.

"I'd love to buy you lunch and just talk."

"What are we going to talk about?"

"You. Because, for the life of me, I can't figure out what you're doing working here."

She looked scandalized.

“You’re a nice girl. And this is not a business for nice.”

“You don’t think I’m tough enough.”

“I think you’re not enough of an asshole.”

She seemed interested by that.

“How do you know that?”

“Because I’m one, and I can see it in others. It’s like gaydar, but for jerks.”

“A cad, an alcoholic, and a self-professed asshole. How can I refuse?”

“You can’t.”

She didn’t.

I was on my best behavior. It wasn’t just that I wanted to get into her pants. She didn’t often wear pants for one thing, a skirts and dresses-kind-of-girl all the way. But more than that, I was looking for a change.

The coke was a bad sign. I’d only just begun using, but I could feel its seductive power. Like the cheap and easy sex I was used to, it was leading me down a path I didn’t like. I’d always been focused and ambitious. The partying was a distraction. Joanie symbolized, for me, an escape from that life. A prize whose attainment would reward the discipline it would take to achieve.

In retrospect that seems like an awfully cold rationale. A very transactional way to view a relationship. But that’s always been the way I’ve been wired. Analytical, detached.

Joanie also had a very practical side to her. That’s why she was interning in finance, when really she wanted to be a writer.

“So write,” I said for maybe the tenth time.

We were on our third date. I was counting lunch in my mind as the first. So I was sort of hoping I'd score. Even nice girls give it up on the third date, right? I might have been looking to move beyond easy chicks, but that didn't mean I was any less horny.

She rolled her eyes at me. It was a relationship stage I'd never experienced before. She knew me well enough to call me on bullshit, yet we didn't have that existential comfort level that you only get after having sex with someone. There was still that spark, that tension. Not that I wouldn't have traded that in a heartbeat to get my hands on what I was now pretty sure were her world-class hooters, but this was still pretty neat.

"You mean wait tables," she replied.

"No, that's wannabe actresses. Wannabe writers work, I think, as editorial assistants."

"And hope to be *discovered* by a successful male author."

"There are worse things in the world than being James Patterson's concubine."

"Speaking from experience?"

"No. That is the one thing I haven't tried."

"The one thing?"

I wasn't going to ruin a good flirtation by getting into details, though I was pleased by this apparent interest in my sex life, oblique and jokey as it was.

"Seriously, though, you're too young not to follow your passions."

"I don't know, Kellen. Newspapers, magazines, they're all dying. I want my work to be consequential. I'm not saying I'm a great artist. I'm not going to write the great American novel. But I want to make people think and feel. I want to provoke a reaction, not just scribble away on vanity

projects. I don't want to wake up in ten years and think I've wasted my time."

"No, Joanie, what you don't want is to wake up in ten years and be selling derivatives if you hate it."

"But that's what you want to do. Or is it just the money?"

I shook my head. "No, I know this is going to sound weird. But I don't care about the money. I like the... juice."

"Huh?"

"It's hard to explain. Sometimes I say I like the strategy of it. You know, two people go into a room, they each want something from the other, but the excitement comes from getting the better of it. If I wasn't a trader, maybe I'd be a lawyer. But a lawyer, unless you're doing criminal, gets what, a couple of trials a year? I make deals every day."

She looked at me thoughtfully. "So is that what I am? A negotiation? A counter-party you're trying to get the better of?"

It took me aback.

"I don't know. Aren't all relationships negotiations of some sort?"

"Maybe. But that doesn't mean we need to get the better of each other."

I thought about that. The answer came to me.

"Okay, but that's because a relationship is positive sum. We can each get out more than we put in."

She laughed. "You're maybe the least romantic man in the world, you know that?"

I raised my glass of sparkling water. "I do always strive to be exceptional."

She made me meet her parents before we had sex. She stopped short of demanding a ring, though I suspect she considered it.

It went well. I was on my best behavior, and as much as I hate to admit it, I do have a salesman's oily charm when I want to. It was like an acting exercise. Could I sell myself at the sort of man a conservative, Catholic mom and dad might want as a son-in-law? We weren't talking marriage. We hadn't even banged. But I instinctively got the message.

Is it weird to admit that the man I pretended to be – family oriented, desirous of finding and caring for a good woman, sane and sober – is the man I wanted to be as well? Joanie, by then, knew that this was more aspiration than reality, and yet, I think she was happy to buy into it. Maybe she saw my potential. Maybe she trusted that her parents' seal of approval meant something. Maybe she was just looking for a meal ticket. We never had the conversation we needed to have about it.

We drove back into the city from Westchester in the car I'd rented for the occasion. I got off the West Side highway to drop her at her student apartment in Morningside Heights.

"So, you're not interested in me anymore?" she asked.

"Huh? Why?"

"You haven't invited me to your place in weeks."

It isn't that I wasn't interested as much as I had sort of given up. Rare for me. But after three months I didn't think she'd ever consent to a night at my place, and the implicit promise of sex that would imply.

"Want to come over?" I asked.

She smiled. "Yes."

She was so awkward and self-conscious that I actually asked her if she was a virgin. I didn't know if I wanted to pop her cherry. She wouldn't have been my first virgin, but certainly she'd have the first for whom it was a concern. She seems like a girl who might make it to her wedding day otherwise.

"No," she answered quietly.

I wasn't sure I believed her, but as we became more intimate I lost my ability to worry about it. Naked, she was even more stunning than I could have imagined. Her breasts achieved a sort of Platonic ideal. Better than that, actually, given the Greek tendency to see modest breasts as the apotheosis of the female form, just as they also considered big pricks as ugly and deformed. I was lost in her tits, huge, firm, with silver dollar-sized, pale pink areolas and amazing nipples that swelled to sensitive, ripe grapes. Dozens of women before had done little to prepare me for that moment when her bra came off. I was blown away. I just wanted to worship her breasts.

But the rest of her body demanded similar attention. The flat of her stomach, the swell of her hips. A hard, perfect, bubble butt. She wasn't shaved, or even trimmed, but her pussy was tight and juicy and so fucking hot. I was a kid in a candy shop, barely able to focus on one treat before discovering the next.

She let me take the lead. I went slow, really slow. An hour just kissing and caressing each other. She was so tentative and sweet with my cock, almost as if she were worried she might hurt me. It was surprisingly erotic.

"I want to make love to you," I said finally.

She didn't answer. Not with words. She just swallowed and nodded. I slipped on a condom.

I climbed between her legs and slowly rubbed my cock up and down her wet slit. She moaned softly. Her hands went to my hips. She was anxious and yet eager. Again I wondered if she were a virgin, but now I was too far along for it to make a difference.

I pressed into her, slowly, gently, but she was more than ready, her pussy drenched and inviting. I thrust in deeper, deeper. She moaned louder. I paused and we kissed again, several long minutes as I caressed her cheek and nibbled on her lips, her chin, her nose.

When I resumed, it was harder now, but she was ready for me. Each thrust eliciting a delicious, contented mewl. She surprised me with her orgasm. I wasn't sure she was comfortable enough with me to let go like that, but she did. Soft sighs, her body suddenly flush with heat, a small, contented smile on her face. I followed soon after.

Our lovemaking progressed, though always through small increments. She learned to give head, although that was never her favorite, and we began having sex more often with her on top. I never thought that would get old. Looking up at her beautiful face, watching her big breasts swaying gently as she rode me, cupping and squeezing her hard ass. I never thought it would get old. But it did.

CHAPTER ONE

My day from hell began with a homeless man stumbling into me as I walked into my office, leaving some sort of smelly slime coating the sleeve of my suit jacket. Even after scrubbing it in the sink, there remained a greenish-white stain that smelled vaguely of vomit.

Then I got an email from Brent asking a question about clause II.C.8 in the TKD contract I'd just negotiated and signed. The lawyers had signed off on it, but they were just looking at it from a legal perspective, not a business one. And sure enough, when I examined it, I realized the language was left over from a previous, much less advantageous draft. A stupid fucking mistake and those TKD assholes hadn't mentioned it, even though they knew we'd agreed on new language about third-party allocations.

I ran the spreadsheet. A \$2.9 million mistake if I couldn't get it fixed, and it wasn't clear I could. Sure, TKD should just sign off on an amendment, but then again, would *my* bosses sign off on just giving away a \$2.9 million windfall? No. They'd take it as a Christmas bonus and buy themselves new fucking cars.

I crunched through lunch to try to find a solution, but all the roads led back through TKD.

I reluctantly called Tanner Alden, the exec who'd done most the negotiations on their side. Tanner is an asshole. Tall but a little pudgy, blond hair, blue eyes, prep school, frat boy, arrogant, with a face you have to restrain yourself to avoid smacking. I hate to admit it, but we look a little alike, except I have dark hair and eyes, but the cleft in my chin seems to provoke a similar reaction.

“Hey, buddy,” I began. “I found a drafting error in the contract. Was hoping I could just courier over an amendment.”

“Hey, pal,” he replied. “What error?”

“Oh, just this one paragraph. You know, an older version slipped in. Some sort of track changes error. No big deal. Sending you an email version of it right now.”

“I don’t know. We reviewed it pretty closely. Language all looked good from our end.”

Yeah, I bet.

“Hmm, let me see,” he continued as he reviewed my email. “No, this is the right language. Third-party allocations, right?”

“Yeah, but remember... the deal was, twenty percent there instead of forty, in return for moving the buy-out option up to twenty-four months.”

“Buy-out option is already set at twenty-four months.”

“That’s the point. You got what you wanted –“

“Sorry, man, I think your notes are messed up. Language is right as far as I can tell.”

I managed to keep my cool.

“Fine. I’ll be in touch.”

“You do that. Nice doing business with you.”

Asshole. And typical for TKD.

Tedder, Kleinhof, and Dean. A vulture capital firm. Not venture. These guys never invested in up-and-comers. They scrounged bankruptcies for undervalued assets and sold them for scrap. We’d done a lot of deals with them over the years. Had to. As a new management team taking over a broken and demoralized organization they needed to find value through relationships, and that’s what *we* did.

I worked for Marston. *Marston Makes Markets*. I think we had a Super Bowl ad one year. I've never quite understood who the ads were aimed at. We only worked enterprise to enterprise. I always got the sense that our ad buys during pro sports was more about discounted luxury boxes rather than in the hopes that some beleaguered CEO might decide they needed our services.

Still, Marston was my dream job. We didn't make anything, we didn't sell anything. We did deals. We connected buyers and sellers, investors and opportunities, wholesalers and retailers. And we took a piece of the pie. I loved it. The strategy, the negotiation. Figuring out what people want and how much they're willing to pay. Squeeze, grind them, and take the leavings. A constant game. And I was good at it. No way would I have agreed to such a stupid deal.

I imagined the TKD execs picking out their new Porsches right now. It was about then that I slammed my phone down and cracked the handset, which meant a call to IT, followed by a chewing out by the office manager who informed me that the cost for a new phone would be deducted from my next paycheck.

I was just about to eat a long-delayed snack, a stale sandwich from the vending machine when I got called into Donald's office. Donald is a small man, with a big ego. He speaks in a weird patois of management theory and profanity that would make a longshoreman blush.

Donald has been spewing some b-school bullshit recently about rewarding risk takers by not punishing failure. Apparently, this didn't count as a failure, or something, because he spent the next two hours tearing me a new asshole, at which point he dismissed me by curtly informing me that he would be "reviewing the situation."

I knew I wasn't likely to get fired. Not right away at least. But I knew I could kiss goodbye the possibility of a promotion or a raise for the foreseeable future, which meant, of course that I'd have to put off Joanie for another year on her plans to have kids. *That* would surely be a fun conversation.

I texted her that I was coming home.

[Kellen]: ugh, long, long day today.

[Joanie]: Aww, sorry babe, see you soon. Pick up milk on the way home?

Why couldn't she have picked up the milk? What the fuck was she doing all day? I metaphorically slapped myself on the wrist for even *having* that dangerous thought. It was my fault she was unemployed, as she often reminded me. We'd moved to Boston for my career, after all. The fact that her prior "job" was a "fellowship" that barely covered commuting was, apparently, beside the point. Fuck it. An unproductive line of thought. I'd pick up the milk.

I stewed through the long metro ride home. By the time I got a seat, it was almost time to get off. *Get off*. Ha. When was the last time I got off, really got off, gotten fucked to exhaustion until every last drop of jism was drained from my hot, sweaty balls?

No, Joanie and I *made love*. Always. Under the covers usually. Me on top or her. Lots of kissing, caresses, and cuddles, and the novelty had worn off. Great tits or not. It was *nice*. But I wasn't in the mood for *nice*.

I thought about the last time I'd had a day quite as miserable. Nearly ten years ago. Before I'd married Joanie, or even met her. I was still with Stacy then, applying to graduate business schools. I'd shot too high I guess, and got denied by all of the schools I applied to, which meant I'd have to

spend at least another year at a job I hated before I could reapply to a new batch of schools.

I'd texted Stacy the news. *She* didn't ask me to bring milk home.

She met me at the door of our apartment with a beer. She sat me in a ratty old armchair that we'd rescued from the curb, dropped to her knees, and she blew me, wet and sloppy, taking me balls-deep even when it made her gag. When I came, she stroked my shaft and swallowed every drop.

And then she kept working on me, sucking my balls, bathing my prick with her tongue, until I was hard again. She stripped naked and climbed into my lap and fucked me like an animal, the whole time gasping and whispering in my ear about how amazing I was, how much she loved my big cock, how I could do *anything* I wanted to her. I came a second time and she climbed off and brought me a second beer. She ordered pizza, kept me well lubricated with beers, and then took me to bed where we fucked until I passed out.

Now, don't get me wrong. I love Joanie. She's kind and sweet. She's funny and wicked smart... and gorgeous. Dress her up in a sun dress and she's that heart-breakingly beautiful Latin princess you once saw drinking an espresso in a Barcelona cafe. Put her in lace bra and panties and she's a lingerie model. She has a look that invites you to cast in your favorite fantasy – slutty cheerleader, over-sexed school teacher, trampy nurse....

But it's an illusion. Joanie is a girl who could be a catalogue model – at 5'6" she's not tall enough for the runway anyway – but who would never consider it. Literally never consider it because it's not a matter of Joanie being unwilling to trade upon her sex appeal, it is more it would never occur to her. Which, in a weird way, was another thing that appealed to me. My last few girlfriends before her had been overtly sexual, but frankly crazy. I didn't miss Stacy. Not really. There was always drama between her

and her girlfriends. She was twenty-four and getting love handles and she farted in bed. She was a complete slob and had the disconcerting habit of getting wasted and then crashing over at some dude's house. *Nothing happened, baby. You know I love you.*

Though Joanie, when I met her, was a nineteen year old, innocent little Catholic girl, she was the first grown-up I'd dated and the first girl I could in good conscience bring home to mother. We bonded over discussions about the future, the stuff each of us wanted to do with our lives. That's really how people fall in love, isn't it? Sharing dreams and desires about what life will bring. I urged her to pursue her ambitions because I knew it would make her happy, but also because I knew I would always be there to support her.

I fell in love with Joanie in part because she was so different from Stacy. But right now, what I wanted, what I needed was for Joanie to channel Stacy for just one day.... Fuck it, one hour.

CHAPTER TWO

I walked in the front door of our townhouse. Joanie didn't greet me at the door. No beer.

She called to me from the dining room, "Did you remember the milk?"

Fuck. "Sorry honey, I forgot, it's been a hard –"

She sighed loudly. "You walked right past the store."

Did you even fucking leave the house today? She was sitting at the table, papers spread out everywhere, wearing sweats, her hair in a stringy ponytail. So much for my backup hope of a nice meal and a bottle of wine.

"I guess I can go back out...."

She looked up at me. "It's okay. We'll do without."

Passive-aggressive bitch.

"What did you say?" she snapped.

Had I said that out loud or had she just read my thoughts?

"Huh? Nothing. How was *your* day?" *Could you at least ask me about mine?*

"I'm crunching on a deadline."

"Deadline?"

"I'm pitching a magazine story to *Harpers*."

So, a self-imposed deadline for a proposal that will likely come to nothing. Got it.

"Oh...." I was literally speechless. "So, um, what's for dinner?"

"I just need to finish up here, would you mind ordering pizza?"

Well, at least I'd get the pizza.... No blowjob, no beer, no getting fucked senseless, but I would get the pizza... as long as I ordered it myself.

"I guess I don't have much choice," I snarked.

“I’m working on something.”

I snorted.

“Oh, I know Kellen, it isn’t anything as important as what you do.”

I snapped. “At least my job pays, you know, actual money.”

“I had a job.”

“You had a glorified internship.”

Her eyes flashed with anger.

I backed down, “I’m sorry. I just had a really bad day, and I could use a little affection.”

She nodded. “We’re both under pressure.”

She rose. She kissed my cheek and rubbed my shoulder. “I’ll call the pizza, okay?”

“Um, okay,” I replied blankly.

“What?”

“Oh, forget the pizza. I don’t care about the pizza. I had a fucking terrible day.”

“What happened?”

Finally. I explained about the botched contract language.

She groaned. “I always tell you how important it is to proofread everything.”

“Yes, you do.” *You fucking bitch.*

“Well, maybe if you check the revision history of the document, you can find a version with the right language –“

“Joanie, I know how to do my job,” I interrupted coldly.

Well apparently not, her expression suggested. “I was just trying to be helpful.”

“You could be more helpful by acting like a supportive wife.”

“What’s that mean?”

“You know what it means.”

“No, I really don’t. What would you expect from a supportive wife?”

I sighed. “Never mind.”

“No, tell me, I want to know. What were you expecting?”

“Expecting?” I chuckled. “Nothing I guess. Hoping for...?”

“What?”

“Joanie, just forget about it. If you understood men a little better –“

“Men, huh? So what’s that mean?”

“Seriously, Joanie, let’s just drop this.”

“No, Kellen, let’s not. I want to hear what you, what *men*, are expecting.”

“No you don’t.” I could feel my heart pounding. I should have controlled myself, but it just spilled out. “Okay, fine, you know what? Fine. I had a fucking miserable day and you know what would make it better? Getting my cock sucked.”

She shook her head. “That would fix things? That would get the \$2.9 million back?”

“Like I say, you don’t understand men. I’m the only –“

“I had boyfriends before you.”

“One, Joanie. One. And he was a high school kid and...”

“And what?”

“Um, Joanie, you know Bradley was gay right?”

“He and I had sex!”

“Like twice. If you’d been my high school girlfriend, I’d have been banging you three times a day. Any man would have.”

She shook her head. “So the reason I didn’t give you what you expected was my lack of experience? If I’d dated more men –“

“It wouldn’t have hurt.”

“I was nineteen when we met, how many men should I have been with before you?”

“You’re missing the point. I’m just saying...”

What was I saying? Who the fuck knew? At this point, I didn’t even want a blowjob anymore. Or a pizza. I wanted to pound a beer or two, take a hot shower, and climb into bed.

“What?” she insisted.

“I’m just saying that being with a few women before you was, I think, useful.”

“A few?” she gasped.

Okay, so it was closer to fifty, though I’d only copped to twenty when we talked about it.

“A little experience is a good thing.”

“Oh, of course, Mr. Perfect. So what’s the ideal number? How many men should I have had sex with before I met you.”

“You’re missing the point.”

“I want a number.”

“Fuck Joanie, how the hell do I know? Two? Four? Eight?”

“And you think if only I’d been with eight men before you instead of one —“

I cut her off with a laugh. “Like I say, Brad only counts as a half, maybe a quarter —“

Her eyes flashed dangerously, “I would have known enough to get on my knees and give you oral when you got home.”

“Something like that.”

She fumed. “You know what, Kel? You’re an immature prick sometimes. Just because you dated sluts —“

“Don’t say that!”

“What? Most of them were. Stacy?”

“What about her?”

“Oh God, Kel, I still can’t believe you invited her to our wedding. She’d screwed half of your groomsmen.”

All of them actually.

“Big deal. She was a friend.”

“Yeah, big deal. My wedding and I have to walk in on the group of you talking about what a good lay she was, and she’s there laughing along.”

“You could learn a few things from Stacy,” I retorted, thinking of her being easy going and fun.

“Like what? Like how to swallow? How to get screwed in a bar bathroom?”

“What’s wrong with swallowing once in a while?”

She screwed up her face. “So that’s it? You’re upset because I’m not enough of a whore? I don’t live up to your sluts? You want me to be more like the girls you see in that disgusting porn you watch?”

I was startled.

“Oh, what, Kel, you don’t I know what you’re up to when you get up in the middle of the night and lock yourself with your iPad in the bathroom?”

“You’re sick, Joanie. Get that stick out of your ass.”

“No, you’re the sick one, Kellen. You’d probably like to see me with a stick in my ass.”

“Joanie, seriously, fuck you. There is nothing wrong with learning how to please a man, even if it means swallowing a little come or trying, just trying, anal.”

“I guess I just need more experience.”

“Yeah, you know what? You do.”

“Maybe I should date other men then, you know to learn what they like.”

I snorted. So fucking transparent. “Whatever, Joanie. I had a shitty day. I’m going to bed. Do whatever the fuck you want.”

“Where are you going?” she shrieked as I turned and walked away.

But I wasn’t interested in fighting anymore... or eating... or drinking... or fucking. I walked into the bedroom, threw my clothes into a pile in the corner of the room, and buried myself under the covers.

CHAPTER THREE

I woke up the next morning alone in bed. Joanie hadn't slept on her side. I groaned. I had been hoping she'd have calmed down after I went to sleep, but apparently she didn't.

I showered, shaved and dressed. I needed to get back into the office and work the TKD issue.

I found Joanie in the kitchen. She was writing on a yellow legal pad. She didn't look up even though I could tell from her body language that she'd heard me enter. I sat down opposite her. I cleared my throat. No response.

"Joanie, I'm really sorry about last night. I'd had a bad day. I didn't mean to hurt you."

She hesitated and then finally looked up. "No, Kel, it's okay. It was quite informative. I'm glad you explained what I need to do to please you."

I rolled my eyes. I had apologized and she seemed to want to start up again. I had neither the time nor patience for it.

"Great," I said ignoring her obvious sarcasm. "So now that we're all in agreement, I need to get to work."

I rose, yet I hesitated. We'd gone to bed angry and had woken up the same way. And now I was going to work that way. But I just couldn't find the energy to deal with Joanie right now. Maybe with a little more time she'd cool down. I leaned down to give her a kiss, but she didn't even give me her cheek. I kissed the top of her head instead.

One thing I always knew about Joanie was that she had a strong sense of morality, of right and wrong. A legacy of her Catholic upbringing. She put things into boxes. Sin or not sin. There were few shades of grey. It's not

something I ever really understood. My reaction was to fudge it. What she didn't know wouldn't hurt her. Except it did. My fear of crossing her lines led me to withhold. It was a slow process, but I locked her out. I realize that now. The series of lies and half-truths that I'd told about my career, our finances, my dreams about the future, all of them, in one sense an attempt to protect her from anxiety, they built a wall between us that allowed tension to build up. We hadn't had a big fight in years... maybe not ever, actually. But now it looked like it was all coming to a head at once. Bad timing.

I spent the morning with the lawyers. I hate fucking lawyers. It didn't occur to me until halfway through the meeting that they weren't necessarily on *my* side, but once it did, I realized that I'd probably spent the past two hours tying a noose around my own neck. Oh sure, they wanted to fix the contract, but their backup plan was clearly to pin all the blame on me for the fuckup. Which was fair, I guess. It *was* my fuckup, but as long as I was a willing sacrificial lamb they didn't have much motivation to help me fix things. No skin in the game.

After I realized the lay of the land, I was more cautious in my disclosures, more close to the vest. Truth is, I might need to throw those fuckers under the bus at some point, so I needed to keep some things to myself. That's a dirty little secret of the business world. Most of your "teammates" are just waiting for an opportunity to put a knife in your back and devour the carcass. Melodramatic? Maybe. Accurate? Definitely.

I finally made it back to my office and began going through my files, reconstructing the negotiation from the beginning. I'm pretty organized, so most of the work was already done, but it did allow me to pinpoint where the screw-up had occurred. The key was to find an interim memorandum of

understanding – we’d been exchanging those at the end of the negotiating sessions to make sure we agreed on what had been agreed -- that incorporated the new language. I knew that was the sort of thing Joanie had been thinking about when she’d tried to solve my problem, but it was also what I already knew I had to do.

Ah Joanie. She meant well. It’s just, yeah, she didn’t always get me. Which is fine. She’s my wife, not my mom. I reached for my desk phone to call her, apologize again. But I decided not to risk it. If we got into another fight, I knew I’d be worthless for the rest of the afternoon, and I needed to get more work done.

I did let my mind wander for a bit, though. I wondered if Joanie was having second thoughts too. Maybe she’d spend the day reflecting on it and realized that, *gasp*, I had a point. It would be so easy to make it up to me.

I imagined her making an appointment at the spa for a mani-pedi, French tips, and then deciding on the spur of the moment to get a waxing. A shower after, where she’d run her hands over her newly bare snatch, getting turned on thinking of my reaction when I saw. Then a trip to the mall for some new lingerie, a sexy, black, lace bra and panties with matching thigh-high stockings. A new dress, very sheer, short, only to mid-thigh, low-cut, showing a load of cleavage.

She’d greet me at the door to our house. Tell me she’d made reservations at Morton’s. In the car ride over, she’d flash me her thigh-highs, hint about the surprise I’d discover later. At the restaurant, a martini for me, coupe of champagne for her, a big steak and a bottle of red.

“Get a coffee, baby, I don’t want you falling asleep on me,” she’d coo, batting her eyelashes at me.

And then, in the car ride home. “Just relax honey and drive,” as she unzipped my pants and swallowed my cock.

My thoughts were interrupted by my stupid phone. Donald's secretary *inviting* me to come up to the eighth floor for a meeting. Just as well. A few more minutes with my fantasy and I'd have ruined my pants.

I was wrung out by the time I got home. Donald had been full of encouraging, not-punishing-failure, kind of stuff. You know, like: "criminally negligent conduct," "bonus clawbacks," "salary garnishment." All of which was bullshit, but it seemed to make him feel better to muse about ways he might be able to fuck me over if I couldn't get the contract fixed. The lawyers had apparently been more creative brainstorming with him about ways to screw me than they'd been with me about ways to fix the fucking contract. I'd probably need to get my own lawyer, paid for out of my own pocket, before too long.

I managed to make it home without incident. I even got a seat on the train. A pretty minor thing, but after the last two days, it made me almost giddy.

I walked in the front door and immediately heard the click-clack of Joanie's heels on the hardwood floor in the hallway coming in my direction.

I smiled brightly at her appearance. Damn, she'd gotten all gussied up for me. Not the short, sheer dress I'd imagined, but a more substantial black and gold wrap that nonetheless looked almost obscene in how it accentuated her curves. And those shoes... black, shiny stilettos. Where had they come from? But mostly I almost gasped at her mouth, a rich red applied heavily to her full lips, outlined with a darker red trace, and coated with shiny lip gloss. It was a look that conveyed one thought, without any possibility for misinterpretation. I felt my cock twitch in anticipation.

"You look amazing," I gushed. "Are we going out?"

She looked down at herself, as if surprised I'd notice.

"Oh, I'm sorry. Not *we*. Just me," she replied.

"Huh?"

"Well, you told me I needed more experience, so I decided I should go out on some dates."

I groaned. So she was still pissed and planned to torment me further. I knew what she wanted. Another apology, more groveling, but I'd gotten my ass kicked enough for the day. She wasn't going to get her jollies from me.

"So you have a date tonight?"

"Is that okay?"

I shrugged. *Whatever*. "Anyone I know."

She hesitated, trying to plan the best lie. "Yes, but maybe it would be better if I didn't tell you who... yet."

I nodded. "Yes, probably.... Well, you have fun then."

She frowned, disappointed, not the reaction she'd been looking for.

"Oh, I will. And don't wait up."

"I wouldn't think of it."

She looked at me for another moment. "Well, I better go. I don't want to be late."

I nodded.

She grabbed a light jacket from the foyer closet and opened the door. "I left your dinner on the counter."

I forced a smile as she walked out the door. I rolled my eyes. She'd really picked a terrible time to push my buttons. I shambled into the kitchen. On the counter was the pizza box from last night, and when I opened it, there was half of a stale-looking pizza staring back at me. It speaks to how shitty my last two days had been that I was actually pleased. With a bottle of beer, or three, the day-old pizza would go down just fine.

CHAPTER FOUR

I didn't actually think much about Joanie while she was gone. I assumed she'd just gone over to a friend's – Trina's place, most likely. Trina was a bit of a cow, pudgy, though most cows don't have red hair. She had never really liked me, and her love life was such a disaster that it suggested she understood men even less than Joanie. A perfect refuge for Joanie looking to vent about what an asshole I was.

I watched some lacrosse on TV, not so much because it is at all interesting, but rather because I quite enjoyed imagining Tanner Alden as one of the preppy assholes on the field getting periodically pummeled with a stick.

“Take that stick right out of Joanie's ass and bash Tanner over the head with it,” I mumbled.

I chuckled to myself, then looked down at the five empty beers beside me. Yup, only a punchy drunk would laugh at that. Time for bed. I cleaned up and stumbled into the sack.

I'd taken half an Ambien to make sure I got to sleep, so I was a little groggy when Joanie woke me coming into the bedroom. I pretended to be asleep until she sat down on the bed. She smelled of cigarettes and sweat. I guess she hadn't gone to Trina's after all.

When I stirred she turned on the reading light and leaned over toward me. “Are you awake?”

Her breath was hot, boozy, a little musky.

“I am now,” I sighed.

“Oh good,” she said happily, as if I’d walked into a trap. “I learned *so* much tonight.”

“Hmmm? Oh, that’s nice,” I replied.

I wanted nothing more than to go back to sleep. Certainly I didn’t want any part of whatever game Joanie had planned.

She shook me gently. “But I have so many questions. Will you answer them for me? Please?”

I sighed. No way this would be good. “Okay.”

I peered up at her. She looked a little tired, but pleased with herself. Her lipstick was badly smudged. A nice touch, although maybe a little too much.

“Okay, so why is it so important for the girl to be on her knees when giving oral? I mean, it is uncomfortable for me, and wouldn’t the guy be more relaxed sitting down?”

“Huh?”

“I’m just trying to review what I learned tonight and understand it better. I was taught that I should get down on my knees to, you know, suck cock. *On your knees and make eye contact*,” she concluded, her voice dropping an octave as if quoting another man.

I stifled a laugh. So transparent. Was I really supposed to believe that she’d gone with another man and let him order her to blow him?

“I don’t know, maybe it’s a submissiveness thing?” I offered, trying to act as if this were all some abstract discussion.

She nodded. “So I guess that’s the same reason for insisting I... I mean, *the girl*, has to swallow? Because you know, the third or fourth time it starts to get old.”

“Four huh? Did you have a date with a teenager?”

I couldn't resist the line, but I immediately regretted it. Even hinting that I thought this was real played into her game.

"No, I just guess, he finds me more exciting than you do."

"No doubt," I deadpanned.

"So, about swallowing?" she persisted.

"Maybe it's just a cleanliness thing. I mean, it has to go somewhere."

"But one time, he... I mean, men want it on your face or tits, right?"

"Yes, but then at least it isn't on the man."

"Okay, so –"

"Um, Joanie, how much longer are we going to do this, because I –"

"Need some sleep. I know. *Believe me*, I do too. But just a few more questions."

"So, the gagging. Why is that a turn on?"

I rolled my eyes. "Gagging?"

"Well, John.... Oops, I shouldn't have said that. But I guess, you do have a right to know. Anyway, I guess John is bigger –"

I laughed. *Really Joanie?* "Well, since I'm about average, I guess by definition half the men in the world *are* bigger."

She nodded thoughtfully. "I had never thought about it that way. So, when I'm walking around, every other man I meet is bigger than my husband?"

I waited.

"Anyway, John –"

"John Martin?" I asked, unable to contain myself. Our neighbor across the street. Divorced. He had a weekly happy hour on his deck that always struck me as a little desperate. I'd heard him setting up when I'd gotten home.

She gave me a sad look that I could tell she'd been practicing for my benefit. "I'm sorry I had to go so close to home. But I was on a short timeline to start my dating."

She paused, waiting for me to comment.

I just wanted to get it over with. "Okay, so John, our big-dicked neighbor, was gagging you, and..."

"Well, it seemed to turn him on."

"Yeah, well, it shows how big he is, right? You can't even handle him."

"Oh, I get it."

"Glad I could help."

She leaned down and kissed my cheek. "Oh, honey, you really did. Between John's demonstrations and your explanations, I definitely feel like I understand how to please men much better. I would show you, but I have to admit, my jaw is a little sore right now. Maybe later?"

"That would be great."

Oh God, were we finally done?

"John offered to help continue my education on other issues, but I feel like it's better if I broaden my experience. What do you think?"

I sighed. "Yes, definitely."

"Okay, good, because I have another date tomorrow... with a different man."

"Right, gotcha. Maybe I'll work late."

"Good idea honey. I know how busy you are."

And finally she'd said something that made some sense. I turned over and went back to sleep.

CHAPTER FIVE

I woke up to the unmistakable sound of a woman sucking cock. A wet, sloppy, gagging, spitting blowjob. The room was bathed in light, so bright that I couldn't even bear to look at the windows. I stumbled upright and moved to the sounds. Into the bathroom, which looked more spacious than usual this morning, whiter also, a big glass shower, like the one in the hotel where we'd honeymooned. I looked inside. The shower was running. Joanie was naked, on her knees sucking off a man with a huge cock, he winked at me... Donald.

I shuddered awake. It was 6:20am and still dark outside. Joanie was in bed beside me, still bearing the aroma of cigarettes and whatever the fuck else she'd been doing. Was that story of hers a fucked up dream as well? No... I didn't think so. That part had happened. Ambien always gave me weird dreams though.

I let her sleep. I dreaded what would happen if I woke her up. Anyway, I need to get back into the office.

On the metro ride in, I reorganized my notes on the contract issue. I'd done this a hundred times already, but it was the most important thing in my life right now... at least the most important I felt I had any control over.

The *Joanie Situation* as I'd begun to think of it, which sounds like the name of a bad novel, definitely felt out of control. Our problems had been building for a while. The move, my long hours, my reluctance to have kids yet had all contributed to the tension. My acknowledgement of some level of sexual incompatibility, at the margins surely, was enough to set her off.

But good God, couldn't she have picked a better time to snap than when my professional world was blowing up. And what was the right

answer? More apologies? Denials that I had meant any of the things I'd said? She wouldn't believe them anyway and it would just lead to accusations of patronizing her. No easy solution. I just needed her to calm the fuck down.

I took a deep breath. The *Joanie Situation* would have to wait.

The contract though... the problem was that the money was in a particular sweet spot. It was too much to ignore, and yet too little to make the company pull together and go to war. If we had to sue, we'd burn through the entire amount at stake in depositions. So I could see how the logic of the situation from Donald's perspective was to either make me solve it myself or throw me under the bus for failing to do so. And yes... I should have caught the mistake. I needed to own up to that.

The key, as with any negotiation, was leverage. I had none. Tanner knew that and wouldn't budge. Unless I could find his initials on an incriminating document, ideally right beside the new language for II.C.8 I couldn't force him to help me. But maybe I could find some way to encourage him to do what I wanted.

It occurred to me that there might be another way around the third-party allocations issue. In theory, there were unlimited potential third parties, in practice just two. Briand, a French company, had a stake in the action, and so did XCOSA, a Mexican one. I wasn't too worried about Briand. They had largely bid themselves out of the market anyway. Only EU regulations kept them in business across the Atlantic.

XCOSA was more complicated, and my spreadsheet estimate of the cost of the contract error was, in fact, based on an early XCOSA bid. If they happened to sweeten their offer, there might be even more at stake. But if they raised their price... then suddenly the value of the third-party allocations would plunge and TKD's interest in keep the clause would

diminish, maybe even to the point where it wouldn't be worth it to insist upon if it poisoned the well with us... or me at least.

Tanner is an asshole, but that doesn't mean he's stupid. If I could figure out the XCOSA option, he could. Which meant I needed to point him in a different direction. I called him up.

"Hey buddy," I said pleasantly.

"Hey man, I'm sort of busy right now."

"Yeah, I bet. Still drinking champagne on my dime?"

"Look, I gotta go."

"Wait, I got a deal to talk to you about. You're not retiring are you?"

He laughed. "I wish. But look, I don't know about you, but I don't get paid to reminisce about old deals. I get paid to make new ones. ABC, baby."

Always Be Closing. I'd seen the movie too.

"This is a new deal. Let me buy you a drink and we'll talk."

"You're buying? Okay, Sparkles at five."

"Sparkles? Really?"

"Well, if you're buying the drinks, then I wanna go someplace where I'll get my money's worth."

That doesn't even make sense. "Okay, whatever."

Sparkles, of course, is a strip club. And that is something I definitely wouldn't be mentioning to Joanie. Bad family history there. Well, she wasn't expecting me home anyway, and she'd be out... somewhere... as well. So it should all work out.

The day went by quickly. I locked my office door, drew the blinds and crunched on my scheme. So many moving parts, so little time to pull it together. Neither Donald nor the company lawyers pestered me, which at the time I was grateful for, but which struck me as ominous as I made my way to the strip club to meet Tanner.

Sparkles is actually a pretty neat place, architecturally speaking. It was at one time an old-fashioned, New Orleans-themed steak house, and there are two levels, the upper level where the VIP booths look out onto the main stage through wrought iron railings, and the main floor with two stages. The two story main stage allows the more intrepid and athletic dancers to perform almost twenty feet in the air. There is a large horseshoe bar that at one point had a raw bar in the middle, but now had a smaller stage with a stripper pole.

Tanner was at the main stage, sucking on a martini, and throwing singles from a fat wad at a young, heavily tattooed blonde in patent-leather, thigh-high boots and nothing else.

“She’d make a delightful Mrs. Alden,” I commented.

“I’d let her suck on my dick.”

“Generous of you.”

He waved for the waitress and ordered another martini. I got myself a beer. I gave her two twenties for our drinks. Before we could start our conversation, two strippers approached and sat in our laps. Sisters, or they could have been, Eastern European, though mine had dark hair and his was blonde. They were dressed in similar lingerie, though mine’s was white and his girl’s was black. Clearly some thought and coordination had gone into this, and they seemed to have an act down pat.

“You wan’ see me suck sister’s titties?” his girl asked in thickly accented English.

“I’ll pass,” I replied.

“I do,” Tanner interjected. “Go ahead, man, buy me a private dance with these two cuties, and I’ll be in a much better mood to listen to your pitch.”

Luckily I’d dropped by the ATM before heading over. “How much,” I asked the girl in my lap.

“Five hundred for half hour and we make sure he never forget.”

I laughed. “Two hundred for fifteen, and make sure he comes back alive.”

They nodded and led him away.

I drained my beer and ordered another. I was almost three hundred in the hole and hadn’t even spoken to the fucker yet. Still, I couldn’t deny the view was nice. Tattoo-girl left the stage and was replaced by a little, blonde cutie in a school girl outfit... or at least the stripper equivalent, which replaced the traditional knee-high socks with thigh-high stockings and of course featured a trashy red bra peeking through a sheer, tied-off, white blouse. She had her hair up in pigtails, which I thought was a little over the top, and the inevitable lower-back tribal tattoo, though more understated than what most girls had at the club, still seemed out of place. But there was no arguing with her big innocent eyes and tight little ass that almost tempted you to take a bite out of it. It was a look Joanie could easily pull off. Was it really too fucking much to ask for her to do something like that once in a while?

Even though the schoolgirl was undoubtedly stripper crazy, I suspected she would have no qualms about sucking me dry after a hard day at the office. Of course, Joanie was working on that, wasn’t she? What had she tried to sell me last night? Oh, yeah, the neighbor, John with the big cock,

coming in her mouth four times *and* also once on her tits. Quite an impressive performance for an out-of-shape guy in his mid-fifties.

He finds me more exciting than you do. Well, sure, any guy is going to go bonkers for a sexy neighbor showing up one night and offering to blow you unconscious. Just a matter of putting a little work into it.

Schoolgirl was definitely putting some work into it. She'd removed her bra and untied her shirt, but kept it on, letting it hang loosely. The effect was more erotic than if she'd just been completely topless. There was a sense of getting away with something each time I caught a glimpse of her pretty, little titties beneath the loose, shifting fabric. She did a similar thing with her panties, slipping them off while leaving on her tiny plaid skirt. When she crawled around the stage, flashing her meaty, shaved pussy it was an instant hard-on. All I could think about was how much I wanted to grab a hold of those pig tails and ram her hard from behind, a desire that almost instinctively manifested itself in me peeling off dollar bills and throwing them at the stage.

She finished off her set, collected her bills, and put on her bra and panties, even as she scanned the room looking for likely lap dance buyers. Her shameless casualness about her nudity was wildly erotic. I hoped she wouldn't come over. I knew I wouldn't be able to resist the offer of a dance, but I needed to stay focused on Tanner. Still, I was disappointed when another guy snagged her just as she got off the stage and took her into the back. Lucky fucking bastard.

The next girl on stage wasn't my type. Nice body, but Goth and covered in tats. I know some guys get off on that look, but for the life of me I can't understand why. Well, to each his own, I guess.

I checked my watch. Almost fifteen minutes had passed, and sure enough, like clockwork the two strippers were leading Tanner back, his

goofy grin a testament to their effective work.

He plopped back down in his seat and waved for another martini. I groaned, drunk was okay, passed out would be a problem.

“You ready for some business?” I asked.

He waved his hand at me, a bored expression on his face. “Yeah, yeah, go ahead.”

I pitched a potential deal involving our South Korean subsidiary, a back door partnership with a Chinese firm. It was a dog, but anything involving China has a surface plausibility. Still, Tanner saw right through it. He was shaking his head before I’d finished the pitch.

“Won’t work,” he said with a cocky grin, as if explaining the obvious to an idiot. “You won’t be able to distribute expenses across the tax zones. Every cost effectively get doubled.”

I shook my head. “No, man, trust me, I ran the spreadsheet.”

He was scouting the room for another lap dance. I needed to close this conversation down before he could waste another couple of hundred of my dollars.

“Look, you owe me,” I whispered urgently.

That got his attention. Nothing like a little desperation in a negotiating partner to set up a lucrative deal.

“Just look at the numbers,” I pleaded. “I’ll send them to you before I leave for Marsailles.”

I saw him perk up at that. Bingo!

“Alright, alright, send them over.” Then with a forced casualness, he added, “what’s in Marsailles?”

I paused, deliberated rolled my eyes to the right, then spoke in a quick, clipped tone. “Nothing, just vacation you know. Had a hard week. Great bouillabaisse.”

He nodded. “Okay, so send the numbers. I’ll review them when I can.”
“Thanks man.”

I threw down another couple of twenties to cover his latest martini and hightailed it out of there.

No one vacations in Marsailles. It’s a seedy port. But Briand was headquartered there, and Tanner knew that if I could lock down a Briand deal, I could flip the third party allocations issue on its head. He’d figure out this was a ploy soon enough, but a couple of days of him focused on Briand rather than XCOSA was all I needed.

CHAPTER SIX

I dropped by the office to crunch some numbers, so I didn't get home until almost midnight. The house was empty. The *Joanie Situation*.

I cracked open a beer and changed out of my work clothes, slowly roaming around the house looking for clues she might have left me about where she'd gone.

I was going to have to get a handle on this thing with my wife somehow, though since I wasn't sure what was going on, it was hard to do. And one of the reason I wasn't sure what was going on was that I hadn't been paying enough attention to her. Even before the TKD contract fiasco, I'd been working too many hours, just coming home to eat, sleep, and occasionally screw. Not exactly a perfect marriage. It didn't help that she didn't have a job and that she didn't really know many people in town.

It occurred to me that I'd been treating Joanie like just another counterparty in a negotiation. She wanted to make me jealous and mad, I wouldn't let her. That was her strategy, her leverage, and I knew how to combat that. I'd been doing that for years, now that I think about it. But that win at all costs approach, successful as it might be in a place like Marston was disaster in a marriage. I'd been squeezing Joanie, grinding her down. She couldn't out-negotiate me, but she shouldn't have had to. That was on me.

On the other hand, it isn't like I had it much better, dragging my ass into the office every day, working for an asshole boss, dealing with jerks like Tanner on a daily basis. And I was doing it all for her... so we could save enough to have a decent house, kids, all the stuff she wanted. Yeah, I wanted it too, but I don't know, they seemed more like her goals that I was

working for. She could cut me a little slack, throw me a bone. Instead, she was playing some sort of weird game with me.

I chuckled. Weird indeed. Out of character. For a girl built like Lara Croft, she was surprisingly uninterested in sex. Well, no, that's not right. She liked sex. Enjoyed it a lot even. But she wasn't very adventurous. At the end of the day, she was still an innocent Catholic girl, full of guilt and sexual repression.

Or maybe she *was* right, and I was the fucked-up one. Maybe I was letting porn shape my expectations of what a girl with that kind of body should be into. But then again Stacy was that kind of girl, in real life. So this wasn't *just* some crazy male fantasy.

And, this was the really weird thing. In a crazy way, I sort of liked Joanie's game. Of course, she hadn't really blown our neighbor, but it was undeniably a hot image. The idea of her walking across the street and offering to blow him until he couldn't get it up anymore was weirdly erotic. Partly because it was out of character. Partly because just the idea of it was sexy, a wet-dream come true. At some level, it suggested that maybe she was coming out of her sexual shell.

I almost wished she'd given me more details instead of phrasing her revelations as a series of questions about male sexual response. What had she said to him when she'd gone over? Had she shown him her tits? Well, I knew she had, since she said he'd come on them. But was that his idea or hers? Had she stripped naked? *If you're going to torment me, Joanie, at least make it entertaining.*

As if on cue, I heard her key scraping in the lock. 12:45am. I walked back toward the front door and we met in the foyer. She startled... guiltily?

"I thought you'd be asleep," she explained.

She really *did* look freshly fucked. Her hair was disheveled, her little black party dress wrinkled. She looked flushed and was carrying her black, spiky heels in her hand, almost a caricature of a party girl completing her walk of shame. I wondered if she'd thought to stash her panties in her purse to complete the illusion.

"You look like you had fun."

She rolled her eyes. "I don't know about fun, but I learned *a lot*."

"John again? You're going to put the poor guy into an early grave."

She gave me a queer look. "You think I'm making this up."

"No, not at all," I replied, suppressing a smile. "It would be out of character for you to lie to me." *But not half as much out of character as going out and screwing strangers.*

She hesitated and then decided not to bite on that. Better to continue her little game. "No, not John. You made it quite clear I should go out and experience other *men*, not one man, multiple times."

I laughed. "I'm not sure I ever quite said that.... But okay, so who? Do I know him?"

"You're not going to be happy about this," she replied, flashing me a Cheshire Cat grin.

This would be good. Who would she pick? She didn't know Tanner, otherwise I had a sense she would say she had been with him. No, it was obvious. Donald. That's what would most get under my skin.

I shook my head. "Probably not. So?"

"I didn't have much time to plan..." she was dragging it out, obviously enjoying the game. "But he lives nearby and he does seem like a *typical* man... so...."

"Yes?"

She blushed and smiled yet again. "Cody."

I groaned despite myself. She'd outdone herself. Cody was my half-brother. It still felt weird to think of him as that. I'd never known he'd existed until seven years ago. Seems that my dad, some twenty-two years ago, hooked up with a stripper name Starlight a.k.a. Rene Simmons a.k.a. Cassidy Roy Johnson a.k.a. God knows what else. But sure enough, paternity tests proved it. It had torn our family apart, and was the reason I couldn't admit to Joanie that I'd gone to a strip club. Family history was not on my side. Graham men can't be trusted around strippers.

Cody, by coincidence lived north of town, in a trailer park and he was indeed a typical man, if by that one thinks of a beer-drinking, NASCAR-worshipping, unemployed Neanderthal. Even after Cody turned eighteen, he still was constantly after my dad for money, and when we moved to Boston, he even paid me a visit asking me for help. *We brothers after all*. I'd never seen him sober or without his hand out.

I hadn't reacted as she'd wanted to her "John the neighbor" story, so she'd pulled out a bigger gun.

"So, how is old Cody doing?" I managed to choke out.

She grinned again. She knew she'd gotten to me.

"Do you mind if I sit down? He really wore me out." She squeezed past me, again the smell of cigarettes and sweat, mingling with a sickly sweet perfume.

"You take up smoking?" I asked, following her into the living room.

Her eyes flashed. She'd been waiting for that question. "Well, not really, but it does help to get the taste of... you know... out of my mouth."

I felt a lump in my stomach. I groaned again, annoyed at myself for being so easily manipulated. I couldn't help but picture it. My beautiful and voluptuous Joanie, in her clubbing dress and high heels, rapping on the thin, aluminum door of Cody's singlewide. The look of surprise and delight on

his unshaven mug as he realized what she wanted. In that dress, there was little doubt. *Why are you here?*

“What did you say to him?” I blurted out.

She dropped heavily onto the sofa.

“I told him you wanted me to have more experience with men,” she replied simply, as if this were a perfectly normal thing to say. “But he didn’t seem to believe me.... at first.”

She waited for me to react, but I managed to hold my tongue. I could tell that annoyed her.

“Well,” she continued, “he told me that if I was serious, I should come on in. He swept a bunch of beer cans off his table and told me to bend over it. So I did.”

Too much Joanie. Gotta keep it believable. I looked away so she couldn’t see my smirk.

“Do you want to hear the rest?” she asked.

“You seem to want to tell it.”

“Well, I *am* doing this all for you.”

“Yes, of course.”

On that we could agree. She was definitely making all this up to get back at me.

She tried to read my expression for a bit, but I managed to keep my poker face intact.

“That’s when he told me to lift up my dress and pull down my panties. *I wanna see your ass,*” she concluded in a passable imitation of my half-brother’s surly drawl.

I rolled my eyes.

“What? He said it!” She paused, giving me an opportunity to respond, but I again opted for silence. “So I did what he told me to. Pulled them

down just enough to let him see... everything. That seemed to get him going. He had a lot to say about you.”

“I bet.” *Fuck*. I need to stop letting her bait me.

She smirked. *Victory*. “He said that he wasn’t surprised that I was there. That he’d always known I was too much woman for you. But you know what Kel? I guess in some ways that’s a compliment, but it didn’t feel like it.”

For Christ’s sake, Joanie, get it out already. I realized I’d have to change tack. Unless I hastened the process, she was going to drag this out all night.

“So what did you learn from him?”

Another satisfied smirk. “Well, I have to admit, I don’t really understand men. He took me from behind like that, bent over his table. And it was like he was angry at me! When he wasn’t saying you were a wimp, he was calling me a slut and a whore. Then when he finished told me to strip and get him hard again... which I did... and then he put me on my hands and knees and again did it from behind, even rougher this time, pulling my hair and slapping my butt.”

“Well, at least you didn’t have to see his ugly, rat face while he was doing it,” I snarked.

“Oh, he’s not that bad. He’s in shape and he’s big too.”

“Of course,” I sighed.

“But seriously, Kel. I mean, even when he took me to his bed, he yanked me so that I was almost falling off the mattress and he screwed me standing up with my legs over his shoulders. And then —“

“I get it. It felt dehumanizing?”

I get it Joanie. I’m sorry I acted like you were a sex object that only existed for my pleasure.

She nodded. “Yes! Exactly. Like, you know, he almost hated me because he wanted me. Like he just wanted to satisfy his urges in the most impersonal way possible.”

I sighed. “Okay. You’ve made your point. I’ll say it again. I was having a bad day, and I’m sorry about what I said the other night. It was wrong of me, and –“

“What are you saying Kel? Are you saying that you wouldn’t have wanted me to, what, service you like I did John and Cody?”

I groaned. She was going to make me not only apologize for what I’d said, but what I’d thought.

“I was being insensitive and –“

She shook her head. “But that is what you wanted?”

“I don’t know what you want me to say.”

“The truth.”

You can’t handle the truth. I smirked, immediately regretting it.

“I regret having those thoughts. I’ll try harder to be more considerate in the future.”

“So you mean that in the future you’ll keep those thoughts to yourself?”

“Sure. Yes. Of course. Joanie, I love you and –“

“Well, I love you too Kel, and that’s why I want to better understand –“

“Can we stop this now? It’s getting late. I’m sorry, I’m sorry, I’m sorry.”

She rolled her eyes. “God, you still don’t get it. That’s not what I am looking for. I’m not looking for sorrys. I’m looking for understanding. How it is that after five years of marriage I still have no idea what you expect of me.”

Now I was genuinely speechless. Out of words. I had no idea what she wanted. And as the moments stretched on, neither of us speaking, I could see her getting more and more frustrated. It is a weird, helpless feeling to be in a situation like that, seeing things going horribly wrong and yet completely unable to conceive of a useful course of action. Should I have taken her in my arms and hugged her? Apologized again?

Finally she broke the silence. “Fine, then I guess I need to continue my research. I’d show you what I’ve learned, but like last night, I’m too worn out for now.”

And with that, she rose and without looking back, she went upstairs to bed.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Confront challenges. Seize the bull by the horns. Take the initiative. It is all well and good to think that, but it only works when you have some idea what to do. And I didn't. I'd taken my best shot with Joanie and had come up snake eyes.

I let Joanie have the bed and slept on the sofa. Or at least tried to. My mind was racing with work-related thoughts. Around 4:00am, I gave up. I showered, shaved, and went back to the office.

The simplest way to fix the situation was for my firm to sign a new partnership agreement with XCOSA that would encourage them to submit a new bid. But that was complicated. The reason they weren't part of the original deal was that they weren't sold on our market analysis. Too much risk, too little upside.

I needed to sweeten the deal. In theory, that should have been easy. Every dollar up to \$2.9 million we spent to seal the deal would come back to us indirectly through the third-party allocations clause. But it still meant dollars up front that would at best mitigate a loss. If my market analysis was wrong, it meant the worst case, throwing good money after bad. And given how pissed off Donald was, I wasn't sure I could bring him around on this.

Worse, even if my market analysis was correct, it wouldn't help Donald's bottom line. The \$2.9 million loss was really a missed opportunity. Invisible. The money we advanced to XCOSA, almost no matter how we did it, was a direct cost. The loss was also theoretical for the next twenty-four months. It might not even occur. Briand or XCOSA could come through on their own. Who knew? Well, I did. And so did Donald, which is why he was pissed, but no one else really needed to know. But

signing a new XCOSA deal, front-loaded with incentives would make the fuck-up public, and suddenly it wouldn't just be my fuck-up, but Donald's as well.

As much of an asshole as Donald is, I thought he'd come around sooner or later. But I didn't have the luxury of "later." The money would go to whomever signed a favorable deal with Briand or XCOSA first. I might have bought a few days with Tanner by making him focus on Briand, but that was it. If I didn't have XCOSA signed and sealed within forty-eight or at most seventy-two hours, Tanner would be on them. We'd be competing for a deal. They would try to fuck us on the negotiations and nothing would happen. Which was fine with Tanner. He won either way. I needed a deal. He could have either a deal or nothing and still come out ahead. He had the leverage.

The only way I could get the leverage back was to make XCOSA an offer they couldn't refuse. And for that I needed Donald's backing, so I was back to square one....

Or was I? That was the \$2.9 million question. In theory *anybody* could sign Briand or XCOSA. Well, anyone but me. If I did it on my own somehow, my firm could kill me if they wanted to. Not literally, but they'd sue me. I might even be criminally at risk. It would look like I'd fucked up the contract in order to give myself the opportunity to step in with a partnership of my own.

I could tip off another firm. That would fuck Tanner, which might be worth it by itself, but that would be pure spite. I'd be violating my fiduciary duty to my own firm to help another and wouldn't even profit. And, of course, if I did, I'd be back in the same boat of being at risk of being sued or prosecuted.

No, I needed to be above-board, and to do that, I needed to first go to Donald and pitch him the idea of sweetening the deal for XCOSA. But if that failed... and I knew it would until he at least cooled down... what would I do next?

Simple. Get Donald to allocate the rights to me legally. Raise around \$1 million to sweeten the deal for XCOSA. And lock XCOSA into a deal. All in the next two to three days.

I chuckled. Maybe I should work on the *Joanie Situation* instead. I had no idea how to proceed with her, but surely it couldn't be as absurdly complicated as trying to fix my business problems.

I sat down with Donald. He wasn't happy to see me. I sat in his outer office for nearly two hours before he let me in. He was supposedly in a meeting, but when he finally left to go to the bathroom, he was alone.

"What do you want Kellen? I'm busy."

I nodded at the campaign literature scattered across his desk. The big fundraiser he was hosting at his house the following evening was consuming all his time.

"New profit center?" I asked sarcastically.

He sneered. "Shouldn't you be talking to TKD instead of stalking me?"

I waved that away. "That's going nowhere. I have a better idea anyway."

He rolled his eyes.

I plowed ahead. "Look, the way the deal is now structured, it is more attractive to bring in a third party."

“I thought you tried that? You saying this is another thing you fucked up.”

I sighed. “I did try, but under the old terms it didn’t make sense to sweeten the deal. Now it does.”

He snorted. “So you want to throw good money after bad? How much?”

I thought I could make it work with \$500,000 with enough time, but I didn’t have time. I needed to shock and awe XCOSA. “I’d like negotiating authority for a million.”

“Fuck you.”

I laughed. “Is that a no?”

“Of course, it’s a fucking no.”

“Because you don’t believe in the deal? Or you don’t believe in me?”

He shrugged. *Why not both?*

“You’re desperate. And desperate is bad for business. You’re going to get taken to the cleaners.”

“I have faith in myself.”

“Save your faith for church. Get the fuck out of my office, Kellen, I have shit to do.”

I gave an exasperated sigh. I needed to sell what came next as a sudden inspiration.

“Please Donald, I’ll...”

“What? Seriously, man, you’re reeking with flop sweat. I wouldn’t give you negotiating authority on ordering lunch right now.”

“I... I...” *Just another few seconds.* “I... fine, look, how about I buy out the option myself?”

He chuckled. “And then what?”

I shrugged. “I don’t know. Get a second mortgage? Borrow from my parents? I believe in this deal.”

He laughed. “Okay, fine, what’s your offer?”

I nodded. Nodded. *Thinking. Thinking.* “Okay, I haven’t had time to run the numbers on it.” *A lie.* “But how about we split the profits fifty-fifty and you hold back fifty percent of my bonuses for the next... three... years?”

“What makes you think you’ll be around that long?”

“Oh, come on Donald. It was one fuck up.”

“My experience is, fuck ups come in threes. I’m not sure I want to be paying you for the next two.”

“It won’t happen again.”

He laughed. “Not if I fire you right away, it won’t.”

I ignored the jibe. “So, we have a deal?”

He laughed. “Fuck no. You want us to sign away our rights? You need to pay up front. \$500,000. Cash on the barrelhead.... And fifty-fifty split on revenue associated with third parties, if those ever come through... which they won’t.”

You have to give it to Donald. Even without a spreadsheet in front of him, he’d made a perfect offer to a desperate man. He’d left just enough in the trough to make it tempting.

I nodded. “I’ll think about it.”

“Don’t think too long.”

“Thank you,” I said finally. I was impressed I’d managed to choke that out.

I didn’t have \$500,000 to give Donald, and even if I did, I wouldn’t. He’d find a way to hold the money and fuck me with XCOSA. That would make him look good. He would be able to say he knew the deal was a dog

and that he managed to get something for nothing. If I made the deal work, even though he'd squeezed me hard, he would still have left money on the table, namely my small share. Our interests were not aligned. But that was okay. I hadn't expected a deal with Donald. The meeting was just about putting the plan to buyout the clause on the table. And in that sense, everything had worked out perfectly.

CHAPTER EIGHT

I was wrung out by the time I got home. Definitely in no state to deal with Joanie. Luckily she was out. Or not luckily... Where the fuck was she? How much longer would I have to play this idiotic game with her?

I pulled out my phone and flipped through to Trina's number. Joanie was probably there. Or at least Trina, through a miserable process of airing of grievances would fill me in on what to do about my wife's anger. I took a deep breath to steel myself for the call, but just before I pressed dial, I noticed movement from across the street. John Martin was pruning his shrubs.

Information is power and before dealing with either Joanie or Trina, it made sense to confirm my conviction that she'd made up all of her adventures. It should just take a couple of minutes.

I cracked open a beer, pasted a smile on my face, and stepped outside. But as I stepped into the street and began making my way across, John spotted me, and dropping his clippers on his lawn. He hurried into his house, slamming the door shut behind him. For several moments I just stared at his closed front door.

What. The. Fuck?

A car honking woke me from my shock. I had stopped in the middle of the street. I jolted and proceeded across, cautiously walking up his path, glancing in renewed confusion at the clippers impaled in his lawn.

I rang the doorbell. No answer. I chuckled uneasily. I mean, he'd seen me, which meant he knew I'd seen him. I rang again. This time I heard a faint rustling sound from the other side of the door.

"Um, I can hear you," I said.

“Kellen, I have a gun,” he replied anxiously.

“Well, I don’t,” I said. “Let me in?”

“What do you want?”

“Oh Jesus, John, I just want to talk. What the fuck is the matter with you?”

He opened the door a crack and apparently relieved that I wasn’t actually frothing at the mouth, he invited me in.

“I figured you’d come,” he said.

“Yeah?” I replied. I was relieved to see he wasn’t actually holding a gun.

“Look, man, I swear, I thought you were cool with it. I mean that’s what she said. But it didn’t sound right. Still, you know, she’s so hot, and well....”

Oh my God. Oh my God. Oh my God. It was like an alarm clock going off in my head. Had she really? *Oh my God. Oh my God. Oh my God.*

“... definitely too good to be true. But then I figured, what the hell? And shit, you know...”

He was still rambling, but to me it was just a weird buzzing sound. I forced myself to think, think. How did I want this to go down? Two options really: My wife is a cheating whore and I’m an unwilling cuckold, or....

I put my hands up. John flinched. I took a reassuring step back.

“Relax, relax. It’s... it’s a game we play,” I said.

He looked at me skeptically.

“Yeah, yeah. I know, it’s a little weird. But you know? Really spices things up.”

“Really?”

I smiled and clapped him on the shoulder.

He flinched again, but less than before.

“She says you’re a real tiger. Five times, huh?”

He blushed a little and shuffled his feet, but I could tell he was proud of himself.

“Haven’t done that in over thirty years,” he admitted. “But it was all her. Man, that’s a sexy woman you’ve got. And you like to share her?”

I shrugged. *You know how things are.*

“And she was really okay with how it all went down?” he asked.

“How so?”

His nervousness returned for a moment. “I swear, Kellen, it was her idea. All the rough stuff, you know. Well, not her idea, but you know, she kept asking for more. All that, *show me what you really want.*”

I remembered what she’d said about the gagging, swallowing his come.

He was still going on, “Truth is, I’d have been just as happy to get her naked, show her a good time. But she said that was all off limits. Just her mouth. You know? Well, you do know, it is your game, right?”

I nodded. “Look, sorry to have dragged you into all of this. We usually, um, play further from home.”

He looked crestfallen. “Oh, so, that was it?”

I shrugged. *Maybe, maybe not, who can say?* “At least you had a good time.”

“Yeah, I did,” he replied, but he was shaking his head sadly. “You let Joanie know I’d like to return the favor some day. Okay?”

“Sure,” I replied as I slowly backed toward the door.

I let myself out, and in a daze, stumbled back across the street to my own home.

I popped open a second beer and dropped hard into the armchair by the TV. I was actually tempted to turn it on for a minute, try to lose myself in whatever I happened upon, but I knew that was a hopeless wish. Sort of like the idea that I'd ever be able to put my life back together.

It occurred to me that Joanie might have conspired with John to create the story. That it might all be a put-on. Even if she hadn't sucked him off, she was pretty enough that he might be willing to cooperate with some zany scheme just to please her. But that just felt unlikely. He'd really been scared at first and desolate at the end when I suggested it was likely a one-time thing.

No, I just had to accept it. My wife, angrier with me that I could have imagined, had gone across the street and blown our neighbor. She'd gagged on his cock, swallowed his come, and taken a load to the chest.

Even worse, if the story about John was true, then so too was probably the one about Cody. On one hand, that one wasn't as bad. I didn't like Cody, but I never really gave him much thought ordinarily. On the other hand, it was worse. He *was* my half-brother after all, and she'd actually *fucked* him.

Okay, so what did I think about it? And what was I going to do about it? The first question was actually, weirdly, as hard as the second.

I was angry. Furious even. I mean, my professional life was falling apart... our professional life, actually, since I was the only one with a salary, and instead of being supportive, my wife had decided to throw the hissy-fit of all hissy-fits. No matter how much of a jerk I'd been, and I was a big enough man to admit I had been one, it didn't justify her global-thermonuclear-war level of massive retaliation.

But I was also sad, and frankly concerned. Sad that I'd driven her to this, if indeed I had. And concerned because, well, this wasn't like Joanie. That was the whole fucking point. I could easily see Stacy doing something

like this, although Joanie's response seemed a bit extreme even for my sex-crazed, queen of bad judgments ex-. Could this be some sort of mental illness? PMS on steroids? A bi-polar episode? The onset of schizophrenia? It didn't seem that way. She was too calm and collected, too in control when I'd seen her. Too deliberate in her taunts. And yet, this was so out of character to be baffling.

And that out-of-character-ness of it was also, weirdly, and I do mean weirdly, sort of, I don't know, hot? Talk about being careful what you ask for. I'd asked for her to behave like a slut, and bam, that's exactly what she was doing. I presume that was exactly the point of her little demonstration, but if she expected me to recoil in horror, she'd miscalculated as well. While I didn't particularly like the idea of her being with other men, the idea of her being suddenly so over-the-top sexually was, weirdly, and I do mean weirdly, appealing.

If she actually enjoyed herself, and if she and I managed to reconcile, then this might all work out. Of course, that was a lot of "ifs," and right now, I didn't even know where she was or what she was doing.

Again as if on cue, I heard her keys rattling in the lock of the front door. I reached up and turned on the light behind me to avoid startling her. I'd been sitting in the dark.

When she walked into the living room, I was oddly disappointed. No party dress, no smudged lipstick, just Joanie in yoga pants and a tee shirt.

"Coming back from the gym?" I asked.

"I guess you could say that," she said with a smirk.

And then I knew. I had another story coming my way. I managed to bite back a smile. I hadn't yet decided what to do about all of this, so best maintain the *status quo*.

"Had another date?" I asked neutrally.

She regarded me closely, trying to see if I still doubted her story. I noticed that her eyes were drawn and tired. All of this messing around was taking a toll.

“Something like that.”

“Are you going to tell me?”

“Hmmm, do you want to know?”

I shrugged. “Why else would I ask?”

“So you believe me now?”

“Of course. Why would I doubt you?”

“I would have expected you to be more upset,” she challenged.

“And I wouldn’t have expected you to be doing any of this.”

She nodded thoughtfully. I wondered if I’d struck the right chord. I wanted to keep her a little off-balance, unsure of what I really thought. I could see that she remained skeptical that I believed her, but I could also tell that she really wanted the opportunity to torment me with her latest misdeeds. Probing further whether or not I was convinced would conflict with that goal.

She smiled. “Well, this one wasn’t really a date.”

“Neither were the first two.”

“True,” she acknowledged. “But at least I got dressed up, went over to their places. This was more an appointment. I, um, paid for it.”

“You paid someone for sex?”

After this was all over I was going to need to teach her some serious negotiation skills.

“Well, not for sex. For his time. I needed a certain expertise.”

“Expertise?”

“Well, it was a little scary for me. I’d never done it. And it was something you specifically said I should learn about.”

I replayed our fight in my mind. What had I said? Then it struck me.

“You found an anal expert? What, a proctologist?”

She scowled. “Don’t be fatuous, Kellen. It was really a scary thought. A big, hard dick entering me there.”

“I’m sorry. I admit, it does seem daunting. So what did you do?”

She hesitated, again trying to gauge my seriousness.

“Well, I knew it would require relaxation. Deep breathing. Stretching.”

I looked her over again. “Your yoga instructor?”

She smiled. “Yes. I scheduled a private session with Raj. And when he asked if there was anything I particularly wanted to work on, I told him.”

“That must have made his day.”

She shook her head. “No. He said it would be inappropriate. But I managed to convince him otherwise. I told him I’d be a good pupil. That I’d do anything, everything he said. See, I am learning what men want, aren’t I?”

I nodded, suddenly dry mouthed. She seemed pleased to get that reaction out of me.

She continued, “Raj said he didn’t have a lot of experience either, but he really seemed to know what he was doing. He took me into the hot yoga studio. Do you know what that is?”

I nodded again. The idea of doing exercise in a hot, humid environment had always struck me as a little crazy. Like courting a heart attack. But I could see the attraction for this sort of activity. Hot, sweaty, relaxing.

“We stripped off our clothes. I think he wasn’t sure I was serious until I got completely naked for him. He has an amazing body.”

“Is he bigger than me too?”

She laughed. “No, actually not...”

I shuddered slightly. That answer, actually did more to confirm the truth of her story than anything else. Surely a fable would have involved yet another enormous phallus to taunt me.

“...thankfully for what we were doing. But he doesn’t have an ounce of fat on him. Just, long, lean muscle. Everywhere.

“We laid out some towels and he led me through a bunch of stretching and breathing. I know I was supposed to be focused on my respiration, but I couldn’t help looking over at him. At his sexy body. At his cock, slowly swelling, thinking of it being inside me.”

“He seems to have been distracted too.”

She smiled. “He did seem, um, interested. He asked me if I wanted to go on, and when I told him I did, he rolled me onto my stomach. He had brought some oils. He gave me a massage. My shoulders, my back, my bum. Then he had me stretch again. Cobra. Then Downward Dog.”

I shuddered at the image of it. Joanie, naked, sweating, oil covered, her ass high in the air. Watching sexy women doing yoga is an instant boner for me, even clothed. So many of the positions are inherently sexual. The rest invite one to imagine those long, flexible limbs twisted, wrapped.... I took a deep breath. There was a limit to the satisfaction I was going to give her.

Still, she’d seen. Her grin widened as she continued, “He slid his hand between my legs and started playing with my pussy. I shifted into Cow and then Cat. The heat, his body, the anticipation. I was so wet even without his oil coated fingers. That seemed to finally convince him I really, really wanted it.”

My surprise led me to exclaim, “You did? You really, really wanted to try anal?”

“Yes. I never did before. But yes, I did. Part of it was just to spite you. But part of it was that I sort of knew it would be good... with him.”

She looked up at me to make sure I'd noticed. Whatever else was going on, this was still about tormenting me as well.

"*Was* it good?" I asked.

She smiled. *Patience. All in due time.* "He laid me back on my stomach and placed a rolled-up towel under my waist. Sort of a modified Caterpillar pose. He told me to, um, play with my clit." There was a hint of embarrassment in her voice. "He went really slowly. Lots of oil. Just his fingertip at first, but it felt so good, so dirty."

"See, I told you," I said.

She didn't want to give me even that. No acknowledgement. Instead, she continued, "I couldn't help myself. He was by my side. I could see his hard cock bouncing as he played with me, and I couldn't help it. I took him in my mouth. Deep. Like John taught me. God, he was so hard, so, so hard. And his finger was going deeper, deeper, and then a second finger."

She shuddered as she recalled the scene. "I came hard. Can you believe it? I came while he fingered my butt."

"I was so relaxed that it took me a moment to realize he was no longer in my mouth, that he was kneeling over my legs. I felt his hardness press against me. He reminded me to breath, and then he put it in. It didn't even hurt. It just felt, I don't know, obscene. And good. Yes, Kellen," she said, finally answering my question, "it felt good when Raj sodomized me."

She paused to make sure I was still paying attention, and despite my intention to maintain a posture of slightly amused detachment, I was rapt.

She took full advantage. "He was amazing. He went on forever. I remember thinking beforehand that I hoped it would be over quickly. But the longer it went on, the more I hoped it would never end."

It took me a few moments to realize her story was at an end. "That's it?" I asked.

She nodded. “I’m sorry. It’s a little personal. Raj and I had such an amazing connection. You deserve to know what happened. But I want to keep some of it private.”

“Yes, yes, of course. I can see that.”

She frowned a little and caught it. That was not the reaction she was expecting. I think that another heartfelt declaration of my remorse at that moment might have won her back over. But crazy as it may seem, her story had triggered a thought in my head. A terrible, evil thought, but at the time, I was in the sway of its inescapable logic. I didn’t want this to end... not yet.

I cleared my throat. “I hope you don’t have another date tomorrow night.”

She looked at me hopefully. “Well, I do, but I could cancel....”

“Yes, please do. I need you to come with me to a fundraiser.”

“A fundraiser?” she asked, confused.

“Donald is throwing it. For Bruce Bryce.”

She was shaking her head. “No way, that man is a Neanderthal.”

“Which, Donald or Bruce?”

“No way am I going.”

“Yes, Joanie, you are. It is important for my job. Don’t worry, I’ll give twice as much to Ipolito to balance it out, but we need to go.”

“God, Kellen, you are an asshole.”

“I’m sorry Joanie. I know you’re upset with me, and I know we have issues –“

She stood up. “Fuck you.” She stormed out of the room.

Ouch. I wondered if I’d overdone things. Oh well, it was done. And anyway, our reconciliation would have to wait for some time when her ass wasn’t still throbbing from taking another man’s cock. I’d been a dick, and I

was willing to grovel to get Joanie back, but there was a time and place even for that.

CHAPTER NINE

I didn't see Joanie before I left the next morning. I was pretty sure that was intended on her part. I actually thought I heard her stirring, but she didn't leave the bedroom until I was gone.

In the office, I secreted myself away. I had a ton to do, three separate contracts to write, with no help from legal. Odds are I was fucking something up, but it couldn't be helped. I couldn't risk getting the lawyers involved.

I did take the time to text Joanie once.

[Kellen]: I'll send a car by to pick you up. And please dress up nicely for tonight. Love you.

Her reply was less than gracious.

[Joanie]: Fuck you.

Still, I was pretty sure she'd show up. Her desire to mess with me was perfectly consistent with making an appearance. Indeed, it would give her a good opportunity to really teach me a lesson. It was that intention I was counting on.

I finished up the contracts, and printed out three sets of each. I checked my watch. 6:30pm. Just enough time to head over, grab a drink and get the lay of the land before the car service dropped Joanie off.

Donald wasn't particularly happy to see me, though he obviously couldn't say anything. He was, after all, throwing the fundraising, and my

two thousand dollar check would go in his column. Still, he wasn't above throwing a barb my way.

"I thought you leaned a little pink?" he noted as he accepted my money.

I smiled. "I've been thinking a lot recently. You're really a mentor to me, you know."

He shook his head. "You're so full of shit."

"Okay, I admit it, I just wanted the opportunity to snoop around your medicine cabinet."

"Try not to fall in the pool."

I nodded thoughtfully, and then proceeded to the open bar.

I was on my second martini when Joanie arrived. She scanned the room. Spotting me, she stalked over, a scowl firmly in place. I leaned in to kiss her cheek, but she blocked me with her hand.

I handed her a glass of champagne.

She took a sip.

"You look great, by the way."

And she did. She was wearing a classy, sheer, satin gown. A single bare shoulder. Dark blue and paired with a well-selected assortment of gold costume jewelry. Sexy without being slutty. Appropriate, but still certain to attract a lot of attention from admiring men and jealous women.

"Thank you," she replied. "I figured even if I didn't have a date, I might be able to continue my education with someone I meet tonight."

Bingo!

I tried to look anxious. "Look, Joanie, I know you're still upset at me."

"Yes I am," she acknowledged eagerly.

"Just please, please whatever you do, stay away from Donald. Just do that one thing for me, okay?"

“Well, I can’t avoid him completely. It is his house.”

I sighed as if defeated. “Okay, yes, you need to acknowledge him, but you know what I mean. Please Joanie, I’m begging you.”

She smirked. “I’ll do my best.”

I opened my mouth as if to speak, but I didn’t say anything. The better to convey the impression that I was so exasperated as to be speechless.

“Look, I need to schmooze a little. Do you want to join me?”

She shook her head. “No, I think I’ll stay by the bar. I prefer to hang out with the working people instead of having to pretend that taxes are just too damn high on the job creators. Jerks.”

I rolled my eyes. “Whatever.”

As I walked away I did cast a nervous glance at some of the wait staff. The two barkeeps were older guys, and most of the wait staff were women. There was a cute Hispanic kid bussing trays. He was a risk. She might decide the best way to mess with me was in a way that would also allow her to make a statement about class solidarity. But ultimately, I was betting on the fact that she’d look to give me a more personal jab.

I circulated slowly, joining various conversations mid-progress, which wasn’t difficult. I just needed to mutter a few catchphrases.

Well, I don’t think anyone needs more convincing that Romney was the right choice in 2012.

That Elizabeth Warren is an ivory-tower communist.

Can you believe we still haven’t gotten to the bottom of Benghazi?

The ability of these guys to repeat the same mantras over and over as if they were profound wisdom was a nice reminder that despite all the money, most business people have the intellectual depth of a kiddie pool. Still, it meant I could seem involved without having to put any real effort into it, which meant I could stay focused on my real mission.

There! Across the room, I spotted my wife sidling up to my boss. He smiled at first at the pretty lady approaching him, and then scowled as he placed her as being with me. He tried to extricate himself from her by pulling them into a discussion with another cluster, but I knew Joanie would be too persistent to be ditched that easily. When Donald tried to slip away, Joanie was close behind him.

He gave her an exasperated sigh, but seemed to decide it was best to get it over with, whatever she wanted. I presume that he was expecting some sort of pitch on my behalf. He was scanning around the room, looking for some escape, but I noticed his expression gradually change and become more focused on my wife.

I wondered what she was telling him. If I had to guess, I suspect she'd hooked him by complaining about me and inviting his commiseration.

Kellen is such an asshole sometimes.

Yes, yes, Mrs. Graham. Can I call you Joanie? He exasperates me too. I'm sure he told you about the latest at work.

Sympathetic nod. He's so immature sometimes. Never admits his mistakes.

A shared chuckle. Well, we need to do the best we can.

I just wish he were more like you. I mean, look at this house. They look around. Shows how hard you work.

Smiling. I'll give you a tour sometime.

Eager. Why not now?

I have all these guests.

Oh, they won't mind. It'll just take a minute.

Donald scans the room. Who's he looking for? Me? I lean forward into the group I'm in.

“Ha ha, exactly. It’s like they’ve learned nothing from the collapse of the Soviet Union!”

I’m not even sure what my group is talking about, but the line works for almost anything.

I looked over the shoulder of a gray haired, ruddy-faced man. Donald was still looking around. For his wife? She’d just disappeared into the kitchen, arguing with the caterer. For Bruce Bryce. No, too early for him. He’ll breeze in later, give a quick stump speech -- small business owners, Keystone XL, simplify the tax code. This crowd will eat it up. He’ll collect his checks and go. But that’s not until later. People are still arriving. The till isn’t full up yet.

Donald looked back at my wife. She batted her eyelashes, twirled her hair. For a girl who sometimes acts so asexual, so reserved, she knows how to turn it on when she wants. If nothing else, all of this made me wonder how much of her sexual repression can be traced to me. Something to think about. But not right now.

I watched in both shock and yet with expectations confirmed as Joanie and Donald made a furtive escape from the room.

I followed them, cautiously. I didn’t really have to worry about losing them. Donald’s house is big – a seven bedroom, six bath, McMansion, but not so large that I could really take a wrong turn. The only real issue was whether he’d take her upstairs or down.

Down, as it turned out. They took the main stairs. I knew I could catch up with them if I took the spiral stairs out of the kitchen. I dashed past the caterers, walking with purpose to avoid questions.

Once down in the basement, I listened for voices. Hearing none I scooted into the downstairs bar. I had to admit, it was a neat idea. Donald

had built a small British-style pub in his basement, complete with a pool table and darts.

I could hear their voices from across the hall, inside his cozy home theater, but as their voices got louder, I realized they were coming my way. I considered just dropping behind the bar, but I had second thoughts. Instead, I wedged myself into a corner, behind an old pot-belly stove that I suspected was just for show.

It was lucky I hadn't hidden behind the bar because Donald made a bee line there, pulling out a couple of mugs and pouring them each a stout. Joanie hates dark beer.

"Ooh, I love Guinness," she cooed.

I stifled a chuckle.

"Cheers," he said genially as they clinked mugs.

Joanie shook her head sadly. "Do you think Kellen will ever be as successful as you?"

"Of course," he replied, though he was shaking his head sadly.

"He doesn't realize it, but he is *so* lucky to have you as a mentor."

"He doesn't think so," Donald replied.

"But I do." She stepped in closer to him. "Please don't give up on him."

"I won't." He shrugged. *But I'm at the end of my rope.*

She nodded. "Would it help if I showed you how grateful *I* am?"

He waved it away, but he looked at my wife hungrily. She was sexy and a good actress, but it took Donald's egomaniacal arrogance to make it happen. Anyone else would have smelled a trap.

"You don't need to."

"I want to."

She reached up under her arm and pulled down a zipper. She peeled off the top of her gown, exposing a sexy, black lace, strapless bra that barely seemed to contain her ample breasts.

“He doesn’t deserve you,” Donald sighed.

“I know,” she replied.

She pulled down her bra. Her boobs spilled out.

“You have gorgeous breasts.”

Joanie smiled at the compliment, though I know in the back of her mind, it rankled her to be objectified like that. Still, I imagine it was all worthwhile if she could gather up an experience that would really, really get under my skin.

“Do you want to touch them?” she offered.

He reached out and began massaging her ample mounds. Her nipples slid between his widely spread finger. She reached out for his crotch. He leaned in and sucked her fat, raspberry nips into his mouth. She rubbed him harder, reaching now for his zipper, pulling it down, snaking her hands into his pants.

“Oh God,” she sighed.

“More than you’re used to?”

“And how.”

She pulled out his prick. Wow. I would never have guessed it. I’d have pegged Donald as tiny. All that bluster. The assholery. Smacked of over-compensation. But no, the guy was fucking hung. Made me hate him even more. Not because he had a big dick, but because it should have made him at least a little more chivalrous.

She stroked him up and down with both hands. He reached down and began pulling up the fabric of her dress until it was bunched at her waist. He pressed his hand down the front of her black, lace panties.

I got my phone out and began filming. They were both squirming and moaning. I could tell he had a finger inside her. His own excitement was obvious.

“Come on, we need to hurry,” he groaned.

Somehow I’d known he’d be a true romantic. She nodded, and he grabbed her by the waist and deposited her on the edge of the pool table. She spread her legs and trailed her red-painted fingertips along her thighs.

He wasn’t interested in a show. He just stepped forward and pulled her panties aside. He coated the head of his cock with a little spit and then pressed against her slit. She moaned as the tip slipped inside, and then shuddered as he rammed it home.

“Fuck, you’re hot,” he said.

She definitely was, in a trappy slut sort of way. With her clothes merely pulled aside, legs spread wide, getting fucked on a pool table, she looked anything but demure. He grabbed a hold of her large breasts and mauled them as he fucked her hard.

I think she was a little taken aback that things had moved so rapidly. But there was no denying that she seemed to enjoy being taken like that. I wondered if she’d give me credit for broadening her sexual horizons when this was all over. Probably not.

Donald didn’t last long. According to the timer on the video, it was precisely one-hundred and four seconds from the moment she’d fished his cock out of his pants until he shivered and came inside my wife.

He withdrew his slimy cock. Her pussy gleamed wet and pink, taking a moment to close up after being thoroughly stretched by him.

“That was amazing,” he said.

“Yeah,” she replied with a little less conviction.

“Look, let’s do this again some time, um, more convenient.” He tucked his cock back into his pants, and straightened his suit jacket. “Give me a few minutes and then come upstairs.”

She nodded. He gave her an awkward kiss and then was gone.

“Jerk,” she spat in his direction. “They’re all jerks.”

Ouch. I knew she was lumping me in with him in that comment. Of course, she had a point. I’d set this one up.

But it was no time for self-reflection. I had shit to do. Once Joanie left, I crept out of my hiding spot and took the back stairs back up to the main level.

I spotted Donald. He gave me a shit-eating grin from across the room. *I just fucked your wife.* But his grin disappeared as I strode toward him. I could see first surprise and then fear come across his face. Could I know already? He looked around the room. He knew he couldn’t run, so I think he was trying to calculate whether I’d be likely to get violent in front of all these people.

“Kellen,” he said warily.

“Donald, we need to talk.”

He shook his head.

“Now,” I insisted.

“Leave me alone,” he replied.

“You don’t want to have this conversation in public. Trust me on that. Anyway, it’ll be quick, and then you can go back to complaining about the moochers with your country club friends.”

I strode away, knowing he’d follow. I walked into his den and pulled the door shut behind us.

“What do you want?”

“Your signature. On this contract.”

I pulled out the document assigning me the proceeds from the third-party allocations. He smirked when he realized what it was. So this wasn't about Joanie after all.

"Did you bring the \$500,000 in cash? You know I can't accept a check."

I laughed. "No. No cash. Twenty-eighty split. Three years hold back on my bonuses."

"Kellen," he said, "even you can't be dumb enough to think you can make this work on twenty."

"Oh, the twenty is for you. I get the eighty."

He laughed. "And I'm supposed to sign that in return for, in all likelihood, bonuses you'll never earn?"

"No, you're going to sign it in return for me not telling everyone in the world that you fucked my wife."

He hesitated, thinking through the options. "I don't know what she told you --"

Ah, denial. "I could drag this out, but I won't. I filmed it. Just now. Downstairs. Want to watch? It won't take long."

He blushed a little, but then went back on the offense. "You want to tell people your wife is a whore? That you're a cuckold?"

I shrugged. "Marriages go through rough spots. But you.... How will that go over with your boy out there, family values Bryce? And what about your wife? I doubt somehow you two have an open relationship. Not to mention that I suspect the senior partners will take a dim view of you fucking your subordinate's wife."

"You're bluffing."

I laughed. "Dude. I watched you fuck my wife and did nothing about it. You sure you want to assume I won't go through with this?"

He was still on the fence.

“Anyway,” I continued, “you know this is a dog, right? I mean, the assignment is worth nothing. You’re offloading the risk and still getting twenty percent of the profits.”

“Fifty,” he shot back.

“No, that ship sailed when you put your dick in my wife. Twenty. Sign and let me get the fuck out of here.”

He chuckled. “Fine,” he said with a snarl. “Even if you can unfuck this deal, you still can’t unfuck your wife.”

I shrugged and handed him the papers. He signed and thrust them back at me. “Get out of my face, Kellen.”

I saluted. “Yes, boss.”

I left his den and returned to the living room. Joanie was standing alone near the piano, looking around for me. She smirked when she saw me, but quickly composed her features into more of a frown.

Oh my God Kellen, I’m so sorry, but something happened... with Donald... and I’m just feeling so guilty.

I didn’t let her get started.

“Come on Joanie. Let’s get out of here. Do you mind driving home alone? I need to go back to the office.”

She seemed surprised. “Um, okay, but, I need to talk to you about something.”

“Later, okay?”

“I really –“

I handed her the car keys. “You can stay at this party now that I think about it, if you’d rather. Or maybe there’s still time for a date. I’m sure Cody is just sitting around drinking beer. Or maybe John...”

She shook her head. “Fuck you Kellen.”

I kissed her cheek. “I love you too.”

CHAPTER TEN

I called up Charlie Staunch at Blaine Capital. Charlie and I had done a bunch of deals over the years, and I knew he was hungry. Even on a Friday night, he'd be willing to talk about a short-term line of credit.

I explained the deal quickly.

"How much," he asked.

"A million five. Will need to commit the million up front, but the rest is just insurance."

"And this is a Marston deal?"

"Well, no. I wouldn't need a new line to come up with that kind of money if the firm was on-board. I bought out the option on my own."

With my wife's pussy.

"So they think it's a dog."

"Donald isn't convinced," I admitted. "But it's too small to really make sense with all the overhead with have anyway. Good news for you. Gives you a chance to be on the ground floor of KelCo."

"Your LLC?"

"Yup. For now. Though who knows? Maybe we'll be a big player next year.

He laughed. "Gotta start somewhere?"

"Yup, even J.P. Morgan was once, you know, just this guy, J.P."

"Okay, so counter-parties and competitors?"

I liked that he was still asking questions. It meant he was interested.

"XCOSA is the counter-party. Heard of them? Manufacturers down in Mexico. No real competitors."

"Really Kellen?"

“TKD has a piece of it. But they’re like Marston. Too big to chase after scraps like this.”

“Who?”

“Alden.”

He let out a low whistle. “Tanner is a dick. He’ll get involved just to spite you.”

“He’s letting me have it,” I lied.

“Yeah?”

“Yeah. We have an, um, understanding.”

“And he’ll confirm that to me if I ask?”

“You know he can’t.” *Fiduciary duty and collusion*. “You’re going to need to trust me.”

Charlie thought about it.

“I don’t know man. And you want this fast? Otherwise you wouldn’t be calling at eight on a Friday.”

“Yup. Need to have the financing locked down by Monday morning.”

He whistled again.

“It’s not that I don’t trust you, but I don’t trust Alden.”

Fuck. Alden was definitely the fly in the ointment. And Charlie was right. I was moving so fast precisely because I wanted to pre-empt TKD not because they were out.

“How about this?” I began, thinking it through. “Does Tanner ever ask about your wife and kids?”

Charlie laughed. “No. And if he did, I’d look into moving.”

“Okay, so how about this. Even though Alden can’t confirm or deny anything, if I got him to send you a personal email like that would it let you know he and I are on the same page?”

He paused. “Okay, but I can’t give you sweetheart terms. I can move the loan by Monday, but you’re going to have to accept over-the-transom rates. And, um, Kellen? I’m going to need you to put up your house as collateral.”

I laughed. “Sure. You know it won’t cover it. But happy to do it to show good faith.”

“Kellen, hungry is good. Reckless isn’t.”

“Charlie, I feel this one in my bones. I got it.”

“Okay. But you owe me. And I will need that email from Alden. From his work account, okay?”

“Will do. And thanks.”

I sat at my desk. Charlie had emailed me a bunch of documents, and I knew I’d be spending much of the night doing paperwork. It was mindless work, and it gave me time to think, which was good because I needed to think. There were still so many moving parts in all of this. I had gotten the options assigned to me, and had secured funding... sort of. I still needed to get an email sent from Alden’s account. I sort of figured that with all the paperwork done, Charlie might let me slide on that if push came to shove. But better safe than sorry. It would suck for a little email to be the undoing of my plans.

As I saw it, I could talk Alden into it, I could hack his account, or I could break into his office and send the email from his desktop. None of those seemed like viable options. He wouldn’t send the email on his own. I didn’t know shit about hacking his corporate email. And if his office was anything like mine, there was no way I’d be able to sneak in. I could, in theory, finagle an invitation to his office... but then, I’d need to get him out

of the way. And anyway, I need to do this in the next twenty-four hours, which meant getting into his office on a weekend. Impossible.

And then it occurred to me. His phone. It was surely linked to his work email. I tried to remember what he used, and whether I had any clue about his password. Tanner was lazy and arrogant. I suspected his approach to password security was lax. I could sort of picture him, slouching at a conference table, checking his phone one-handed, using just his right thumb to enter the code to unlock it?

That was a long shot, but also my best bet. But how to get his phone? I needed him drunk, ideally, and in a situation where he wouldn't notice me rummaging in his pocket.... Or someone rummaging in his pocket.

Sparkles. Get him to Sparkles. Pay a stripper to give him a lap dance and steal his phone. Hack it while he has a pair of titties in his face.

It was worth a try. And anyway, I needed to get a sense from him about whether he'd figured out Marseilles was a red herring.

I made a note to call Alden first thing in the morning. The idea of spending a sunny Saturday afternoon in a strip club would surely appeal to his dissolute nature.

And I needed to call Alejandro Espinosa down at XCOSA. I had a good relationship with him. When we first met, he said I could call him *Al* if I preferred. I'd had the good sense not to do so. Alejandro Espinosa always struck me as a consummate gentleman. They were something old world of him, but in some ways I knew that was an act. He was just as ruthless a businessman as anyone I'd ever met. He wouldn't have been as successful as he was otherwise. There was a veneer about him that put you on your best behavior. And yet, that wasn't the whole story. How could it be?

I sighed. It occurred to me that I was so frantic about this stupid deal because it gave me something to think about other than Joanie.

I pulled out my phone and watched the video of her and Donald. God, she was a sexy woman. A classically beautiful face, and that body.... Seeing her getting fucked on top of a pool table by Donald's big cock was a reminder she was sometimes almost pornographic in appearance. And now, in behavior as well.

I didn't know what to think of that. It was, I had to admit, what I'd been dreaming of for years. Well, except that I'd fantasized about her really letting loose sexually with *me*, not with every man *except* me.

The other men didn't actually bother me that much. I've never been too hung up on the idea of my woman having another man's dick inside her. I mean, big deal. You take a shower, and everything is good as new. I've never understood men who see sexually adventurous women as used up somehow. It is a sick, misogynist perspective.

What did sadden me was that she was doing it all to spite me, not in a genuine spirit of exploration. That said, I sort of wondered if she wasn't getting into it despite herself. Her commitment to the goal of punishing me was a little awe-inspiring. I think even the most angry of women would have gotten it out of their system after the first "date."

You are such an asshole that I blew the neighbor.

That she was continuing with her project seemed to suggest there was more going on than malice. Even if she wasn't willing to admit it, even to herself, she must have, at least in part, started to get off on exploring her slutty side. Had to, right?

Somehow, I would need to reconcile with my wife in a way that supported and encouraged this new side of her. Frankly, I wanted that

because, well, I wanted it for myself. But also, I was hoping that she'd want it too.

I looked at the time on my computer. 1:15am. I needed to go home. I could finish off the paperwork there, and hopefully, if Joanie was still up we could begin to work on that reconciliation. The problem was, I didn't have a plan for that. I had no idea what words or deeds could even begin to fix things.

The cab pulled up to the darkened house. It occurred to me for the first time that Joanie might not be there. I had basically taunted her to go out and get herself fucked again. It would serve me right for her to call me from Cody's.

Ugh, Kellen, ugh, Cody is fucking me right now.

I shook my head. Did I actually want that? No. Well maybe, a little. Stress was making me loopy.

I kicked off my shoes and tossed my jacket over the back of a dining room chair. A whiff of acrid sweat washed over me. Ugh. I needed a shower.

I started slowly up the stairs. The lights came on in the bedroom. I breathed a sigh of relief, immediately followed by a groan as I realized a confrontation was coming.

I stepped into the room. Joanie was sitting up on the bed. She'd wanted to talk earlier in the evening, but now she just glared at me with cold eyes.

I sat down beside her, and put my hand on her thigh. She slapped it away.

"I fucked Donald tonight."

"I know."

“He told you?”

“I saw it.”

Her eyes went wide with shock. “What?”

“In the pub. On the pool table. I even filmed it.”

“You’re sick,” she hissed.

“It was sort of hot,” I admitted.

She shook her head. “So that’s it, huh? Just didn’t work out between us.”

“That’s not how I feel.”

She laughed darkly. “I’m not sure you feel anything.”

“What am I supposed to do? Scream? Throw things?”

“That would be a start,” she admitted.

“It would be an act. It’s not that I’m not jealous. I am. But I can’t help but think that I sort of deserve it.”

She snorted. “That’s for sure.”

“Okay, and then the question is whether you’ve been doing all of this *just* to spite me.”

“What’s that mean? That I’m just using the fact that you’re an asshole to do things I really want?”

I nodded. “Something like that.”

“Oh, you’d like that, wouldn’t you?”

“Yes, Joanie. Yes, actually I would.”

“You like me fucking other men?”

“I like you embracing your sexuality. And if you need to be angry at me to justify it to yourself, I’m willing to be the bad guy. Except, at some point, spite can’t be the whole story.”

We both sat silent for a few moments.

“Look,” I continued, “what were you expecting to come out of this? That’s what I don’t quite understand.”

“It was supposed to, I don’t know, slap you across the face. Remind you I exist.”

“But Joan... I mean, you had to know it wouldn’t work out like that. *I blew our neighbor*. Oh, honey, I’m so sorry. I mean, what? How does that work?”

“Maybe I didn’t care anymore. Maybe I’m just sick of you always being at work, of you sneering at my career, of all the shit.”

I paused. “No. I don’t want to put words in your mouth, but that doesn’t make a lick of sense. Because if you didn’t care, you’d have just drifted away.”

“Then I don’t know.”

“Joanie, let’s get some sleep. We’ll talk about it again tomorrow. But here’s the thing. I sort of like this new Joanie. Impulsive, a little crazy, passionate –“

“A slut.”

“Sure. Why not? What the fuck is really wrong with that?”

“You wish you’d stayed with Stacy.”

I hesitated. Did I? “No. But not because she was passionate and slutty, but because she was selfish and irresponsible. I’ve accepted the dichotomy without thinking. That it had to be either or. Passionate or sane. But I don’t think that’s true anymore. That hot/crazy matrix is horseshit. I like the new Joanie. Do you like her?”

She shook her head. “It’s an act.”

“Yeah? Well then you’re the most method bitch in the world. Fuck Stella Adler.”

“I don’t even know what that means.”

“Sure you do. If all of this was to spite me, if you hated every moment of it, then we’re through, because it means you’re willing to do things you detest just because you hate me. But... if getting back at me was an excuse. A chance to do things you might have wanted to do anyway but couldn’t figure out how to let yourself do it.... If this was a way to explore a new side... then we can work it out. Somehow.”

She shook her head. “I don’t know, Kel, I really don’t.”

“And that’s okay. All I can say is, I’m sorry. And I understand your anger. And I still love you. So the rest, honey is up to you.”

“Kellen... I sucked off our neighbor. I fucked your half-brother. I let my yoga instructor fuck me in the ass. I screwed your boss.... What the fuck is wrong with you?”

I laughed. “Fuck do I know? I just hope you enjoyed it. Weird, huh?”

“Yeah, Kellen. Yeah, it is fucking weird.”

I leaned over and kissed her forehead. “Life is weird sometimes. I’ll see you tomorrow.”

I grabbed my PJs and after a quick shower, went back down to the living room sofa. Hard to explain why, given how we’d left things, but I felt that somehow, weirdly, I was getting a handle on the *Joanie Situation*.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

I awoke earlier than I would have liked. I'd been up several more hours studying Tanner Alden's online presence, Facebook, LinkedIn, any thing I could get my hands on. I had his birthday. Favorite sports teams. I took a run at a few of his online passwords, trying to hack into his social network and Google logins, but no dice. I needed to get a look at him entering his password on his phone to have a shot.

Making my way to the kitchen I realized Joanie had woken up even earlier. She was sitting in our breakfast nook looking a little haggard, staring into an absurdly large mug of coffee. One of her silly quirks, but she'd always done that, taken her coffee in a quart-sized mug.

Happily, though, she'd left me enough for my own mug.

"What's going on with you Kel?"

"You mean?" I waved my hand around our house.

"No. At work."

I chuckled. That was the question I was hoping she'd ask me four days ago... though in all honesty, I'm not sure I would have answered honestly at the time. *Oh, nothing, everything is fine.*

I took a deep breath. "Well, I fucked up a contract, and cost the firm three million dollars. Well, you know that part. Now, it looks like Donald is probably building a termination file for me right now."

She gasped. "Oh God, last night...."

I laughed. "Definitely complicated things... though I think in a good way."

"Is that why...."

“I didn’t break it up? Yes. And... well, Joanie, it is worse than that. I sort of set it up.”

“How? You told him... something about me?”

I shook my head. “No, I just knew that as angry as you were....”

She snorted. “Jesus. And I thought I was pushing your buttons, but turns out I was just... just... what?”

“Can we... can I go back to the beginning here? It’s all more weirdly complicated than you can imagine.”

So I told her the story of the TKD deal. Not just the botched language, but the various conflicts of interest. How I was on my own, Donald wanting to see me fail, the Marston lawyers covering their own asses, Alden pocketing the proceeds of the mistake. I’m not sure she caught all the details, but I think I managed to convey the broad strokes of the situation, including the fact that I was likely about to be fired and that the only real bright spot was the possibility of completing a deal with XCOSA on my own.

“Oh, wow, Kel, all that happened this past week?”

I nodded. “Thankfully. Kept me busy. Otherwise the whole thing with you would have driven me crazy.”

She laughed. “Well, if I hadn’t gone off the deep end, I wouldn’t have seduced Donald, and you wouldn’t have gotten the options.”

I nodded. “Which is why I sort of encouraged it.”

“That’s fucked up, Kel. You know that, right?”

I nodded. It was. “But not really any more fucked up than you going on dates to mess with my head.”

“Fair enough. We’re both nuts.”

“Okay, but here’s the thing, Joanie. This is still an opportunity.”

“Or a cluster-fuck.”

“Right, that too. But I think I can pull it off.... Well... we can. But I need your help.”

She eyed me suspiciously. “My help?”

I nodded. “I know this is going to sound crazy... but if you’re willing to continue punishing me for just a couple of days, I think –“

“Oh, my God, Kel, really?”

“Not if you’re going to hate it... but, if you’re sort of interested in seeing what else you have inside you, then maybe.”

“I’m not sure I understand.”

I smiled. “Joanie. Have you ever been to a strip club?”

CHAPTER TWELVE

As I expected Tanner was up for an afternoon at Sparkles. Actually, he was more enthusiastic than I would have guessed. He didn't even make me explain what I wanted. I filed that away. A small, red flag to keep in mind.

I dressed causally in khakis and a polo, but I had Joanie get a little sexed up in clingy jeans and a tight cropped tee. I suggested she wear nice underwear.

"Is anyone going to be seeing my panties?" she asked, surprised.

I shrugged. "Maybe? That's up to you. Anyway, don't want you feeling underdressed. You're going to be quite a hit."

"With Tanner?"

"With the girls."

"Huh?"

"You'll see."

"So, explain this again to me?"

"We're fighting. You overheard me inviting Tanner to Sparkles and insisted on coming along. You don't trust me in a place like that."

"I don't, you know. Not completely."

"Good, then it won't be a stretch."

"And then I try to steal his phone?"

I nodded. "Yup. You accompany him to the champagne room to watch him get a lap dance. So you can see, you know, that there is no sex in the champagne room."

"Is there sex in the champagne room?"

"Well, the reality of Cody marring the beauty of this lovely planet suggests there may well be."

“He’s not that bad.”

I laughed. “Well, sure, you’d say that now that he’s your boyfriend.”

“He’s not my boyfriend.”

“Lover? Fuck-buddy?”

She smirked. “How about spite bang?”

I continued. “You need to dig around his pocket. Ideally while his pants are down around his ankles. Get his phone. Get it to me. And make sure he’s kept busy for the next thirty minutes, or so.”

“How am I supposed to do that?”

“Well, there will be a stripper or two back there with you. Remember, you’re supposed to be just an observer. But you know that Tanner will try to get you into the mix.”

“And...?”

I shrugged. “Go with the flow. Whatever feels comfortable.”

“This is crazy.”

“Yeah. And it probably won’t work. But it will smooth the process with Charlie if I can pull it off. And worst case, if I get the phone, I can at least try the password enough times to get the phone to lock and wipe the data.”

“How will that help?”

I laughed. “It won’t. But you’re not the only spiteful bitch in the room.”

She shook her head. “You’re a psychopath. Seriously Kellen. Did you torture small animals as a child?”

“Only ants. And my sister.”

I knew Tanner would be into the idea of Sparkles midday because, well, it appeals to me too. Not sure why. I’m so white bread in so many

ways. Always did well in school. Ivy League. Business school. Tailored suits. Married young. Never cheated on my wife.

Yet, I've always been attracted to the seedy. Back in the day, they'd call it slumming. There is something exciting to me about stepping into a dive bar. Dark, the smell of stale beer, the regulars eyeing newbies suspiciously. There is a TV on, but no one is watching. Half the time it is tuned to infomercials. A pool table, a dart board. No one ever plays. No one can be bothered to have fun. A universe of bad choices, regrets, but also of no questions, no expectations.

Strip clubs have the same attraction. Walk in, and you're a new person. No one cares about anything outside the four walls. You want to say your name is Fontleroy and you're an astronaut, and no one will challenge you. The girls all inhabit that same weird netherworld. Identities checked at the door. Tiffany is a student, not a HS dropout with two kids, and a lay about boyfriend. Star is an aspiring actress, not a part-time whore who got kicked out of her home at sixteen. The stories aren't all sad. But they are all stories. A completely artificial world of completely artificial people.

At Sparkles, Tanner wasn't a sad nerd churning deals in a pathetic struggle to get ahead. He was a *playa*. Chicks hanging all over him, at least until he ran out of cash.

He was already there when we arrived.

He eyed Joanie as we joined him. "Bring your own stripper?"

"I'm his wife," she replied hotly.

He smiled thinly.

"You could pass for a stripper," he taunted.

I interposed myself between them. "Joanie's never been to a strip club. She wanted to see what it was like."

And indeed, having adjusted to the dark, she was staring around in amazement. Or disgust. It was a little hard to tell which. Seeing it through her eyes reminded me of the thrill I'd had the first time I'd been to a strip club. Vegas for me. Scads of just drop-dead gorgeous girls in skimpy lingerie. Like dying and going to heaven. Sparkles was a nice place, but not in the same class, and anyway, I think Joanie's interpretation tended more towards Sodom and Gomorrah than heaven... or at least it would have until this past week. Now, I couldn't be sure any longer.

As I had expected, with Joanie in tow, we attracted a lot of attention right away. The relatively few patrons all were quite unabashed in checking my wife out. That's another weird thing about strip clubs. Unlike most places, it is not only accepted, but sort of encouraged to openly ogle women. That includes not just the dancers, but also the wait-staff, and, of course, female patrons.

Even more interesting was the attention we were getting from the dancers themselves. I'm not completely sure why, but strippers love seeing women come into the club. Sure enough, there were a number of girls who seemed like they would just love to eat Joanie up.

Moments after we sat down, a brazen, little blonde plopped herself down in Joanie's lap.

"Hey beautiful, I'm Amber," she cooed.

I recognized her from the other night. The sexy, blond schoolgirl with the plump, pussy lips. Today she was in red hot pants and loose, shimmery, silver-black tunic.

"I'm, ah, Joanie."

My wife was more than a little flustered as the blond twirled a finger in Joanie's hair.

"Fuck, I love Lesbos," Tanner exclaimed.

Both girls gave him a nearly identical scowl, then promptly turned away from him as Amber resumed flirting with my wife.

“You’re shivering,” Amber noted. “Do I scare you?”

Joanie laughed. “A little,” she admitted.

“Never been with a girl before?”

My wife shook her head.

Amber let out a low, excited moan. I was certain she was getting wet just thinking about despoiling my wife. And I was getting hard thinking of her sucking on my wife’s large breasts, Joanie’s fingers sliding between Amber’s wet, swollen lips.

I could hear Tanner smacking his lips behind me, though I couldn’t be sure if it was in excitement or frustration at being left out. Luckily the ratio of girls to patrons was pretty good and soon another couple of girls joined us.

A slender black girl, with short hair, and vaguely sixties, mod look took a seat on my lap.

“Hey brown sugar,” Tanner exclaimed. “What’s wrong with me?”

She seemed a bit put out at his aggressive tone.

“Chill out, man,” I cautioned him.

Happily, almost immediately, a tall, buff brunette, her hair in a Katy Perry ponytail and with a single sleeve of colorful tats pulled up a chair by Tanner.

Tanner confirmed that I was paying, and then ordered a bottle of champagne. Having been around the block a couple of times, I grabbed the waitress before she got away and made sure we were getting the cheapest champagne. It was still \$500 for the bottle, but I knew they had bottles they charged \$10,000 for if you gave them half a chance.

“I’ll take care of everyone,” I let her know, “but don’t fuck me, okay?”

She cast a glance over at Alden wondering she wouldn't do better if it was his party.

"He's a cheap motherfucker when it's on his tab."

She nodded and went away to get a bottle of the cheap stuff.

My girl was chattering in my ear, but I was having trouble paying attention to her. On my left Joanie and Amber were locked in a soulful conversation, staring into each other's eyes, Amber stroking my wife's cheeks tenderly. Joanie shot me an amused look. *What? It's all her*, she seemed to be saying. But whoever was the instigator, it was obvious that Joanie was getting a kick out of being on the receiving end of a lesbian seduction.

On my right, Tanner was expounding loudly to his girl about what a business genius he was. He kept calling her Casey, even though I could swear she'd introduced herself as Lacey. But Casey, Lacey, it didn't really matter. She had a cold, mercenary look in her eyes that only seemed to brighten at the word million.

As in, "Ain't that right, Kel, took you for three million in our last deal."

I gave my best nonchalant shrug, *you win some you lose some*.

My girl had told me her name was Jas, though I wasn't sure if it was Jas as in Jasmine, or Jazz as in, Jazz. I decided to assume the former. Prettier name. She was gently running her fingertip up and down my forearm. Very subtle, yet quite sexy. She had a curious expression as if trying to figure out our party.

"That's my wife," I said, nodding toward Joanie.

"She like girls?" Jas asked with a smile.

"Sure looks that way," I replied. "And that guy, I'm in business with."

"But you don't like him?"

“He’s not very likable.”

“You friends with Amber?” I said nodded toward the stripper who was now reading my wife’s palm.

Jas giggled. “Yeah, she’s fun.”

“What’s the story with Lacey?”

Jas shrugged. “She works here.”

Enough said. Not *she’s a cool chick*. Or even, *she’s hot*. She was trouble. I needed to get rid of Lacey.

The champagne arrived, barely enough for the six of us. I handed over my credit card and ordered another bottle.

I turned to Jas. “Hey, baby, I think you’re super hot, but I need to do a little business before pleasure. Wanna come back around in a bit?”

She looked a little put out that I hadn’t chased away Lacey or Amber, but she nodded. “Sure sweetie, see you around.”

She retreated to the bar. I leaned over and got Tanner’s attention. “Let’s talk a little before we all get too bombed.”

He waved me away. “Case and I are just getting to know each other.”

“We could get to know each other better in the back,” she suggested.

“Now that’s an idea. Pay the lady,” he said.

I smiled. “Just a taste and then we talk.” I turned toward Lacey. “Three dances?”

She started to protest, but I cut her short with a crisp hundred. “Warm him up, he’ll be here all afternoon.”

She led him over to the banquette at the edge of the room and started grinding on Tanner. Joanie’s eyes followed him, but Amber put her hand on my wife’s cheek. *Pay attention to me, baby.*

I slid my chair closer to the two women.

“You two seem to be hitting it off.”

Joanie gave me a quick glance, blushing, then returned her attention to Amber.

“I want to suck on your wife’s tits,” Amber growled throatily.

I laughed. “Yeah, we definitely want to party.”

Joanie was shaking her head a little anxiously. Amber nodding hers confidently.

“You got any other friends working today?” I asked.

“Jas is cool,” Amber replied.

“I mean for my friend,” I nodded toward Tanner. “I think we’ll all have a better time if we all like each other.”

Amber turned toward me. “You’re not just trying to get rid of me, are you?”

I shook my head. “No. You’re with Joanie. I’m with Jas. Just need a cool chick for Tanner.”

She nodded. “Alright. I’ll be right back.”

“You okay?” I asked my wife.

She fanned her face. “She’s a, um, very confident girl.”

“I think you’re her type.”

“I think she’d eat me for lunch.”

“I think that’s the idea.”

Joanie laughed nervously, but I could tell she was turned on.

“What’s the plan?”

“When Tanner gets back we talk a little business. Then Amber and her friend take him... and you... into the back for a little party.”

“And I steal his phone.”

“And give it to Jas, when she comes back to check up on you guys.”

“This isn’t going to work.”

I laughed. “Of course it is. Between Amber’s friend grinding on Tanner and Amber grinding on you, he wouldn’t notice if you gave him a colonoscopy.”

She seemed hesitant.

“In the worst case,” I added, “you can count this as one of your seven dates.”

She frowned and then after a moment laughed. “Well, I was wondering how I could top what I’ve done so far.”

“Believe me, you don’t need to,” I replied.

Before she could respond I noticed Lacey and Tanner walking back in our direction.

“Thanks, give us a few?” I said to her, giving her another twenty.

She shrugged. *Whatever*. It had been a good start to her shift regardless.

“She seems like a cold fish.”

He shrugged, but didn’t dispute it. He’d been checking out Amber’s smoldering seduction of my wife and I knew a mercenary like Lacey wouldn’t be able to hold a candle to it.

“Look, let’s talk some business.”

He chortled. “Shouldn’t you be in Marseilles?”

“Marseilles? Why?”

“You’re too late Kel. Always a day late and a dollar short.”

“How so?”

I didn’t like his attitude. Of course, I never liked his attitude. And it was a little hard to credit his confidence too much. He could easily be bluffing. Still...

He shrugged. “You have another dog of a China deal to pitch?”

“You’re going to regret not getting in on that one.”

He snorted.

“No,” I continued. “I want to talk about the contract clause again. Look, man, you’re burning a bridge with me... over what? What’s your take?”

“Nothing yet,” he admitted.

“We’re young guys man, we’re in this for a long time. How am I supposed to work with you after this?”

“I’m sure I’ll have plenty of opportunities to make it up to you.”

But it was obvious he didn’t care. He’d consigned me to the loser file.

His eyes drifted up over my shoulder, and I followed his gaze to see Amber returning holding hands with a just adorable little brunette. Even in four-inch heels, the new girl was tiny, but she was just gorgeous, wearing fishnets, a tight leather skirt, and black choker. The face of an angel, the body of a high school cheerleader, and dressed like the star of a BDSM porn video.

Amber nodded in Tanner’s direction. The new girl climbed in his lap.

“I’m Riley.”

“Tanner,” he replied.

“That’s a sexy name,” she cooed.

I looked back to see Amber and Joanie giggling together. They’d gone right back to where they were. I saw Jas beginning to head in my direction. I shook my head. *Not yet*. I hoped she got the message and didn’t see it as a dismissal.

“I think I’m in love,” Tanner said. His hands slid over Riley’s slender thighs.

“Love can wait.”

“Nah uh,” he moaned.

This was moving a little faster than I'd hoped. I wanted him a little drunker, sloppier. Still it was promising to see him so smitten. Not surprising, but promising. Riley had that weird slutty innocence about her that most men find irresistible. I had to move fast.

I ordered a third bottle of champagne. "Fuck it. You celebrate. I'll drown mine. You're right, you can make it up to me on some other deal."

He smiled at me, but he wasn't really listening. All he cared about was that I seemed to be done yammering at him.

When the champagne arrived, I stood and dug into my pocket for a tip. I gave a couple of twenties to the waitress. Tanner was still focused on Riley. I fumbled with my own phone and send an email to his work account. Marked urgent from a dummy Gmail account I'd set up last night, with the name of one of the partners in his firm. I wasn't sure it would get through to him.

Sure enough his phone buzzed in his pocket. He pulled it out and saw the alert. With a glass of champagne in one hand and a girl perched in his lap, he held the phone out and typed in a password. It was too fast to catch all of it, but he definitely started up with three quick presses of a number in the top row, then finishing off near the bottom. Seven. Eight. Maybe nine characters.

I went through the list of password ideas I'd come up with. 1-2-3... ABCDEF... CAB... CABOT1999. His high school and graduate date. BINGO.

He scowled at the phone when he pulled up an empty message, but Riley blowing in his ear got him back into the moment.

"So, we gonna party?" he bellowed.

"You're an asshole Tanner. I don't even have a girl with me."

"That your problem."

“Yeah, it is,” I acknowledged. “Alright, how about you four get a private room, and I’ll come on back later once Jas returns?”

Amber and Riley were quickly to their feet, pulling their respective “dates” out of their seats.

“VIP room?” Amber asked, eyebrow raised.

“Yeah, and get more champagne,” I replied.

“Yes sir.” I saw her hand tighten on my wife’s. “Come on, baby, we’re going to have some fun.”

Even in the dark light of the club I could see Joanie redden. And yet, I knew she wanted it as much as Tanner, who was virtually drooling. I just hoped my wife would remember she had an assignment.

I watched the foursome disappear into the back. I cast my glance back around the club. I almost panicked when I couldn’t find Jas. I needed her to recover the phone after Joanie stole it, but if she’d gone back with another customer, I was fucked. I mean, I could find a way back there, but...

... and then I spotted her, eyeing me skeptically from a dark corner behind the bar. I nodded in her direction and smiled.

She approached me.

“What game are you up to?”

“I need your help.”

“Yeah?”

“Yeah. It’s a long, long story.”

She rolled her eyes. “I bet.”

“I need a favor.”

“Yeah, how’d I know you’d say that.”

“It’s for a good cause.”

“Whatever,” she replied, wary and a little annoyed at what seemed to be a game I was playing.

“Look, could you go into the back and check in with my wife? Make sure she’s doing okay?”

“Why don’t we just go back there and join them?”

“It’ll freak her out if I’m there.”

“She really your wife?”

I nodded. “Yeah.”

“And the other guy?”

“Hard to explain. We work together. Look, I know this is weird, and –”

She cut me off, “Baby, you don’t know from weird until you’ve worked in a place like this.”

I laughed. “I bet.... So?”

She hesitated and looked around. She took my hand. “Okay, come on, real quick.”

“What? Huh?” I said as she began dragging me toward the back. “I don’t want my wife –”

“To see you. I know. Trust me.”

She led me up a narrow flight of stairs and then along the balcony overlooking the club. I could see the VIP rooms ahead, dark mirrored glass allowing those inside to look out on the club without being seen from the floor. But before we reached the doors to those rooms, she dragged me behind a thick curtain and hustled me through a narrow black door.

We were in a darkened, narrow hallway.

“Where are we?”

“Shh. Quiet.”

She led me about twenty feet forward, and then we turned right into a second narrow passage. My eyes had started to adjust to the very, very faint red tinged darkness. Up ahead, to my right, the wall itself seemed to be illuminated. As we approached, I realized it was a window, looking into one

of the VIP rooms. Just as they could look out onto the club without being seen, we could see in without being noticed.

“What’s this for?” I whispered.

“In case they need to keep an eye on a party,” she replied softly. “Get a lot of shady dudes through here.”

I was casting about for a jokey response, when I peered into the room and got an eyeful.

Joanie and Tanner were sitting at opposite sides of an ornate, plush canapé. Amber and Riley had both stripped down to their thongs and nothing else. Amber was astride my wife. She seemed to be nibbling on Joanie’s ear and had both hands up under her shirt, obviously playing with my wife’s full breasts. It was a super sexy scene, and it was a little funny watching Tanner having trouble figuring out whether he should be looking at Riley’s tight little ass gyrating in his lap or the two women getting it on just a few feet away.

Amber settled the debate decisively when she leaned back and swiftly pulled my wife’s shirt over her head. As I’d suspected, the little blond had already unsnapped Joanie’s bra, so it was a simple matter for her to yank it off, leaving my wife completely topless. Joanie looked over at Tanner, embarrassed at being exposed to him, but also seemingly helpless before Amber’s lusty assault.

“Holy shit!” Tanner exclaimed as he caught a glimpse of my wife’s tits.

He didn’t have much time to admire them before Amber dived back in, audibly motorboating Joanie’s big boobs before sucking one erect nipple after the other into her mouth.

I realized why Jas had shushed me. Though we were on the other side of glass and there was music playing, we could still hear into the room. It

was muffled, but full-throated conversation was audible.

As Amber continued to lick and fondle Joanie's breasts, she reached down with her other hand and began unbuttoning my wife's jeans. Joanie ineffectually tried to push her away, but the blond stripper was persistent. She peeled open her jeans and thrust her hand down the front of my Joanie's sexy panties. My wife gasped and Amber smiled triumphantly. *Got you, you little slut.*

"Is she wet?" Tanner groaned.

Amber molested my wife a few moments longer and then leaned toward him. "Taste," she growled as she thrust two fingers into his mouth.

I couldn't believe what I was seeing. Tanner was tasting my wife's pussy on another woman's fingers. That small VIP room seemed about ready to combust. Before retreating, Amber and Riley kissed, just inches from Tanner's face. Then suddenly Amber launched herself back toward my wife. Her hand disappearing again into her panties, and the two women now kissing wetly, passionately.

Beside me, I could hear Jas breathing hard. "Your wife likes girls."

"I guess so," I admitted.

"Her first time?"

I nodded.

"Fuck that's hot."

I nodded again. It was.

Tanner benefitted from Riley's excitement at watching her friend play with my wife. I'd noticed her twice before defecting his hands as he tried to reach under her thong, but now she seemed to relent. His fingertip curled beneath the thin fabric at her crotch and slipped inside her.

With Tanner fingerbanging Riley and Amber doing the same to Joanie, the two couples writhed beside each other on the sofa. Then the blonde

escalated things again. Dropping to her knees on the floor, she jerked down my wife's jeans. Joanie's desperate grasp managed to save her panties, but she couldn't keep Amber from stripping her pants clean off. Or maybe she didn't want to. Her protest when Amber lowered her head into my wife's lap was perfunctory at best.

Tanner was now jamming two fingers into Riley's tight little box as she humped his hand, but her moans didn't come close to those of my wife who was squirming as Amber ate her through her sheer panties. For a few long moments, Joanie just seemed to relish it, lying back, eyes closed, her hands running through Amber's blond hair.

Then she shuddered, and I don't know if she came or just came to her senses. But either way, she looked over at Tanner cagily.

"Why is he the only one with his clothes on?" she asked.

Tanner shrugged and the two strippers ignored her. Joanie took the bull by the horns. Flopping over to the side, with Amber twisting to remain between her legs, my wife tugged at Tanner's pants.

"I want to see his cock," she demanded.

Tanner was eager to help out. He fumbled with his belt and zipper and raised his ass off the sofa. Riley moved to help out. Squirming away from Tanner's grasp, she took a hold of his left pant leg even as my wife yanked on the right. His boxers came along for the ride and all bunched up at his ankles. Joanie fumbled down there for a few moments, and I nearly cheered as I saw her extract his phone and stash it beneath the sofa cushions.

I leaned down to Jas, whose own hand had disappeared into her thong. "Now."

She looked up at me, glassy eyed.

"I need you to go check on my wife."

She chuckled. "Baby, trust me, she is more than okay."

“I know. But she has something for me. Please?”

Jas shook her head. “I don’t know what you guys are up to, but...”

“Think of it as a practical joke. Just please. Pop in, get close and ask her if she’s okay.”

She sighed. “Okay.”

She walked slowly along the corridor. I looked back into the room. Joanie had asked to see Tanner’s cock, so I guess she didn’t have any choice but to pay attention to it. Still, it was galling to see his smug grin as he looked down to watch Riley and my wife, face to face on either side of his prick, slowly stroking and discussing his hard on. I was grateful that he didn’t seem bigger than me, but somehow his average size seemed less important than the fact that my wife was inches away from it.

The door of the VIP room opened, and all of them jerked to cover up. They relaxed when they saw it was only Jas.

“Join the party,” Amber cooed from between my wife’s legs.

“Her hubby sent me to check up on her. She seems, uh, to be okay?”

Jas leaned down toward my wife, peering at her curiously.

“Tell him I got it all under control,” Tanner preened.

“I’m fine. We’ll be just a bit longer,” Joanie replied, pressing something into Jas’ hand.

Jas nodded silently and hid the phone against her thigh. “Okay, I’ll tell him.”

“Have them send another bottle of champagne,” Tanner bellowed as the door shut.

I waited anxiously for Jas to return. Back in the room, Tanner seemed eager to restore the mood. He reached out and palmed the back of my wife’s head.

“I think you were in the middle of admiring a real man,” he chimed as he pulled her back toward his lap.

Joanie gave him a exasperated glare, but Amber gave him an assist by shoving my wife forward so that she fell flat on the sofa, her head in his lap. Joanie turned her head toward Amber, but her protest was cut short as the blond again descended on her, spreading her ass cheeks wide and tonguing her vigorously from behind. I couldn't tell if she was licking my wife's ass or pussy, but either way, it seemed to put Joanie in a compliant mood.

She returned her attention to Tanner's rod, twitching proudly at attention. She stroked him up and down several times, even as he tried to thrust it into her mouth. Luckily Riley now joined Joanie with her face in his lap, and my wife seemingly trying to avoid sucking him off eagerly took up the distraction of kissing Riley wetly on the mouth.

“Erm?”

I startled at the sound beside me. Jas with the phone. She handed into me and as I stepped away from the glass, she took up my spot. Her hand again snaked into her thong and she began swaying gently to the barely audible bass coming from the main floor.

I took a deep breath, swiped Tanner's phone, and inputted the password I'd guessed. CABOT1999... and holy shit, it worked. I shook my head in shock. Dumb, brilliant luck.

I opened the email app and was pleased to see I didn't need another password to access his work account. I wasn't too surprised about that. I knew the lazy bastard would have the minimum security in place. I quickly composed the email to Charlie. Short, sweet, solicitous, and to the point. So un-Tanner-like that Charlie would have no choice but to accept that he and I were in cahoots. I sent the email then went into his sent-mail folder and dumped it in the trash. Hopefully he wouldn't notice.

“Um, you might want to see this,” Jas breathed.

I almost put the phone down immediately, except, as I’d gone into his email I’d noticed... something. I went back into his inbox. And there it was. A conversation thread with Alejandro Espinosa. Five emails. I read them over quickly. The bastard had been negotiating with XCOSA for days now. He hadn’t bought my Marseilles diversion for a second. There were a bunch of documents attached, but I couldn’t read them on the small screen. I was tempted to forward them to myself, but couldn’t figure out a way to do that without him finding out. The last email confirmed a meeting. Tanner was flying Alejandro up Tuesday morning. No wonder Alejandro hadn’t responded to my call. He was finalizing a deal already.

“No, seriously, I think you’ll want to see this,” Jas urged again.

I shoved the phone in my pocket and approached the window.

“How’d that happen?” I gasped.

“Amber was eating her ass, and then suddenly she said, something about needing a cock.”

And indeed, despite her earlier reticence about taking him in her mouth, Joanie was now astride my competitor, riding his cock as her big boobs bounced in his face. The other two girls were on either side of him, Riley bent low to suck on one tit, and Amber leaning over and kissing my wife passionately on the mouth even as her hand massaged my wife’s lower back and urged her on.

“Does she usually tell you about it after?”

“Yes,” I replied, thinking of the past week. Then I realized what she meant. “No, we don’t usually do this.”

“But it turns you on?” She didn’t wait for an answer. Instead, she confidently reached out and grabbed my crotch, feeling my hardness.

I nodded, but found I was having trouble speaking. Joanie was no longer kissing Amber. Instead, she had both hands on Tanner's shoulder, riding him briskly, bouncing up and down on his cock. She was looking past him, at her own reflection in the mirror, but we were lined up perfectly and it felt like she was staring straight into my eyes. It was uncanny enough that I had to ask.

"She can't see us, can she?"

Jas shook her head and then slid between me and the glass. She thrust her hard ass against my hard cock. She turned her head and hissed at me over her shoulder.

"You can fuck me if you want... just don't come inside me."

I gaped at her in surprise.

"Do it," she sighed.

Joanie's brow was furrowed in concentration as she got closer and closer. I fumbled with my zipper and somehow freed my cock. I leaned in and without thinking thrust upward. My prick plunged deep into her sopping, wet cunt, pressing her up against the glass. We both looked into the room, worried they might have heard, but they were all too distracted to notice the faint bump.

Jas wasn't taking any chances with me getting her off. She rubbed her clit briskly even as I slowly pumped my cock in and out of her. Like my wife, it seemed that she needed a cock.

Joanie's eyes were closed, head back, gasping as three sets of hands fondled her all over. She growled and shivered as she climaxed, the blood rushing from her head to her sex. Her head lolled and she began to slide out of Tanner's lap.

Amber caught her and eased Joanie down on top of her on the sofa, my wife's head resting on the blonde's belly. Tanner wasn't done though. He

kicked off a shoe and extricated his foot from his pants. With one foot planted on the floor and a knee on the sofa, he straddled my wife's ass. He reached out and grabbed her around the waist and then thrust into her hard from behind.

As he pulled her toward him, my wife's face slid down over Amber's flat belly, her shaved mound, and ended up inches from the blonde's fat, swollen snatch. Amber pulled aside her thong and placed a hand on the back of my wife's head. Joanie hesitated, but just for an instant, before sticking out her tongue and licking Amber's juicy slit.

Jas saw it too and I felt her pussy clench at my cock as she came. Riley sidled over to Amber's side and stared glassy-eyed at my wife eating pussy. She wrapped an arm around her friend and the two kissed. Amber's hand cupped Riley's sex, and then sliding a finger beneath her thong began fingering her in time with Tanner's rough strokes into my wife.

Seeing those three women playing with each other seemed to be too much for him, though. With a moan, he pulled out and shot several thick ropes of come all over my wife's ass and lower back. I wasn't as quick witted, but luckily Jas sensed what was about to happen. She pirouetted on the spot and dropped to her knees, taking my cock into her mouth just as I exploded.

"Oh God," I moaned. "Oh God, thank you."

She swallowed my come like a pro, which I guess she was. She shrugged. "Neater this way. I still have a shift to work."

Jas stood as I awkwardly put away my cock.

"We'd better get out of here," she suggested.

I glanced into the VIP room where the three women were, a little sheepishly, getting dressed while Tanner surveyed his domain like a pasha. God, the guy was about to get even more insufferable.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Sure enough when the four of them returned to our table on the ground floor, the first words out of his mouth were, “You were supposed to get us another bottle of champagne.”

I’d already settled up, leaving big tips for all the girls. Jesus, a five-thousand dollar adventure. I’d overpaid to get that email sent, but the intelligence on the deal in progress with XCOSA was invaluable.

I looked over at Joanie who was looking at me anxiously. I gave her a quick smile and glanced in the direction of his phone. She nodded, looking at least a little relieved.

“I found your phone on the seat.”

“Well, aren’t you just a Helpful Holly?” He put the phone in his pocket and sat down heavily in his chair. “Let’s get another round, and when I’ve recovered,” he winked lewdly at Joanie, “maybe we can have a little more fun.”

“Actually, I think we’re going to have to get out of here,” I replied as Joanie nodded along.

He shrugged. “Whatever. And hey Kellen?” he paused for effect. “Turns out that contract was only the second most valuable thing I’ve taken you for this week.”

I could see the disappointment in his eyes when I failed to rise to the bait. I stood and took Joanie by the elbow and led her toward the door. Amber tagged along.

“You guys okay?” she asked in what seemed like genuine concern.

We both nodded curtly. Amber stepped in close and placed a piece of paper in my wife’s hand. “Call me,” she said as she kissed Joanie on the

cheek.

Joanie turned toward me. “I need to tell you something.”

“It’s okay.”

“You know?”

I nodded. “I have to admit something too. Me and Jas...”

Before I could react, Joanie lashed out at me, her hand catching me flush on the cheek.

After the initial shock, I couldn’t help but laugh. Joanie seemed equally taken aback.

She put her hands to her mouth. “Oh God, did I just do that?”

It wasn’t completely clear to me what “that” actually referred to.

I paused to make sure she wasn’t going to hit me again. And then I took her hand, and gently led her outside... into the bright sunshine of mid-afternoon. Somehow that made all that had just occurred seem all the more seedy.

On the car ride home, Joanie stared out the window with a Thousand Yard Stare. I knew we needed to talk, but for right now, I was just as happy to have time to think as well.

I guess I’d always known the whole XCOSA deal was likely a pipedream. I’d fixated on it because coming at the same moment as the crisis with Joanie, it was something that I felt I could control. As it turned out, that had been an illusion. On the flipside, it also turned out that my problems with Joanie might have been more tractable than I realized. The past week suddenly seemed like a lot of misguided energy and misplaced priorities.

Though I could see Joanie struggling to process things, I knew she'd come around. No, that's not true. I didn't know. I hoped. I don't think I ever quite understood the influence of Joanie's Catholic upbringing. Her parents were very strict. They went to church religiously, one might say. She was named after Joan of Arc after all. By the time we met, she'd rebelled, though in that typically-Joanie low-key way. She didn't reject the Church, she just marginalized it. But it doesn't go away. And now, she was suddenly confronting the reality that maybe, deep inside, she wasn't that nice little Catholic girl.

Or maybe that was just wishful thinking on my part. As crazy as it sounded to actually think it, the truth is, I would do it all over again. My wife having sex with five different men in five consecutive days was, in a strange way, a small price to pay in order to have witnessed, and participated in, that searing scene at the strip club. I just wished we could have gone through all of it as a team rather than as adversaries.

I heard her sob.

"Joanie?"

I was on the highway and couldn't really pull over safely.

"Joanie?" I said again.

"What's wrong with me?" she asked.

"Nothing. God, you're amazing," I gushed.

"Then what's wrong with you?"

I chuckled and saw her scowl out of the corner of my eye.

"I'm not laughing at you. I was just thinking sort of the same thing. But why does anything have to be wrong with either one of us?"

"Jesus, Kellen, really? Because I don't know about you, but I've never considered myself the 'have sex at a strip club' kind of girl."

"What kind of girl is that?"

“A crazy slut?”

“I don’t know why people always use those words together. Why is it crazy to be slutty? And why, by the way, is being sexual slutty in the first place?”

“What are you talking about?”

“Joanie, this all started because I was having a bad day, and like a baby, I just wanted to be comforted. And somehow that made you think I wanted you to be like some of the girls I dated before you.”

“Stacy,” she snorted.

“Right. Stacy. Stacy was a crazy slut. She was crazy. And she was a slut. Separate issues. And yes, I’m not going to lie. I liked that she was a slut sometimes. Just like, I sort of like this over-the-top sexual you, and I can’t believe I am actually saying this, but that’s true even if it means you’re sometimes sexual with other men... or women.”

I glanced over and saw her blush.

“But,” I continued, “only if you sort of like it too. Do you?”

“I shouldn’t. It’s wrong.”

Sinful, she meant.

“But you do?”

“I don’t know.”

I sighed.

“What?” she snapped. “You think this is easy for me?”

“I never said it was....” I took a deep breath. “I don’t want to badger you into saying something you don’t believe. But Joanie, I just don’t know that I could live with the knowledge that you hated everything that’s happened over the past week. That you resented me so much... for moving you here, for working long hours, for the damage to your career, for everything. That you could get so angry at *me* that you’d hurt *yourself*, over

and over, just to spite me. I'm not going anywhere. I love you, and I'll work on fixing things, but if that's where we really are, I am not sure there is anything left to save. I already asked you this, but you didn't answer me. Did you hate all of it?"

She didn't answer right away, but I'd said my piece, and now it was her turn. I could tell she was thinking about it. We drove for several minutes in silence.

In a small voice, she finally answered, "I didn't hate all of it."

My lips twist into a smile, a rush of happiness bloomed in my chest.

"Yeah?"

"I quite enjoyed the hot yoga."

I felt a surge of heat myself as I pictured her, sweating in a darkened studio, her cut, limber instructor churning his cock deep into her virgin ass.

"And, just now," she continued. "Oh God, I had sex with a girl."

I laughed. "Technically two girls and another man."

"That little blonde raped me, you know. I was violated." I could hear the smile in her voice.

"You gonna keep her number?"

"Fuck yeah," she laughed.

I laughed as well.

"And, I know this is going to sound cruel, but I sort of liked teasing you."

"You mean it turned you on."

She hesitated. It was still hard for her to talk about this sort of thing. Guilt is a durable emotion.

"Yes. I... I wanted to hurt you. And God, you were so fucking infuriating about it. But then you'd break, just a little, and I could see I was getting through to you, and it gave me a thrill."

“You like being a bad girl.”

“And I liked rubbing your face in it.”

I didn’t quite know how to respond.

After a moment she continued, “Tanner’s cock felt so good inside of me.”

I jolted.

She laughed. “See, that’s what I mean. Getting that reaction out of you. It’s hot.”

“You know, you’ve always gotten that reaction out of me. You’re so sexy. Sometimes, I get a peek of you, half-dressed, changing, whatever, but I can’t help but imagine a different context. And of course, when we’re making love, when you finally let yourself go, it is... intoxicating.”

“It’s hard for me... it’s always been hard...”

“I know...”

We’d had this discussion once before, sort of. Joanie had blossomed early, too early. Her clothes were always playing catch-up with her body. And there had been an incident. An asshole, probably drunk, had accosted her. Nothing physical had happened. Verbal harassment, but scarring. I don’t think men always realize how deeply their words can wound, especially with young women, insecure, grappling with their emerging sexuality. They may look all grown up, but they remain coltish, vulnerable.

“...but Joanie, you’re a grown woman now. Married –“

She snorted.

“Married,” I insisted, “but not dead. We’re young. We don’t have kids yet. Why not sow a few more wild oats.”

“You said it, Kel, we’re married.”

“So, what, we need to be one those couples who keep everything under wraps until what? We die? The kids are gone and we get into that flabby

over-sixty swinger scene?”

She laughed. “You seem to have thought a lot about this.”

“No, I mean....” I laughed. *Fuck it. Busted.* “Yeah, I guess I have. I go to bed every night with, seriously, the sexiest bitch I’ve ever seen...”

Another snort, but I could tell she sort of liked it.

“...and we’re so... vanilla.”

“I like vanilla.”

“I like it too. I really, really do. But that doesn’t mean we can’t occasionally have other flavors. Strawberry, chocolate, chocolate-chip-cookie-dough. And you want it too.”

“You’re very sure of yourself.”

I laughed. “I saw it.”

The bell rang. “Wait, you were watching us?”

“Yeah, Jas and I were behind the mirror.”

“Oh God, how do you arrange that?”

I shrugged. “Dumb luck. But the point is –“

“And you, what...?”

“I fucked her. I wasn’t planning to, I swear. But you were so hot, and when you climbed into his lap... we couldn’t help ourselves.”

She chuckled. “Ohh, poor baby, just couldn’t help yourself, huh?”

“I don’t think you realize the effect you can have on people. We were all in your thrall. Me, Jas, Amber, Tanner....”

“Awfully convenient, Svengali. Everyone is under my spell, and yet somehow we’re all doing your bidding.”

I opened my mouth to answer, but then stopped. She did have a point. “I am a rock star,” I admitted.

She laughed. “You’re an asshole.”

“That too.”

“Speaking of which,” which paradoxically was her way of changing the topic, “did you get what you wanted?”

I groaned. I suddenly didn’t feel like a rock star. “Yes and no. Yes, I got into his phone. Yay, good news, I have a one point five million line of credit. Bad news is I have nothing to use it on. Fucking Tanner’s already locked up XCOSA.”

I didn’t give her the really bad news. I’d probably committed fraud to get the line of credit. And some sort of cyber-crime in hacking into Tanner’s phone. I’d be lucky to avoid jail time.

“You’re not just giving up, are you?”

We pulled up in front of our house. A townhouse. Three small bedrooms. One and a half baths. A tiny yard. If I shut it all down, I could probably survive professionally. Not at Marston, but somewhere, and we could get on with it, our little, middle-class life.

“I don’t know.”

After a moment, she replied, “I did not screw your boss for nothing.”

“No,” I laughed. “You screwed him to spite me.” But she didn’t laugh. And slowly it got through to me. For five days I had stopped at nothing to win. I had committed blackmail and fraud, I had whored out my wife, and now, suddenly, I was throwing up the white flag. No fuck that. Tanner’s deal with Alejandro was still a proposal. Nothing would be signed over the weekend. I still had thirty-six hours to blow it up and get my own deal out front.

“Hey, Joan, pack your bags. We’re going to Mexico City.”

“What’s in Mexico City?”

“Alejandro Espinosa,” I replied. “He’s actually quite handsome.”

“A handsome Latino, eh?”

I chuckled. “That would make an interesting sixth date, wouldn’t it?”

“I don’t know. I guess we’ll see.”

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Inside our house, Joanie immediately went upstairs to shower. She was probably still feeling the sticky remains of Tanner's come on her ass and back. I let her go first. After all, I'd been licked clean.

I got on my laptop. I had an email from Charlie. He'd received the note from Tanner. He was processing the loan. There were some more papers to sign, and I needed to send him information so he could link the line of credit to my bank account. I took care of that as quickly as possible, and then went upstairs to check on Joanie.

Truth is, I was hoping to do more than check on her. She'd had sex with five different men in just the past five days. That was a run I doubted even Stacy had matched. Stranger still, none of those five men was me, her husband. Even before the craziness, we'd been on a bit of a dry streak. How long had it been since we'd made love? Ten days, two weeks, more? I was planning on fixing that.

The lights were on the bedroom. A good sign. But Joanie was out cold on the bed. She was wearing one of those oversized tee-shirts she usually slept in, but even its tent-like proportions couldn't hide her curves, and of course, ending at mid-thigh it exposed her shapely legs. Her legs were spread slightly, and I couldn't help but sneak a peek, and when I did, I got quite the jolt. She'd apparently taken the opportunity of a shower to shave herself. Normally she kept herself lightly trimmed, but as far as I could tell, she was now completely bare.

I resisted the urge to wake her and find out. She probably needed her sleep. Instead, I covered her up, turned out the lights, and returned downstairs.

I booked up an early morning flight to Mexico City. I wanted to lock it in, not let Alejandro try to talk me out of coming. And then I composed an email to him.

Dear Alejandro:

My wife and I decided to take a last minute trip to Mexico tomorrow, and we'll be spending a night in Mexico City. She's never been. I'd be delighted if you could join us for dinner. I know this is sudden, but she and I are trying to be more spontaneous. I hope you'll be available, even if only for drinks.

Regards,

Kellen

Joanie was the key. I was counting on him being too much of a gentleman to turn down the invitation. I also knew that with Joanie there, he'd be able to deflect business talk. That was fine. It would make him more likely to accept, and anyway, I just needed to get my foot in the door.

Sure even, less than thirty minutes later, he replied.

Dear Kellen:

Yes, of course. I would be delighted to host you and your wife for dinner. Would you like to come to my apartment? We can eat on the terrace and have a lovely view of the city.

Alejandro

Smart of him. Keep it on his home turf. It would prevent me from picking up the tab if we went out. Like this he was clearly doing me a favor. Business is all about leverage, and he wasn't going to give me any. He'd be even harder to handle than Donald or Tanner.

I went upstairs and showered. Joanie was still sacked out, so I went back downstairs. I warmed up some leftovers and had a beer as I pondered the situation.

Tanner had probably clued Alejandro in on the basics of the situation. The facts worked in his favor. I was on the outs at Marston, he was riding high at TKD. Whatever Alejandro felt about us individually, and I didn't really know that either, he knew the importance of personal relationships. Working with Tanner deepened XCOSA's ties with TKD. Working with me would not only cause him problems with Tanner, but also my own firm since I was basically freelancing the deal. Even if my deal was sweeter, it was riskier and probably would provide fewer long-term benefits. If I were Alejandro, I wouldn't sign with me either.

At some point I would also need to deal with the fact that I'd been whoring my wife out. I cringed just thinking those words, but I'd been in denial long enough. Our marriage had gone through a crisis, and instead of trying to make things better, I took advantage of it. Once that really hit her, I doubted she'd be able to forgive me. Or maybe she considered forgiving me penance for her own over-the-top behavior? I didn't know.

Anyway, Joanie wasn't the answer to Alejandro. He was single. In macho Mexico. There would be little or no stigma to having an affair with the beautiful wife of a clueless American businessman. Hell, he could probably brag about it, though from what I knew of him that didn't seem his style.

Ugh. Everything was still such a mess.

I awoke to sound of rustling in the kitchen. I sat up slowly, sore from sleeping on a lumpy couch. I'd fallen asleep still clutching a half-drunk beer. I followed the scent of bacon and coffee and walked in on Joanie.

Kel? You didn't come to bed?"

"I guess I passed out on the sofa."

"Yeah, I guess we're getting a little old to be partying like that."

“We’re not that old,” I replied.

“You haven’t been partying as hard as I have,” she noted.

“What time is it?”

“A little after six.”

“We can’t dawdle. We have a 8:30am flight.”

“Okay, but I need to eat first. I’m starving. What do you want?”

I wasn’t really hungry. My mood had darkened overnight. The guilt over my behavior was eating at me.

“Joanie will you ever be able to forgive me?”

She looked at me curiously. “I was going to ask you the same thing.”

“Huh?”

“Oh Kellen, I’m...” she sobbed. “I’m the one who acted like a baby. Instead of just talking to you, I went out and pitched the fit of all fits. I was so angry, all I could think of was humiliating you.”

“Joanie, I manipulated you. At least you were angry. What I did was in cold calculation. That makes it worse.”

She shook her head. “You were just responding to me. I went first. Nothing you did could justify it. You were an ass. I was a lunatic. And yours was the right response. I wanted you to yell, scream, lose your mind. I’m glad you didn’t.”

“It’s not that easy Joanie. I *did* provoke it.”

Her eyes moistened, but then she laughed ruefully.

“What?” I asked.

“Kel, you’re not going to convince me that what I did was anything short of monstrous. All I can is plead temporary insanity. And worse, your biggest concern has always been that I at least be enjoying myself.”

“That’s just my selfishness. I didn’t want more guilt.” I laughed a little as well. “I don’t know much about this sort of thing, but I think the fact that

we both feel more guilty than angry is a good sign.”

She nodded.

“And Joanie, look, I was just kidding about Alejandro being a sixth date. I mean it, I’m not bringing you along just to sleep with him.”

“Just?” she asked, eyebrow raised.

“I mean, sleep with him at all.”

Even saying that made me feel guilty. Was I really over whoring out my wife? Or had I just calculated that it wouldn’t work?

We both noticed the smell at the same time. She wheeled. “Oh crap, my bacon.” She lift the smoking pan off the stove.

I laughed. “There, another thing for me to feel guilty about.”

“I’m the one who burnt it.”

“I’m the one who distracted you.”

She laughed. “You’re right, Kel, it is all your fault. Now, if you’re not going to eat, why don’t you go take a shower and pack before you find more of my mistakes to take credit for?”

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

We had to fly through Dallas and that unfortunately entailed a lengthy layover. I'd booked us business class, so it was pretty comfortable, but it was still long. We didn't talk very much. I think we were both still trying to make sense of everything.

My guilt kept growing. It wasn't just that I'd provoked it and whored her out, it was also that I was sort of glad it had happened. I liked the new, sexually adventurous Joanie. I knew it was wrong to want that. You're supposed to love a person as they are, not as you'd like them to be. Aren't you?

Joanie seemed lost in thought as well most of the trip, but on the final leg into Mexico City, I caught her at one point looking out the window with a cute, little smile on her face. I wanted to tap into that light, to break my sense of gloom and darkness.

"What are you smiling about?"

"Oh, nothing," she replied.

"Oh, um, okay."

She hesitated. "You really want to know?"

"Yeah?"

"I was thinking about yesterday."

"At the club?"

"Uh huh."

A surge of guilt. I'd had my wife screw that asshole Tanner Alden just so I could get a hold of his phone. But she was still grinning.

"You liked it," I suggested.

She nodded. "Do you know which part I liked best?"

I thought of Jas's words, *Amber was eating her ass, and then suddenly she said, something about needing a cock.*

"Was it when you climbed into his lap?"

She regarded me thoughtfully as if considering it. Then she shook her head. "No, after. When he was taking me from behind, and I was, ah...."

She couldn't seem to actually say it. "Giving Amber oral?"

Joanie blushed a deep red. She gave me a quick nod. "I've never understood what you get out of doing that to me."

"It's the reaction."

She smiled. "I know that now. It was amazing to see her writhing around like that. So exciting to see how excited I got her. And... and she was so smooth."

"Is that why you shaved?"

A look of shock.

I shrugged. "Sorry, I caught a peek when I was tucking you in."

"Caught a peek, huh?"

My turn to blush.

"But yes," she answered. "Think you'll like it?"

"I know I will. Just wait until I get you into the hotel."

Unfortunately, once we got to the hotel, there was no time. Between getting through immigration and the appalling traffic, we barely had time to shower and change before we had to go. I did get another quick peek as she slipped on her matching, black bra and panties, but that would have to do until we got back tonight. She wore a simple black dress, cut a little lower than most of her clothes, showing off a little cleavage. The kind of dress I hadn't given her much of an opportunity to wear recently.

The taxi brought us to his home, a 1950s apartment building in Palanco opposite Parque Lincoln. Alejandro was doing even better than I had realized. It gave me a little hope. A man who could afford an apartment here might be secure enough to take a risk on a young, hungry partner.

As we walked through the front door, a gorgeous young woman came out. For a moment, she gave me a start. She was almost a spitting image of the brunette stripper from yesterday, Riley. She even wore a similar choker around her neck, though hers was adorned with a small golden loop. Flashing, dark, nearly black eyes. Red lipstick. As she squeezed past us, I caught a whiff of her perfume, intoxicating, smoky and a little spicy.

Joanie caught me looking at her and gave me a little jab to the ribs. I shrugged. *Sorry*.

When we got upstairs and Alejandro opened the door, I had to suppress a laugh. I hadn't smelled her perfume. The scent was the same as coming from his kitchen. Well, I had to admit, he had good taste in housekeepers.

He waved Joanie in and shook my hand as I followed.

"Alejandro, this my wife, Joanie. Joanie, Alejandro."

He smiled at her and shook her hand. He was taller than I'd remembered, although part of that was his perfectly tailored, grey suit that accentuated his lean frame. Cleanly shaved with salt and pepper hair, he looked vaguely aristocratic, although he dispelled that a gregarious tone and an easy laugh.

"I'm so delighted you were available for a social visit," he said.

He didn't stress the word *social*, but nor was it possible to avoid the connotation.

I laughed. "Yes, indeed, I need a break from talking or thinking about business," I replied.

That seemed to set him at ease.

“May I offer you a drink?”

“Yes, please,” Joanie replied.

He smiled and took her elbow, leading her out on the terrace, where there was a dinner table set for three and a bottle of champagne chilling.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

We had a delightful evening. We ate dinner. The food itself was a little bland, but the wine was delectable.

Alejandro was a gracious host. His rich, baritone, voice, English tinged with a soft Mexican accent. He told us about his life. Wealthy parents, youthful dabbles into leftist politics, travel and finally business. He'd been with XCOSA almost twenty years and seen it boom after NAFTA was signed, with factories and assembly plants lining the border.

He and Joanie had a long conversation about her work.

"I always dreamed of writing," she told him. "But I'm thinking maybe I need to do something else."

She'd never told me that. But then again, when was the last time I'd given her a real chance to talk about her career?

"No, don't, you're too young not to follow your passions."

"Ah, but what if I don't have the talent?"

"Talent follows passion, does it not?" He smiled. "Anyway, I am quite sure Kellen would prefer you be happy over anything else."

I nodded. "That's true."

She looked at me hard. "You don't always seem that way. Not about being happy, but I mean about the writing."

"I know. I need to be more supportive."

Though right now, I didn't know if I could actually support us financially enough to be genuinely supportive of her non-lucrative career. We both went silent. This was yet another discussion we'd been avoiding but really needed to have.

Alejandro laughed, dispelling the tension. “There, it is settled. And now, some port?”

I excused myself to go to the bathroom, feeling suddenly gloomy again. A lovely evening, but the cost of the trip suddenly weighed on me. Why were we here? I had told Joanie this wasn’t about her sleeping with Alejandro, but in the back of my mind I knew I had brought her along to keep that as an option. Just a sick thought, but I couldn’t help myself.

After peeing, I lingered a little to get myself back in a social mood. I glanced at his bookcase. I always loved the way a wall of books looks in a home, and even more the insights it provides into the character of your hosts. In a few years, you won’t even see bookcases, a person’s interests now hidden away as zeros and ones in some portable device.

Alejandro seemed to read mostly fiction, though I didn’t recognize most of the books. A whole work of Spanish-language literature that I barely knew existed. As I scanned the shelf, I noticed a small, dog-eared book at the end of one shelf. Clearly a favorite. I pulled it out partly.

Justine by the Marquis de Sade. I chuckled. Well, well, our host had some exotic tastes. And then it hit me. The housekeeper with her choker... or was it a collar. I remembered something else. By the door. I turned and approached. Yes. On a hook behind the coat rack, a thin, leather dog leash. But I hadn’t seen any sign of a dog.

I peered back out at Alejandro speaking to my wife. There was something about him that exuded confidence, power. He was wealthy and handsome, but there was more. The kinky bastard was into bondage and domination.

I sat back down with them and sipped my port. Like the wine it was delicious. The relatively lesser quality of the food hinted that Alejandro hadn’t hired his housekeeper just for her housekeeping skills. He might be

willing to make some trade offs in return for a quality submissive.
Leverage.

I looked at Joanie. My precious little innocent Catholic girl. Feeling so guilty about the past week. I could also tell she liked Alejandro. He was handsome, stylish, interesting.

I know I should have taken her aside, clear it with her. But I knew I couldn't. I wouldn't be able to say the words. And anyway, I didn't want to talk her into it. It had to be her idea as much as mine.

"Are you okay honey?" she asked.

I looked from her to our host and back again. I hesitated. Was I really going to do this?

"Actually, no." I turned to Alejandro, who was now looking at me curiously. "Alejandro, I hope you don't mind if I discuss something personal with you."

I didn't give him a chance to shoot me down. I plowed on. "Joanie and I have been having some problems. It's why we decided to get out of town at the last minute. I thought a change of location would help, but I've been thinking and I realize that all we've done is take our issues on a plane ride."

"I am not sure what I--" he began.

"You're a worldly man. Experienced. You're not married, but I can tell you understand women. Maybe that is why you're not married?" I proposed.

He looked equal parts surprised and intrigued.

"I know you've suggested that I should support my wife. And I try, but does she not owe me some respect as well?"

"I respect you!" Joanie insisted.

"Is that why you sleep with other men?"

She blushed a deep red. She asked, "Kellen, what is this all about?"

There was a rawness to her response that let him know this was for real.

I gave her a quick wink.

“She doesn’t respect me,” I continued, “because I’ve never properly disciplined her.” I saw his nostrils flare at that, just for a moment. His gaze shifted to my wife, suddenly fiery. “I’ve failed her. I’ve been too soft.”

She just stared at me like I’d grown a second head.

“It is not about softness,” Alejandro said. “It is sometimes hard to do what is necessary to those we love.”

“Can you help me?”

“What’s going on?” she demanded exasperated.

I gestured resignedly in her direction. *See what I mean, I can’t control her.*

He shifted his gaze from me to her. “Is this true, Joan? Have you been cheating on your husband?”

She shot me an annoyed glance.

He snapped his fingers. She returned her attention to him.

“I asked you a question,” he noted.

She turned to face him and drew herself up proudly, almost as if making my point for me. Her chest heaved, her cleavage seeming to pulse with adrenaline. She didn’t answer immediately. I noticed that he didn’t feel the need to repeat himself, doing so would be a sign of weakness. Finally she broke down.

“Yes,” she replied meekly.

“Do you regret it?”

I could see her eyes twitch, wanting to look again at me, but she didn’t. Her gaze remained locked on his.

“Yes.”

“Why did you do it?”

“I was angry.”

“A tantrum?” *Are you a naughty child who needs to be punished?*

She nodded.

He inclined his chin in her direction.

“Yes,” she replied.

He seemed to consider that for a moment. Then he turned back toward me. “Do you understand what you’re asking?”

“Yes,” I replied.

“Well, I don’t,” Joanie snapped. “What are you two talking about?”

“Are you familiar with the notion of the confessional?”

“Yes, I was raised Catholic,” she replied.

“But you do not partake of the Sacrament any longer?”

She shook her head a little awkwardly. “Only on Easter and Christmas.”

He nodded as if he’d expected an answer like that. “Your husband is asking me to hear your sins and then,” his eyes flashed, “devise an appropriate punishment.”

“I still don’t...” and she got it. “Oh.”

She looked over at me in shock. I gave her a small nod that seemed to do little to reassure her. Still, I could see she was intrigued.

“What kind of punishment?” she asked.

“That is for me to determine and you to suffer.”

I tried to read her expression, but I couldn’t be sure. Was she angry? Excited? Intrigued? Frightened? All of the above? None?

“Come,” he said firmly, and I noticed he’d gotten to his feet and was towering over us. “We should go inside away from the chill.”

He stood above my wife, his hand held out. She looked from him to me, and then slowly, tentatively took his hand and rose from her seat. Then with his hand on her lower back, he confidently led her inside. I followed after.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

He closed the French doors behind us. I drifted over to Joanie who was now shivering slightly. Alejandro walked over to a large wooden chest, and removed a item from the top drawer. He handed it to me. A black, leather choker, with a small golden ring, identical to the one worn by his housekeeper.

“If you want this,” he said to me, “prepare her for me. Strip her and collar her.”

He sat down in a comfortable leather armchair and observed.

“Yes, Alejandro,” I replied.

I turned back to my wife. She gave me an imploring look. *Are you sure you want to do this?*

For your guilt, I mouthed. She hesitated for a moment and then gave me a quick nod. I was sure Alejandro had seen, that he’d judge me for my weakness in requesting her assent. But then again, he already knew I was too soft with her.

I gave her the collar to hold. She fingered the soft leather nervously. My own hands trembling, I reached out and pulled her dress off her shoulders, dramatically increasing the amount of visible cleavage. Joanie was breathing hard, face flush.

I walked around behind her, both so I could reach her zipper more easily, but also so that Alejandro could see her face, her breasts as I stripped her. I was giving her to him, but I wanted to see his expression, his admiration as he first saw my wife’s perfect, naked body.

I slowly pulled down the zipper of her dress. Joanie shuddered as she felt the fabric loosen around her, then begin to sag. Her hands twitched as

she struggled to resist the temptation to catch it before it slid off completely. She managed to stay still, and then with a sudden whoosh, the dress flowed downward, pausing for just a moment at her hips, and the pooling down around her feet. She gasped and shivered.

I helped her step out of the gown. She was now just in her black bra and panties, and her heels. I admired her gorgeous, hard, round ass from behind, but Alejandro had the better view being able to take in the entire sweep of her body, her slender legs, flat stomach, her large breasts almost overflowing her bra, her beautiful face, excited, nervous, embarrassed all at once.

My hands trembled as I reached for her bra clasp. I couldn't believe I was doing this. How had we gotten to the point where I was willingly, enthusiastically even, stripping my wife for another man? He would discipline her, but I knew he would also take his pleasure. Once she was nude and collared, she'd be his to do with as he wished.

I pulled her shoulder straps to the side, and I unsnapped her bra from behind. I held it taut for a moment, letting the anticipation build. She seemed to be holding her breath. I finally released the straps, and her bra slid off, falling to her feet. She couldn't stay her hands this time. Instinctively, they flew up to cover her big boobs.

I reached around and took her hands in mine, and firmly pressed them back against her sides. Then I reached up and cupped her breasts in my hands, displaying them to him. I circled her nipples with my fingertips, and felt them stiffen at my touch. When I released them, they remained erect, swollen. I knew he was seeing now some of the most perfect breasts in his life. The thought filled me with a weird pride.

She knew what was coming next, but she still gasped as she felt me squat down and place my hands on her ass. I could smell her arousal, and

bending lower, I could see a spot of shiny wetness on her panties. I took a hold of the sheer fabric, and slowly, slowly began to pull it down. I remembered suddenly that she'd shaved for me, feeling a spike of jealousy that the first man to get a really good look at her newly bare snatch would be Alejandro rather than me. As her panties reached her ankles, she lifted one foot, then the other to let me slide them off. I tossed them, along with her bra onto her dress.

“Do you want her barefoot?” I asked.

“No, she can keep on her heels.”

I nodded and stood. Circling around to face her, I couldn't help but admire her body, note her excitement. Her nipples remained erect, her breasts heaved, her face flush. She handed me the collar and I fastened it around her neck, as she licked her lips. I stepped back to admire her. A sex goddess. Transformed from my sweet, innocent wife into the woman I'd always fantasized lurked within.

I heard his footsteps behind me.

“Leash her, please,” said Alejandro.

I turned and he handed me the thin, black, leather leash I'd seen earlier. I took it from him and attached it to the collar around my wife's neck. He changed out of his suit jacket into a loose fitting, satin smoking jacket that might have been stolen from Hugh Hefner's closet. Somehow it worked on him.

We exchanged a quick glance. Nothing profound passed between us, but maybe that was the point. This was just an experience, an experiment, a form of adult play. Or maybe I was the only one thinking that. Maybe Joanie was just in shock. I wouldn't know until later.

I faced Alejandro. He held out his hand to me. I looked at the leash in my own palm. Once I handed it over, she would be his, until he decided to

release her. I handed him the leash and watching his fist close on the soft leather.

I stepped back, retreating from them, and as I did, the room seemed to darken, just a spotlight illuminating them, as if on a stage. I was suddenly nothing more than a spectator, the fourth wall rising up, separating me from them. I was tempted to sit in his armchair, but somehow that seemed wrong. Instead I found a different seat in an upholstered, hardback dining room chair, which further contributed to the feeling of being at a play.

He gave a quick yank on the leash, just enough to get her attention. She edged closer to him. He reached out with his free hand. She flinched slightly as he cupped her breast, but his touch was gentle. His thumb encircled her engorged nipple. Even in her heels, he was much taller than her, and with her naked and him clothed, he seemed even more dominant.

“You’re quite a beautiful little pet.”

He rolled her nipple between his thumb and forefinger. She squirmed at his touch.

“Be still,” he commanded.

She stiffened, even as he continued to play with her nipple, now pulling on it, elongating it, lifting up her heavy breast.

“But you’re sinful.”

He slapped downward hard, two fingers catching her nipple with a loud smack.

“Owww!”

She backed away, but he brought her back with a quick yank on the leash.

“Oh, yes,” he continued. “Sinful. Pride!”

He smacked her nipple again.

“Oww!”

“Yes, pride. You think your beauty is enough that you can do whatever you want. And you’ve been right. Until now. Wrath!”

Another quick, two finger slap on the nipple.

She cried out again.

“You let your anger carry you away in self-indulgence. Lust!”

Another smack. She whined in pain.

“You are sinful, girl, and you must atone for your sins,” he thundered.

“You must be scourged until you repent.”

He reached into his pocket and pulled out a wooden clothespin. With a quick movement, he reached out and clamped it on her already battered nipple. She howled in pain and reached to remove it, but he caught her hands and easily held them away from her body until she submitted, her arms going limp and dropping to her side as he released her.

“Cross your wrists behind your back,” he ordered.

She hesitated and he flicked at the clothespin. She hissed, but complied with his demand. As he walked around her, he trailed his fingers over her trembling body.

“This is for your own good,” he said.

He withdrew a long, silk scarf from another pocket and wound it around her wrists. He tied the ends together in a firm knot. He circled back around, again casually touching her. He grabbed the clothespin.

She looked up at him, red-faced and gasping.

“Are you ready to confess your sins?”

She nodded.

“Speak.”

“Yes.”

“Yes?” he eyed her expectantly.

“Yes.... Father.”

I saw a twinkle in his eye, but he managed to keep a straight face. Still, he was clearly pleased at how quickly she'd taken to it. He released his grip on the clamp. She relaxed visibly.

"I am prepared to confess my sins," she replied.

"You've committed adultery?"

She nodded. "Yes, Father...."

He read the incompleteness of her answer. "More than once?"

"Yes, Father, with five men and one woman."

He paused as he seemed to consider that. Then suddenly he reached out and sharply twisted the clothespin still fastened to her nipple. She cried out.

"You know you must be punished," he said, still grasping the clothespin.

She eyed the clamp warily. "Yes, Father," she gasped.

Another small twist. She groaned and shuddered. A drop of sweat ran from her hairline down the side of her face.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

“Tell me about the first one,” Alejandro ordered.

Joanie nodded. “It was our neighbor. I was angry at my husband. I wanted to hurt him. I went the across the street and knocked on the man’s door. I offered myself to him. I offered to satisfy him orally.”

He seemed to consider that. “Show me.”

She hesitated. He twisted the clothespin. She yelped.

“On your knees, harlot,” he thundered, “and show me how you abased yourself for this man.”

He yanked down on the leash and she sank to her knees. She watched in some combination of anxiousness and anticipation as he slowly lowered his zipper. With great deliberation, he slowly pulled out his prick. Tormenting her had chubbed him up, but he was far from hard. He was very big already, thick, and I suspected that when fully erect he’d be even larger than Donald. I wondered if Joanie would be able to handle him, and I felt a surge of excitement as I realized that leashed and bound she’d have no choice but to try.

He ran his fingers through her thick, dark hair, tenderly for a moment before suddenly seizing a clump in his fist. Her pained whine turned into a surprised yelp as he pulled her forward, off-balance. With her hands tied behind her, she was totally at his mercy. He pulled her face into his crotch.

To my surprise, and I think his as well, she easily took his fat tool deep into her mouth. Our neighbor, John, seemed to have done a good job with her. I could hear my wife slurping wetly on Alejandro’s cock as he looked down at her with increasing affection. When he pulled her upright by the hair, his long, thick cock slid out of her mouth, gleaming with her saliva.

She looked up at him submissively and, as he stepped forward, she again opened wide to accept him.

There was something about her that was different, a new eagerness to please. When he let his prick dangle before her, she reached out with her tongue to lick his cock head. He alternated between face fucking her, with long, slow strokes that must have reached her throat, and interludes where he allowed her to gently suckle him, her cheeks hollowed out, her tongue swirling on his shaft.

I could tell he was getting close. His thrusts were harder. Joanie gagging on his big prick, looking up at him with tears in her eyes, but never giving up or trying to squirm away. He pulled out.

“Open your mouth, but don’t swallow,” he instructed.

She gave him a quick nod and opened wide, flattening her tongue out over her teeth. He stroked himself once, twice, and then began coming into my wife’s mouth. She flinched, but he held her firmly in place as he drained his load. She looked up at him expectantly, her mouth full of his come.

“Not yet.”

She was breathing hard through her nose. Saliva mixed with come began to drool out of the corners of her mouth, tracing the line of her chin, forming drops that dripped onto her big, heaving breasts.

He eased her back onto her heels and deliberately returned his cock to his trousers. When he’d zipped up, he gave her a quick nod.

“You may partake of me,” he said. And like a good little Catholic taking her wafer at communion, my wife swallowed his come with a loud gulp.

He yanked her to her feet by the leash. She stumbled a little, but he caught her. When she was standing, his hand reached out for the clothespin. She winced and shuddered. He played with her trepidation, handling the

clamp in a way that must have sent twinges of pain through her nipple, but which hinted at much worse. Then finally, with a small smile, he pinched it open and removed it.

She breathed a sigh of relief as I gaped at her nipple, which was now a dark, purplish red, and more swollen and distended than I'd ever seen it. He cupped her breast and his thumb circled her wounded nipple, which judging by her reaction was equal parts soothing and painful.

“Your adultery was not only oral, was it?” he asked.

“No Father. I also let men have sex with me.”

“And the next man, who was he? And how did he have you?”

She shuddered before answering, knowing her punishment would be severe. “It was Kellen’s half brother, and he bent me over a table and took me from behind.”

CHAPTER NINETEEN

I raised the glass of bourbon to my lips. My hands were trembling. That was why I was having the bourbon. To calm my nerves.

I was sitting in the bar at the Intercontinental. I'd just left Joanie and Alejandro back in his apartment. He'd bent her over his heavy, mahogany dining room table.

He had her detail the rest of her encounter with John, and then the specifics of her time with Cody. The whole time, he ran his hands over her, gently, but ominously, in a way that made her tremble with expectancy.

Then, when she was done, he walked over to an armoire. Withdrawing a key from his jacket pocket, he unlocked the heavy wooden doors. Inside was a veritable arsenal of tools of discipline and pleasure.

Joanie glanced over her shoulder anxiously as he removed first a flail, then a riding crop. He seemed to contemplate them, though I suspected he was merely taking the opportunity to let Joanie see them. He returned them to their hooks and then withdrew a heavy, wooden paddle, dotted with holes to allow the air to pass through and the paddle to swing smoothly.

He approached my shivering wife and again caressed her beautiful, unmarked ass. Then without hesitation he drew back the table and swung it hard. The wood made contact with her flesh with a thunderous clack. She cried out in pain. When he lowered the paddle, I could see her butt was already bright red.

Alejandro turned toward me, acknowledging me for the first time since he'd taken the leash from my hand.

"This is going to take a long time. Perhaps it would be best if you left her with me for now."

I looked at my wife, writhing against the table in pain, her breath coming in ragged gasps. But despite the abuse, I could see that she was still very excited. Her bare pussy swollen and glistening.

I nodded.

“When are you leaving?” he asked.

“We’re staying another night.”

He inclined his head in thought. “Then I will return her tomorrow night before dinner.”

He returned his attention to her. “Yes, my sweet, we have much work to do, and only a limited time to do it.”

I had been dismissed, and suddenly it felt like I was intruding on a private moment. I rose quickly and let myself out the front door. As I approached the elevator, I heard another resounding smack, another loud yelp of pain from my wife.

I downed my drink in one quick gulp, relishing the burn in my throat and the immediate rush in my head. I ordered another.

I slept fitfully and woke up at dawn. I changed into my running attire and took off through the streets of Mexico City, watching them slowly come to life on that Monday morning as I logged the miles. My chest burned from the altitude, and my lack of fitness. That was another thing I’d been neglecting recently. Whatever else happened, I knew I would need to find a way to restore balance to my life.

Every few minutes I thought about Joanie, and every time I quickened my pace, driving out those thoughts with the burn of my exertion. It was my own form of punishment, but also practical. I wanted to have those

discussions about our past, our present, our future, together. At least as far as she was concerned, I was done with scheming on my own.

The day dragged by slowly, and my intention to keep my wife out of my mind until she returned repeatedly faltered. I kept returning to the image of the armoire full of implements of discipline but also of pleasure, because in addition to the whips and restraints, there were also dildos, plugs, vibrators, oils, and lotions. I knew from the way he'd tenderly caressed her, before, after, the slaps and the paddling, that at any given moment he'd be pleasuring her rather than punishing her. Indeed, I knew that was essential. The juxtaposition between pain and enjoyment the essence of the game.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Mexicans eat meals late. So when he said he'd return her by dinner time, I knew it would well into the evening before they returned. Indeed, it was already dark when he called to let me know they were on their way.

I wait for them in my hotel room. There was soft knock on the door, and I let them in.

Alejandro was his usually dapper self. Joanie looked a little frumpy, wrapped up in one of his coats over her dress. Her expression was inscrutable. She was tired, but oddly radiant.

"She's been disciplined," he explained, "but not broken. If you want that, it will take more time."

I nodded. I didn't actually want her broken.

He made a show of transferring her back to me. He handed me the leash, and it fell to me to detach it and then remove her collar. Even still, when she asked, "May I take a shower, it was directed at him rather than me."

He deferred to me.

"Of course, honey. Shower. I'll buy Alejandro a drink downstairs and say goodbye for us."

She nodded, but she shot him another quick glance, and I knew there would always been a bond between them.

Downstairs, in the bar, over martinis, I made my last ditch gambit.

"Thank you Alejandro. I trust it wasn't too tedious."

He smiled. "It had to be done."

"Indeed. But now that you've done me a favor, I feel like I need to do one for you."

“There is no need, I assure you.”

“Yes, but I want to.”

There was an awkward moment where he seemed to contemplate that. I knew he was not the sort of man who’d acknowledge the real nature of the transaction, that I’d allowed him to play with my wife, and now he owed me. But that was okay. I didn’t need the acknowledgement. I didn’t want it, actually. I was dealing with enough guilt without making things explicit. But what I did need was for him to accept the fiction and let me proceed, not just to humor me, but to genuinely entertain my offer.

He considered it, and then with a smile, he gestured for me to proceed.

I didn’t begin with the money. I began with the concept. I’d been honing this in my mind all day. It wasn’t a pitch I fully accepted myself, but it was one I would like to accept. The man I wanted to be rather than the man I was.

I told him of my dissatisfaction with the Marston model. Deals for the sake of deals. Skimming a percentage off the top of other people’s work. Yes, we provided a service. It was valuable; it deserved to be rewarded. But it didn’t need to be honored. Even worse were the TKDs of the world. Bottom-feeders, living off the misfortune of others. And then instead, I spoke of XCOSA. Of their dozens of factories and thousands of workers. Of the tangible goods they produced.

Even as I spoke, I could see his interest deepen. I felt a rush. Leverage. In my mind, I was already thinking through how to adjust the offer I had in mind, make it less generous, squeeze out every last dollar. I shook that off. No, I’d stick to the deal I’d originally worked up.

I offered it up. A new partnership. A relationship. My money up front, not only as good faith, but also recognizing the risk of working with

someone striking out alone. The deal would be advantageous to him. That was fine. He could make it up to me later.

He nodded, then asked, “And what of Joanie?”

I was tempted to offer her up to seal the deal. Hint at her continued availability to him. It was a dark thought, and it shamed me as how insistent it was in my mind.

I shook my head. “She’s not part of this. I think we’re now past our marital problems.”

He smiled. It was what he wanted to hear. “Send me the proposal and I will review it.” He rose. “It was a pleasure to see you again, Kellen, and a delight to meet your wife.”

We shook hands and he left.

I went back upstairs. I walked into our room as Joanie came out of the bathroom, wrapped in a white, fluffy bathrobe. She stopped short and our eyes met. I took a step toward her, then stopped when I saw her reach for the sash on the robe. Slowly, deliberately she untied the belt. She shrugged and the robe slipped off her shoulders, falling to the floor.

I gasped. She was covered in marks. Her left nipple, where he’d placed the clothespin was swollen, dark red. Purplish stripes over her right breast. Ligature marks at her wrist and ankles. She turned and I gasped again. Up and down her spine and on the back of her thighs were angry, red bands. Her ass was blotchy, bruised.

She turned back around to face me. I wanted to take her in my arms, console her, apologize. And then I noticed the gleam in her eye, saw the corners of her mouth twitch as she tried, unsuccessfully to suppress a smile.

“You enjoyed it.”

It was a question. An observation. A fervent wish. Yes, really. I wanted her to have enjoyed it. Just as I hoped she'd enjoyed her time with John... and Cody... and Raj... and Donald... and Tanner... and Amber. Because, and here's what I had come to realize, that it wasn't about getting the better of my wife, it was about bettering her life.

She nodded.

"Yeah?" I asked.

"Yeah."

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

We didn't make love that night. Not in the traditional sense. Instead, she described her twenty hours with him. The pleasure and the pain, although it wasn't as if the two were distinct. They blurred, intertwined, as she told it.

The paddling transitioning into a loving massage of her ass, his strong hand slowly working its way between her legs, into her wet and expectant pussy. The way he'd spanked her hard just as he felt her climax. The burning agony in her shoulders as he pressed her bound arms upward, forcing her hard onto the table, his huge cock suddenly penetrating her from behind.

Then when she told him about Raj, and he'd hung her by her wrists and forced a fat plug into her butt. He'd gagged her and left her like that. An hour, maybe more, until her hands went numb and her back and shoulders burned in agony, as the ball gag muffled her screams. Then he'd returned and attacked her clit with a Magic Wand until she came in a writhing, gasping orgasm, the pain in hands, arms, and shoulders somehow feeding the strength of the climax.

Onto his bed. Bound again, both ankles and wrists. Face down. Still gagged. He'd fucked her ass. Pausing to stripe her back and legs with a riding crop. Then resuming his anal assault, coming deep in her ass, leaving her tied up as his semen slowly leaked out.

Finally untied, he'd let her sleep, but only for an hour or two. Then he'd woken her and forced to continue her confession. Legs held apart by a spreader bar, he slapped her pussy and her stomach as she told of screwing Donald.

More humiliation followed. Naked, leashed, blindfolded, he walked her around his apartment on her hands and knees, assigned her Our Fathers and Hail Marys for each sin she confessed from her time at the strip club, spanking her raw ass with the leash if she paused or hesitated.

There was more. Things she couldn't or wouldn't share, but I read them in the gaps in her story and the unexplained bruises and sore spots.

I ordered room service and fed her. Lotioned and soothed her wounds. She fell asleep in my arms, and I didn't wake her, even as my own body revolted, pins and needles in my limbs, my back and neck becoming stiff.

I had to give Alejandro credit. The man knew what he was doing. He's marked her up impressively, but the wounds weren't deep, and by the time she woke up the next morning, all that remained were the stripes on her back, and even those were fading nicely.

"You're almost as good as new," I remarked.

She rolled her eyes. "There is not an inch of me, inside or out, that isn't still sore."

"Well, you did need to be punished."

"I did," she admitted.

"And now the guilt is behind you?"

"Of course. I confessed. Did penance. And received absolution. Of course, in the real world, all I did was add sacrilege to my sins –"

"The real world?"

"You know what I mean. I don't think Alejandro is really a priest... at least I hope not."

"So, still feeling bad?"

She shook her head. "Actually no. I can't explain it, but I do feel like I paid for my sins."

"They weren't sins. Or at least, shared between us."

She nodded.

"I still feel I need to make things up to you," I added.

"I'd think that knowing your wife is a dirty slut who's been had by almost all the men in your life would be punishment enough for you."

"As I've said, it would only be a punishment if I knew you regretted it, and I think you don't. At least not most of it."

"You're weird. You know that, right? It's supposed to be the other way around... or something. You're not supposed to be okay with me having pleasurable sexual experiences with other men... people. I cheated on you, and --"

I shrugged. "The only thing I regret of what I did, well, besides the sense that I pushed you into things, is what happened with Jas at the club."

She hesitated and then laughed. "Kellen, you don't regret any of it."

I began to respond, but she cut me off.

"You don't do regret. You're pure Id. You get what you want or you don't. And this," she waved her arms around to indicate everything that had happened, "is what you wanted. That's why you're okay with it. Not because I enjoyed it, but because you've always wanted me to be more like your slutty exes."

"That's not who I want to be," I replied sadly. "I want your happiness to be important to me."

She observed me closely before speaking. She smiled. "Now that I can accept. An aspiration rather than a reality."

"And you, Joanie?"

"I don't want to be the woman I've been this past week."

“Okay, okay,” I replied, a little anxious at how this might turn.

“But,” she continued, “I also don’t want to be the woman I was before this past week.”

“You were perfect.”

She rolled her eyes. “Jesus, Kellen, stop it. Look, when I was hanging from my wrists in Alejandro’s apartment with a butt plug the size of a fire hydrant in my ass and my body aching from being slapped, paddled, and clamped, I got to thinking.”

She gave me a saucy grin.

“And a big part of what I realized was that I was playing a role. Had been playing one since I was kid. Maybe it was growing up Catholic. Maybe it was being the only daughter with three brothers. Maybe it was growing boobs before I knew what to do with them or how to deal with the attention they brought. I don’t know. But I’ve never been a real person. I’m a construction. Sugar and spice and everything nice. Except if that is what you aspire to, it can make you an insufferable prig. Self-righteous, indignant. A passive-aggressive bitch.”

“I’ve never thought that,” I insisted.

“Liar.” She said it simply. Not in anger, but simply as an observation. She resumed her self-flagellation. “Superior. Snooty. Stuck-up. Selfish.” She paused. “Did you like that? The writer in me pulling out the alliterations.”

I couldn’t help but chuckle.

“Is that one-sided?” she asked rhetorically. “Yes, of course. I’m sure I have some lovely qualities as well. But here’s the thing. This past week... I don’t know what the fuck it is. Maybe it’s just a start. Maybe I’m going to self-actualize into an unrepentant whore, fucking my way through life, one

sensual experience after another. Or maybe it's just a chance to step back and ask who the hell I really am."

It made sense to me. I said, "We're opposites, aren't we? You often repressed. Me completely in thrall to my own needs. Me, me, me."

"Opposites and yet the same," she replied. "You're selfish and self-indulgent. You think the world revolves around you. But you're free, and it's what attracted me to you. Jesus, Kellen, when we met, I was nineteen, and you... you were already fully-formed, ambitious, exciting, confident."

I laughed. "And you were everything I thought I wanted in a woman. Beautiful, chaste, devoted... to me."

"We deserve each other. Both selfish asses in our own ways," she concluded.

"We were young."

"We were."

"But now, maybe we can learn from each other," I suggested. "I can learn self-control, to care for the opinions of others."

"And I can learn from you, to embrace my needs and wants, my desires and passions."

"I want to make this work. A woman willing to go to the extremes you went to in order to teach me a lesson is a woman I want to keep."

"And a man willing to forgive me after what I did is a man I can't afford to lose."

We looked at each other for a moment. I wanted to sweep her into my arms, but I'd missed the moment. Instead I looked at my watch.

"We need to get a move on if we're going to make our flight."

After our discussion in the hotel, we didn't speak much during the trip. We both had a lot to think about, I guess, and we'd already said all we needed to say.

I knew I should be more mindful, more focused on the woman sitting beside me, but I couldn't help it. I obsessively checked my email in hopes that Alejandro had gotten back to me. He didn't. It didn't help my state of mind that I knew from reading Tanner's email that Alejandro was scheduled to fly up to Boston today as well. It was just dumb luck we weren't on the same plane. But regardless, he'd be meeting with Tanner this evening, perhaps to finalize their deal. Well, as I said, I couldn't blame him. Signing with KDP is what I would do as well.

When we got home at the end of another long day of travel, both Joanie and I collapsed into bed. I was down because I still hadn't heard back from Alejandro, and I knew Joanie was still recovering from her adventures. We cuddled but didn't make love, and as I fell asleep, I noted glumly that we had now hit the two-week mark since we'd had sex... with each other, at least.

For all of our straight-talk in the morning, it still felt like we were drifting apart.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

I slept in the next morning. I just couldn't seem to get myself out of bed. I couldn't bring myself to go into the office. It was clear to me now that Alejandro wasn't going to call. At some point, I'd receive a polite note, handwritten, apologetic, giving his regards to Joanie, and informing me that he regretfully had to decline my business proposition.

My mood darkened. I realized he'd gamed me. He knew I was desperate. Hell, Tanner had probably told him all about the situation. For all I knew, by the time I invited myself to Mexico City, Tanner might have filled him in on *all* the details, including what had happened in the club.

Had Alejandro played me from the start? Was his "gracious" invitation to dine at his place designed to result in the seduction of my wife? God, I'd made it so easy for him. I'd thrown her at him. But he'd been there to catch her. More eager than made sense in retrospect.

I shook my head to chase away those evil thoughts. It didn't work. I imagined them, Alejandro and Tanner, over drinks and dinner comparing notes about fucking my wife. Tanner recounting how he fucked her from behind as she ate a blond stripper's pussy; Alejandro topping him with a detailed description of him fucking her up the ass, bound and gagged on his bed as he whipped her back.

Actually, I couldn't picture it. I was trying to make myself do so, my own form of penance, but I just couldn't. Tanner and Alejandro just seemed like oil and water. They might do business together, but their socializing would be stiff, formal, for both a chore to get through. Oh sure, they'd have their martinis, their steaks, their wine, but the conversation would be about business and the weather. I'd bet on it.... And I was going to have to,

because Alejandro coming around was my only hope. Not just my only hope... but our, Joanie's and my only hope at the future we'd always wanted.

I tried to think about sources of leverage. But I had nothing left to offer. I'd left myself no room for bargaining. I gave Alejandro my best offer up front. I had to. I didn't have time for games.

Games.... Well, we had had time for games, hadn't we? I'd let Alejandro play with Joanie. And yeah, maybe it did help her work out some issues, but I also realized that most normal people would have gone in for a few months of couples therapy rather than turn their wife over to an experienced dominator for penance and punishment.

Still, he'd had fun with her. That much was obvious. And even though I'd phrased it as him doing me a favor, he had to feel some gratitude. Gratitude but not obligation, apparently.

My phone buzzed. I groaned as I looked at the incoming number. Tanner.

"What do you want?" I asked.

He laughed. "You didn't really think you'd get XCOSA?"

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"Al won't give me the details. But I know you were down in Mexico to see him, and yet here he is ready to sign with me."

"If you have it all figured out, then why are you calling me?"

"I have a deal for you, Kelly boy. An offer you can't refuse."

"You gonna blow my brains out if I refuse?"

"Nothing quite so morbid, though the effect on your career would be about the same. You do know Donald is going to fire you next time he sees you, right?"

"And how would you know that?"

“He and I had a nice, long talk about you.”

That could easily be a bluff, though it was likely true. Now that the shock of being confronted had faded, he probably realized he could fire me with impunity. I knew I probably wouldn’t burn Donald with the video if he canned me. Not so much for his sake, but rather for Joanie and for me. He’d probably figured it out by now as well.

“Well, then I guess I need to listen to your offer.”

“Not really an offer. More of a take-or-leave-it deal.”

“Sure Tanner, sure.” No point in arguing it, but there is no such thing as take it or leave it. There is always room to negotiate.

“I want you to sign over your allocations.”

Now this was interesting. Was Tanner going to screw his own firm by executing the distribution allocations outside a TKD-XCOSA partnership?

“To you? Or to TKD?”

“None of your business, now, is it? They’re worthless to you now anyway. You have to realize that.”

“As long as they have value to you, they’re not worthless to me.”

“Kellen, you’re being obtuse. You’re a loser, but you’re not dumb.”

I laughed. “Thanks Tanner, I feel the same way about you.”

“Do you want me to get to the point, or what?”

I sighed. “Yeah, could you?”

“Point is, I want your allocations, and I want to give you a job.”

“A job?”

“Oh, don’t get too excited. I mean, after your flameout at Marston, you need to start again from the bottom. But I have a junior analyst slot open. I’ll need you to sign a three-year contract and a non-compete.”

I laughed.

“Health insurance, a paycheck, you could... you will be doing a lot worse soon if you don’t agree.”

“I think I’ll try my luck on my own,” I replied.

“There’s more, Kellen. Just shut up and listen.”

I bit my tongue. He was jazzed about something. Best to try to figure it out.

“That’s better,” he replied. “I’ll also cover whatever you’ve laid out in your failed trip to Mexico....” He paused, dragging it out. “And, I’ll let you keep twenty percent of the action from your allocations.”

Now *that* was interesting. Depending on how the TKD-XCOSA deal was structured, that twenty percent would be worth between \$360,000-\$580,000. Amortized over a three year deal, plus a junior analyst’s base.... at least we’d be able to keep the house, the cars, a semblance of a normal life. Interesting and oddly generous for Tanner.

There was a certain logic to it. It headed off the possibility of Briand reappearing in the mix. And if Alejandro had insisted on an opt-out clause, it hedged against that risk as well. Still....

“And that’s it?” I asked.

He chuckled.

Uh oh, here it comes.

“Well, now, Kelly, nothing is quite that simple in life, is it?”

“Spit it out.”

“I want your wife as my personal whore.”

I laughed. “God, Tanner, you’re fucked up.”

“Don’t kid yourself, Kel, she’s a bitch in heat. She’s going to be out fucking someone anyway. Might as well get your career back out of it.”

“Fuck off.”

“You should at least ask her. After that performance in the strip club, I bet she’d love the opportunity to work it again for a real man.”

“And that’s you?” I snarked.

“Me and some of my closest friends. Your new colleagues actually. I think it’ll be a good experience for you to have to work every day with a bunch of guys who pulled a train on your wife. I know it’ll make them more eager to welcome a loser like you onboard. Of course, we’ll need regular goodwill refreshers from her.”

I laughed. “I will give you this, Tanner. You may be an asshole, but you have an active imagination.”

He didn’t reply right away, though I could hear him breathing on the other end of the line. It was weirdly effective.

“Still there?” I asked.

“Told you, Kel, take it or leave it. Tonight, celebrating at dinner with Al, then after we have a suite at the Westin. I have a whore on call in case you don’t show. 10:00pm. And dress her sexy. We’re gonna want a little show before we start painting her white.”

He hung up. Fucking asshole.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Now, look, I wasn't really considering it. Not really. And if I had just been up to me, that would have been the end of it. But it wasn't just up to me. Not anymore. Not since I'd co-opted Joanie's efforts to teach me a lesson and dragged her into my business woes. She had skin in the game, quite literally, and I needed to involve her in the decision.

Except, it shouldn't have been an *issue*. Even as I worked myself up to talking to Joanie rather than rejecting Tanner's offer out of hand, I knew I had an ulterior motive. I couldn't *ask* Joanie to do this. But, what if she *offered*? It surely wasn't up to me to *forbid* her from doing it.

I found her sitting in the kitchen, drinking her morning coffee out of her absurd mug. I just stared at her. I couldn't quite think of how to broach my topic of my conversation with Tanner. She looked up at me.

"You okay, Kel? You look a little... weird."

"More weird than usual?"

My lame attempt at a joke fell flat.

"Do you have something to tell me?"

"It's nothing, really."

She rolled her eyes. "Get on with it."

"Well, it's like this..."

I explained the situation and the offer. Joanie didn't seem surprised. Or angry. Or, well, anything. She regarded me blankly. It reminded me that she had a rare talent at suppressing her emotions. She'd make an excellent poker player, but it was a problem in a spouse. It was that, in part, that had allowed me to ignore her and take her for granted for so long. Not that I was blaming her for my conduct this past week, but, that said, I realized now

that she'd only gone zero to sixty so quickly because she'd spent so long trying to pretend everything was okay.

"Well?" I asked.

"Well, what, Kel? I mean, you want me to do this, right? Be with those *men*," she amplified.

I shook my head. "No, no. I just, you know, felt like you should know."

She laughed. "Bullshit."

"Joanie –"

"Here's your thinking," she began. "You need a new start. The payoff from the allocations gives you a nest egg. Regardless of what job they actually give you at TKD, you know you'll impress their execs. They'll move you up. You'll eat Tanner's lunch. And as for me? Well, I've done worse this past week haven't I? And this is just one night. Except...."

She hesitated, thinking. I began to speak, but she raised her palm to silence me.

"Except," she continued, "I can't see you being willing to have me continue as Tanner's plaything. So you have an angle on that."

I sighed.

"Tell me," she insisted.

"Once the contracts are signed that part of the deal isn't enforceable. There is no way he can force you do anything with him, or anyone else. The three year contract binds him as well as me."

She nodded. "Makes sense. \$300,000. A new job in the same field. And all you have to do is let a bunch of guys fuck your wife for one night."

I shook my head. "I don't want you to do it."

"No, Kellen, you don't want to *ask me* to do it. But the cost-benefit calculation argues for accepting the offer."

“Joanie, I...”

I trailed off. I didn’t know what to say. She was right. The alternative was bleak. I was a flame out, in a field where a new batch of young, hungry assholes gets minted every fucking year. Up or out. And right now, I was hanging on by my fingertips.

I’d already whored her out. Three separate times. I’d thought of her fucking Donald’s big prick on his pool table. Of her riding Tanner in the strip club. Of her, on her knees, Alejandro’s come pooled in her mouth, waiting for his permission to swallow. And what of tonight? Have a few drinks. Let a half-dozen assholes try to perform in public, half of them probably not even getting it up. A couple of hours, three, then a shower, a good night sleep, and it would all be in the past.

I knew it was wrong. I should never have even mentioned it. And now that it was out there, I knew I should squash it. But I couldn’t speak, my silence louder than words.

“Okay, Kellen, I’ll think about it.”

“No Joanie, I... don’t...”

“Fuck off, Kellen,” she snarled. “I can’t stand looking at you right now.”

“I —“

“Seriously, shut up. Go! Do whatever the fuck you need to do to line it up. I need some time to myself. If I decide to do it, I’ll meet you at the bar at the Westin at 9:45.”

“I—”

But this time she didn’t interrupt me. She just rose and walked away.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Cost and benefit analysis. It's how rational people make decisions, right? And she'd nailed the fucking CBA. You can't put a price on pride or virtue or decency. Or can you? \$100,000 an hour overcomes a lot of scruples.

I took my computer and decamped to downtown. I found a small, dive bar, tucked into an alley. They looked at me like I was from Mars. Yuppie with a MacBook Pro and a thousand dollar suit ordering three dollar whiskies and typing away like a maniac.

I drafted the contract language, for the job, the non-compete, the allocations transfer. I made sure the terms were favorable. Guaranteed salary. Pay-or-play on the allocations. I sweetened his side on the upside to make that palatable. He'd said the deal was take it or leave it, but face to face with Joanie, his buds clamoring for him to close the deal, I knew he'd accept my terms, if Joanie showed.

If Joanie showed....

I ducked into a Kinkos and printed out my documents. Then on to the Westin. I found a seat in the back of the bar with a view of the door.

I sent a text to Tanner, just in case.

[Kellen]: What room?

[Tanner]: 2716. You on your way?

[Kellen]: Guess you'll just have to wait to find out.

[Tanner]: Tell her to get her asshole ready. That's where I'm going first.

I shut off my phone. I didn't need it anymore. Everything from now on was going to be face to face.

Though I was tempted to gulp it, I nursed my drink. If shit went down, I'd need to keep my wits to keep Joanie safe. If I was going to be a pimp, I'd at least be a good one.

I kept a close eye on the door, watching for my wife. But still, I was startled when I saw her. Fuck, she looked good. She was in her little black dress and fishnet stockings. Stiletto heels. All tits and ass and topped with her covergirl face, framed by her long, silky hair. The epitome of a high-class call girl, which I guess is what I had turned her into.

Heads turned to follow her as she walked into the bar. I looked behind me at the emergency exit. I was tempted to flee, unsure whether I could face her, thinking in part that if I disappeared, she too would leave. Nothing would happen, but it was a coward's way out.

No more games. Whatever happened would happen together, openly and unambiguously.

I stepped out of the shadows and gave her a small wave, relishing the looks of jealousy and anger from the men in the room as she saw her join me. If only they knew what we had planned.

"You look amazing," I gushed.

"Your friends are paying a lot for me."

"They're not my friends."

She shrugged. "So, the party is still on?"

"Joanie, we... you don't need to do this."

"Are you saying you don't want me to?"

"I don't.... I'm not the boss of you."

Joanie's face twisted into a mask of disappointment at my pathetic dodge. *Yes or no, Kellen. It isn't that hard.* Yet, it was.

"Fine, then let's do it. You have the room number?"

"Joanie –"

"Kellen, fucking shit or get off the pot. You have a room number?"

"2716," I groaned.

"Fine. You going to wait for me down here, or do you want to watch?"

"I want to keep you safe."

She snorted. "Thanks for the concern, Kellen, but I can handle Tanner and his pasty-ass buddies. They want my ass, not my skin."

"No, we're in this together."

She hesitated, then nodded. "Okay. You've seen me fuck three other guys, so I know it doesn't bother you."

"It does bother me."

She laughed, darkly. "Let's go."

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

We approached the door. There was music, loud chatter from inside. I hesitated. Joanie shook her head and rapped on the door.

“Joanie, I love you,” I exclaimed suddenly.

She turned toward me, surprise written on her face.

Then the door opened. Tanner, drunk, dissolute, in his blue suit and crooked tie. He whistled loudly. I was aware that the chatter from inside had died down to nothing, just a low bass beat rumbling in the background.

He took Joanie by the elbow and led her inside. There were six men in the room. Overgrown frat boys. Wrinkled suits, faces bloated with drink and self-importance. Young men who’d gotten too rich, too soon.

“I told you she was a grade-A piece of ass.”

Murmured assent, wide eyes, open-mouthed excitement. I followed them in, and then I saw him, Alejandro, sitting in a corner alone, cupping a snifter of brandy, observing. I felt a surge of anger. It was his fault. Had he signed with me, we wouldn’t be here, at Tanner’s mercy.

Tanner and Joanie stood face to face.

“I knew you wouldn’t be able to stay away, baby,” he said. “I knew you’d want more after I fucked you.”

She didn’t deny it, and that was enough to make Tanner’s status rise in the eyes of the other TKD guys. He’d surely been bragging about nailing my wife, and now her silence acknowledged it.

“But, that was just a start,” he continued. “Now we get to finish the game.”

Joanie swallowed loudly and then gave him a quick nod.

“You’re going to give us whatever we want, right?”

She shot me a quick glance. I was paralyzed. She turned back to him and gave him another nod.

“Say it,” he ordered.

“Yes,” she replied in a barely audible whisper.

“Louder.”

Another rapid look in my direction.

“Yes,” she replied firmly. “Whatever you want.”

“Your mouth?”

“Yes.”

“Your cunt?”

“Yes.”

“Your ass?”

She nodded.

“Say it.”

“Yes. You can fuck my ass if you want.”

Tanner smiled triumphantly as his buddies whooped it up.

“Lose the dress, whore,” he ordered.

I expected her to look at me again, but she didn't. She'd written me off. It was just her and the men in the room.

No hesitation, but a disconcerting blankness on her face. She eased the straps off her shoulder and shimmied sexily out of the dress. More whistles. She'd really gone all out. She was devastating in skimpy, black lace, her breasts overflowing from her demi-cup bra, tiny thong panties, and a garter belt holding up her fishnets.

I looked over at Alejandro and was surprised to see that he was looking at me, his expression at once blank and yet that very blankness seemed to convey an unmistakable message. And I got it, then, really got it. I'm not sure why, but it hit me like a thunderbolt.

Tanner was telling Joanie how he was going to come all over her face. His hand was wedged into her bra, fondling her tit.

“Get the fuck off my wife,” I hissed.

He turned toward me, smirking, his hand still on her breast.

“Don’t be dumb, Kellen, this is the best offer you’re going to get.”

I took an aggressive step toward him. He flinched and stepped away from Joanie. He turned toward her.

“He’s a loser baby. You’ll be selling it for a lot less if you stay with him.”

She looked over at me, her face still blank. And then, suddenly, a smile, growing, brightening. She turned back toward Tanner.

“Probably. But I’ll take that chance.”

I reached down and picked up her dress and pressed my hand against her lower back.

“Come on, honey, let’s go.”

I led her from the room. As she reached the door, Tanner called after me. “I’ll have her yet. She’s a whore, Kellen, a whore. And you’re a loser.”

I looked at Joanie. We couldn’t help it. We both began to giggle, and continued to do so as we heard the door close behind us.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

She pulled her dress back on. In the elevator, I pressed 11. She raised an eyebrow at me.

“Another group of men you want me to fuck?”

I grinned. “Just one.”

I walked her into the room I’d reserved, then pulled her into an embrace.

“Joanie, I am so, so sorry. For tonight. For everything. I –“

She put a finger to my lips. “Shh, Kel, shh. It’s okay.”

“You’re not angry?”

She laughed. “I’m fucking furious. And we have a lot of work in front of us. But not tonight. Tonight, I’m here to get fucked.”

I gasped. Where had my innocent Catholic girl gone?

“You said you had a man for me?” she added.

I smiled. “I do.”

I reached down and scooped her into my arms. I carried her over to the bed and dropped her onto the mattress, harder than I expected.

“Shit, sorry,” I gasped.

She looked up at me. “I’m not going to break.”

“Yeah?”

“Yeah,” she replied. “You just had to ask.”

“Really?”

She hesitated. “I don’t know about then. But I know now.”

I smiled and joined her on the bed. “I don’t want to break you.”

I kissed her, gently, then more passionately.

“Not tonight,” I added.

I slowly stripped her. I'd dimmed the lights, but left enough so that I could see and really admire her lingerie and her body. I worshipped every inch of her. Those big, firm, breasts, her exquisitely sensitive nipples. I massaged her flat belly and slowly peeled her stockings off her toned legs. I licked up her inner thighs, and then gently began kissing her through her sheer panties. When I finally pulled them down, I inhaled deeply of her excitement. I feasted at her gorgeous, shaved snatch. I sucked her clit into my mouth, my tongue circling her swollen bud until she came in a torrent of soft moans and a whole body shiver.

Naked now myself, I slipped up between her legs. As I rubbed my cockhead against her drenched pussy, she put a hand on my chest and stopped me. I pulled back and nodded. She was right. I didn't deserve that, not yet. I hadn't made things up to her yet.

But I was wrong. Instead, she flipped onto her stomach and rose up on her hands and knees. She flipped her hair from her eyes and looked back at me over her shoulder.

"Go ahead."

I glanced down at her perfect ass, swaying gently in anticipation, at her fingers spreading her wet twat.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

We'd never done it doggy style. Joanie had told me it was demeaning once, early on, and I hadn't asked again. I was still reticent. Was this some sort of weird test? And then I realized that no, it wasn't. She had changed. Become more open through her experiences.

I entered her slowly from behind. She moaned softly. I encouraged her, with soft words, and gentle caresses. But my excitement built. I began thrusting harder. I reached around and cupped her swaying breasts. She'd

gone quiet, but I was too far gone to care. And then, suddenly, she shuddered again, her pussy kneading my cock. She looked back at me, eyes glassy, smiling happily. I came, hard, a week of frustration and anguish suddenly evaporating as I emptied myself in my beautiful, amazing wife.

We lay side-by-side, exhausted.

“Would you really have let yourself be gangbanged?” I asked.

“I don’t know. Maybe? I’m finding I like all of this more than I ever thought I would or could.”

“But that still makes you feel guilty?”

“Yeah,” she replied. “Not sure that ever goes away. Not sure I’d want it to.”

I nodded. I understood her worries. I had been very close to doing things I would regret forever.

She broke the silence: “Why did you stop it?”

“I don’t know, Joanie. I really don’t. I’d like to think it was my moral compass belatedly kicking in, but if I really saw a clear path to get what I wanted.... I don’t know. How much does that make you hate me?”

She shook her head. “It doesn’t. Because to tell you the truth, I don’t really know how I feel about any of this myself. We’re just going to need to work on this, I think.”

“I need you to keep me honest, babe. I have trouble doing it on my own.”

“And I need you to keep me a little off-balance, otherwise, I fall back onto how I think I should act. I think I’d be happier with a little more of your lunacy in my life.”

We didn't resolve anything that night. Or for long thereafter. It was a process. But what we found was that we could help each other be happier, saner, and even more successful if we each took more cues from the other.

EPILOGUE

In a case of all's well that ends well, I ended up signing a deal with Alejandro after all. Tanner overplayed his hand, tried to squeeze Alejandro too much, and I got the contract. Maybe my negotiating skill had won the day, or maybe his memories of his time with Joanie ultimately swayed him to decide to work with me. Or maybe I won him over that night in the hotel room, when he saw me finally stand up for my wife.

I can't be sure, which is why as with everything else, I have mixed feelings about what happened that week. I'd acted awfully, but had gotten much of what I wanted, a new start in business, a new passion in the bedroom. It was almost enough to encourage me in my sociopathic tendencies. And yet, I knew also how close I'd come to destroying everything I cared out.

I know Joanie still struggles with the guilt of what she did as well. Provoked or not, it was a shock to her own sensibilities that she had that inside her. On the positive side, she turned to writing as a way to explore her feelings, and is now finishing up a novel that builds on the events of the week.

Of course, there are no free lunches in life. As I promised Alejandro, I was trying a new path, building rather than destroying or just skimming off the top. A white knight capital fund. We seek out good ideas that just need a little more time, a few more connections, and try to make them work. We offer generous terms and encourage them to keep workers on their payroll. We're investing for the long-term.

It is long hours. Too long, too often.

I came home one night, way too late. My dinner was still on the kitchen table, cold and congealed, looking as forlorn as the glass of wine Joanie had poured for me and left as a testament to my distraction. I thought she was asleep, so I was surprised to hear footsteps coming down the stairs.

“Whoa,” I said in surprise.

Instead of PJs and slippers, she’d donned the black dress and stockings from that night at the Westin.

“Is that for me?” I asked playfully.

She looked down at her outfit as if surprised to see what she was wearing. When she looked back up and me, she had a cryptic smile on her face.

“Sorry, honey, I have a date.”

I groaned. “I know I’ve been taking you for granted –“

She cut me off, “Then you know this is my way of reminding you.”

“You don’t need to do this.”

She continued down the stairs and picked up her handbag.

“It seems like I do. And anyway... I want to.”

I nodded. “Okay. I guess I deserve it.”

I had to admit, I had mixed feelings. I didn’t want my wife to have sex with another man... yet again. Still, I had been benefitting from her new openness in bed for months. We were still pretty vanilla, but definitely with some sprinkles and the occasional cherry on top.

“Anyone I know?”

“Actually,” she smirked. “Yes.”

“Oh.”

Well that sucked. Other than Alejandro, I didn’t have any contact with the other men she’d been with, which I considered a blessing.

The doorbell rang. “Oooh, right on time.”

I wasn't surprised. Most men were smart enough, or maybe horny enough, not to keep Joanie waiting.

"Okay, well, have fun," I said, trying and failing to conceal my misery.

I started toward the kitchen and the first of what I planned to be several beers.

"Don't you want to meet my date?"

I stopped. No, I really didn't want to have to shake hands with the man who would be teaching me a lesson by fucking my wife.

"I think I don't have a choice."

I followed her to the door. She opened it slowly. And to my shock, and I admit delight, in walked a petite, very pretty, blonde in a black and white striped party dress. Amber. The stripper who'd seduced Joanie in the club.

She entered and pressed herself against my wife, giving her a wet kiss.

"Hey beautiful. Ready to have some fun?" Amber asked.

"Uh, why don't you both stay here?" I suggested hopefully. "We could all have fun."

Amber looked from me to Joanie, and then laughed. "Men are so funny. You can barely satisfy one woman, and you're always trying to get two at the same time."

Joanie smirked in pleasure.

Amber leaned in toward me. "Don't worry. I won't ruin her." A pause. A wicked smile. "Well, maybe a little."

She took my wife by the hand and pulled her out the door.

"Don't wait up," Joanie called over her shoulder.

I laughed. *Of course*, I was going to wait up. This was one date that I couldn't wait to hear recounted in lurid, explicit, graphic detail.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

I am your typical family man with a wife and kids and an overactive imagination. I am a longtime reader and author of erotic fiction. I write in genres that I find exciting and arousing. Most of my stories are in the naughty wife, wife-watching genre, though occasionally I venture into other subject matter.

Reader feedback is what keeps me going. Please feel free to contact me at ben.boswell.author@gmail.com or visit my blog at benboswell.blogspot.com. You can follow me on Twitter @BenBoswellAut.

I have written five other pieces of longer-form fictions.

Two Sides of Terri

Bill has just about the perfect life. Good paying job. Lovely home. Perfect children. And most of all, he has his wife Terri--smart, funny, great with the kids. Thing is, she's a good girl trapped in a bad girl's body. Blonde, busty, and devastatingly beautiful, she makes him want to do dirty things--things you don't admit to wanting from the girl-next-door.

Or so he thought.

It starts with a revelation about Chucky, a past boyfriend, and everything he thought he knew about his sweet wife unravels. He becomes obsessed with learning more about this other side of Terri--and everything he learns points back to Chucky, a man she couldn't say no to. Does he dare invite her past back into their present? And if he did, would she now be able to say no?

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Two-Sides-Terri-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00HSCMZTW>

Whatever it Takes

Daniel and Kris are as white bread as they come. Together since junior high, they have two kids, a house in the suburbs, and no excitements in their lives. Things change when Kris' little sister Jessi moves in. Jessi is everything Kris isn't, reckless, promiscuous, and mixed up with very bad people. As their two orbits intersect, Daniel and Kris get dragged into Jessi's world of drug dealers, strip clubs, and prostitution. Can they survive the dangers? And even if they do, will their marriage?

Fueled by their love for each other, and drawing on a strength and resourcefulness they never realized they had, Daniel and Kris are desperate to recover their old lives. To do so, they will do whatever it takes!

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Whatever-It-Takes-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00KABTO42>

Honeymoon Hazards

After being together for seven years, John and Claire marry and jet off to beautiful Hawaii for their honeymoon. It is a paradise of hard bodies in tiny bikinis, mixed drinks consumed in the hot sun, and a resort built for private encounters.

But when John is struck down with a stomach flu, he can do nothing but sit on his balcony and watch others have fun. Discovering his inner voyeur, he finds that spying on a resort full of sexy and adventurous guests is an enjoyable distraction.

That is, until he spots his new bride flirting with an oh-so-handsome stranger by the pool. Things really heat up when Claire disappears from view, and he can't find the stranger, either. As John's imagination runs wild, the line between fantasy and lust blurs until he can no longer tell where his worst fears end and his fondest desires begin.

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Honeymoon-Hazards-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00N84NIRM>

The Surrogate Master

Would you trust a stranger you met online to repair your marriage? Would you be comfortable with him knowing your wife's most intimate secrets? Would you let him come into your home, your bedroom?

When his wife Rachel returns to work after being a stay-at-home mom for five years, Max knows they will have to make some adjustments. What he hasn't counted on is Rachel's new boss. Handsome, aggressive, and domineering, he awakens long dormant desires within Rachel.

As Max watches, helpless, the transformation in his wife, he has to deal with his own insecurities and fears. As their marriage faces its ultimate challenge, both Rachel and Max have to confront their pasts, their fears, and their fantasies... but they aren't alone.

They meet a stranger online, a man who has an uncanny ability to see both Max and Rachel for who they really are. But what is his game? Is he just an unconventional marriage therapist? Or does he represent an even greater danger than they can even imagine?

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Surrogate-Master-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00P3FDIE2>

Dark Tide: An Interracial Adventure on the High Seas

Jeremy should be focused on enjoying a luxury cruise with his beautiful, blond wife Jennifer. But all he can think about is her with Captain Reg Wallace. Reg is built like an NFL wide receiver, and very, very black. Jeremy can't shake the image of this powerful, black man between his wife's creamy, white thighs.

With everything going right in his life, is Jeremy willing to risk it all to indulge his fantasy of seeing his wife with a gorgeous black man? And how will he react when he finds she is all too willing to make his fantasy come true?

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Dark-Tide-Interracial-Adventure-High-ebook/dp/B00U8AV05Q/>

Short Stories

There are a number of short stories that I've written over the years that I am particularly fond of. I am in the process of editing and preparing them for publication. The first four are out.

Cuckolding Shorts

Volume 1: The Cottage

Rich has always had fond memories of his parents' old lake cottage. When they decide to sell it, he invites some old friends to join him and his wife Becky for a weekend of beer and nostalgia. But Rich's plans are upset by the presence of Robby, who is boorish, aggressive, and makes no secret of his lust for Becky.

When Robby badgers Rich into a foolish bet, he learns that his wife is willing to go to any lengths to make sure he pays his debts.

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Cottage-Cuckolding-Shorts-Book-ebook/dp/B00NY1CQAE>

Volume 2: Déjà Vu x

Bill and Jessie are celebrating their tenth anniversary when they run into Bill's college roommate. Chad is so handsome and charming that Jessie knows she needs to have him. Saying no should be easy for Bill, but he and Chad have a long and twisted past and this is not the first time Bill has had to deal with Chad's intoxicating effect on even the most sober-minded of women.

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Deja-Vu-Cuckolding-Shorts-Book-ebook/dp/B00QE2B1ZG>

Volume 3: Last Fling

Married couple Dave and Leslie have decided it's time to have kids. They know it is a life changing decision. No more sleeping in late, no more spontaneous hiking trips, no cozy vacations alone. And worst of all, no more day long sessions in bed, naked, making love and eating take out. So to bid farewell to their old life they decide on a "last fling" in Las Vegas.

Although they agree that "what happens in Vegas, stays in Vegas," they find it isn't easy to remain detached and easy going when things begin to get hot and heavy. Dave, in particular, begins to have second thoughts when he realizes that Leslie's idea of a last fling may be more lusty and intense than he ever imagined.

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Last-Fling-Cuckolding-Shorts-Book-ebook/dp/B00WTR42L0/>

May/December Romances

Volume 1: Midlife Glitch

Dan is fifty-four, married, semi-retired, and an empty nester. Ashley is eighteen, blond, beautiful and the daughter of Dan's best friend. She's in town pursuing an internship. They have nothing in common except a sudden, burning attraction that risks destroying everything around them if they give in to temptation.

When a family emergency sends Dan's wife half-way across the country, he is left to grapple with his lust for his inappropriately young

houseguest. But Ashley has her own needs and desires, and in the end, attraction can't always be contained.

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Midlife-Glitch-December-Romances-Book-ebook/dp/B00STZT9KA/>

For more information on future projects, visit
<http://www.benboswell.com>